Whence Came I: On Oxxxymiron and Persona in the Digital Age

by

Aleksandra Marciniak

A dissertation submitted in partial fulfillment
of the requirements for the degree of
Doctor of Philosophy
(Slavic Languages and Literatures)
in the University of Michigan
2025

Doctoral Committee:

Professor Benjamin Paloff, Chair
Assistant Professor Alena Aniskiewicz, Michigan State University
Associate Professor Herbert Eagle
Professor Mikhail Krutikov

Aleksandra Marciniak

aleksma@umich.edu

ORCID iD: 0000-0002-8472-1491

© Aleksandra Marciniak 2025

Dedication

To my grandmother, born ten months after the Nazi invasion of Poland, who was a testament to the phrase “life goes on.” And for my son, who would have made her squeal with joy.

Acknowledgments

Without the support and encouragement of Professor Benjamin Paloff, this dissertation would not be possible. As my doctoral advisor, he treated my ideas with respect and never questioned their place in the field. His genuine interest in my research motivated me to write through complex and uncertain periods. Above all, he taught me to take ownership by never asking for permission and finding my own way; this advice has guided me in writing and in life. I am forever grateful.

To Professor Herb Eagle for his compassion, understanding, and ability to see the person in front of him without fail: thank you. His empathy as an instructor and mentor is inspiring. I would also like to thank Professor Misha Krutikov for dispelling my preconceptions of "The Dissertation" and for his assistance with the complex and nuanced translations, which are central to my analysis. I am indebted to Professor Alena Aniskiewicz for paving the way. She has been extremely generous with her time and resources, both as a colleague and a mentor. I aspire to be as captivating a writer and researcher as she is. A collective thank you to all my colleagues and friends in the Department of Slavic Languages and Literatures at the University of Michigan, whose company and encouragement immeasurably enriched my doctoral experience.

I would like to mention my undergraduate mentor, Professor Richard Robin, for guiding me through my Russian language studies and beyond. His enthusiasm and passion were the driving forces behind my decision to declare a Russian major and pursue a doctorate at the University of Michigan many years ago. Спасибо Вам огромное!

Additionally, my graduate studies were made possible by grants and fellowships from the following sources: the Rackham Graduate School, the Center for Emerging Democracies, the Weiser Center for Europe and Eurasia, the Copernicus Program for Polish Studies, the Foreign Language and Area Studies Program, and the Sweetland Center for Writing. Special recognition is due to Marysia Ostafin, who included me in events and activities through pre-candidacy and beyond: dziękuję bardzo. Thank you also to my colleagues on the Rackham Professional Development and Engagement team for your encouragement, support, and grace. Thank you to the Academic Writing Group for providing the space and accountability to write in the final stretches, and for the camaraderie. My gratitude also goes to my students for sharing their stories, thoughts, and optimism. Their outlooks and updates fueled me.

Given that this is my dissertation, I would be remiss not to acknowledge *myself*. I have impeccable discernment when it comes to choosing friends, without whom I would not have remained focused and in good spirits. So, thank you to me for surrounding myself with the following key figures: Grace, Misha, and Sara, the true gifts of my tenure in the Department of Slavic Languages and Literatures. Our collective ability to champion one another, no matter the circumstance, is a force to be reckoned with. I love the friendships we have built. Thank you to McKenna and Gabi for modeling perseverance and checking in on me. To Gina, Izzy, Gretchen, and Rebecca, my lifelines for all these years, for helping me to see academic milestones through a different lens and for celebrating them along with me. Thank you to Aristea and Carina, my fellow Slavic moms, for their immense support and understanding. And a collective thank you to our little ones for filling our lives with perspective and joy. Watching them all grow and develop distinct personalities has been so special; what a thing to witness.

I would like to end by thanking my family. Their words of motivation and displays of pride for my accomplishments mean the world to me. To my parents and siblings, thank you for caring enough to discuss my achievements with others, but not so invested as to inquire about details or deadlines. It's "Dr. Ola" from now on. My gratitude also goes out to my in-laws for their encouragement and support along the way. And lastly, to my most trusted and supportive confidant, my first and last reader, my husband, Derek. Thank you for always listening and co-managing our shared life, especially during the final stages of dissertation writing. Only you know what this took

Table of Contents

Dedication ii

Acknowledgments iii

List of Figures viii

Note on Translation xi

Abstract xii

Chapter 1: On Man as Maker 1

1.1 On Persona, Cultural Myth, and New Media in Russian Studies Scholarship 3

1.2 On Persona Studies in the Digital Age 13

1.3 On Persona Research in Music and Cultural Studies 25

1.4 On the Life and Times of Miron "Oxxxymiron" Fyodorov 32

1.4.1 On Miron Yanovich Fyodorov: Emigration, Coming of Age, and Education 35

1.4.2 A Limited Career Trajectory, from MC MiF to CEO 40

Chapter 2: On a Life of Conflict in the Battle Rap Arena 50

2.1 On the Dozens as a Precursor to Battle Rap 53

2.2 On Battle Rap's Beginnings in the Russian Context 61

2.3 On the Feigned Intimacy of the Versus Battle Arena 65

2.4 On Gimmicks and Crowd Work in Battle Performances 68

2.5 On the Insult of Ethnicity: Jewishness in the Battle Rap Arena 74

2.6 On the Necessity and Failure of Universal Tropes in the Battle Rap Arena 82

2.7 On Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS: A Clash of Archetypes that Oxxxymiron Loses 83

2.7.1 On Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS, Round One 84

2.7.2 On Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS, Round Two *89*

2.7.3 On Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS, Round Three *93*

Chapter 3: On "Death" and "Resurrection" on Oxxxymiron's Terms 97

3.1 On *Gorgorod:* Format, Themes, and Meaning 100

3.1.1 On the Album's Reception and Ensuing Dialogues *104*

3.2 On "Who Killed Mark" and Deconstructing Persona 108

3.2.1 On Friends, Foes, and Feuds *108*

3.2.2 On Bearing it All: Recounting the Pain of Silence *113*

3.2.3 On Laying it All Bare: Speaking About the Past *122*

3.2.4 On Resurrection: Introducing a New Oxxxymiron *130*

Chapter 4: On the Afterlife of a Public Figure 134

4.1 On Oxxxymiron, the Free Speech Activist 135

4.2 On Beauty, Ugliness, and the Time of Troubles: Political Themes in New Releases 140

4.3 On Oxxxymiron, the Anti-War Activist 146

4.4 On "The Creative Method": The Podcast that Tackles Person and Persona 154

4.4.1 On Personal and Impersonal Relationships with Miron Fyodorov a.k.a. Oxxxymiron *160*

Conclusion: On Man's Digital Permanence 168

Afterword: On the Researcher's Intention 171

Bibliography 173

List of Figures

Figure 1: An image of Peter Steiner's 1993 *New Yorker* cartoon. 13

Figure 2: A chart defining key features of past and current Web versions..... 17

Figure 3: Oxxxymiron's X (Twitter) post about his mental health. He refers to being diagnosed as "manic depressive" in the comments section..... 38

Figure 4: An opening still frame from the “I’m a Hater” video. 43

Figure 5: An opening still frame from the “I’m a Hater” video. 43

Figure 6: Oxxxymiron showing his "Imperivm" knuckle tattoos. 47

Figure 7: Pins depicting Oxxxymiron's knuckle tattoos. Sold by his official store "Oxxxyshop."..... 47

Figure 8: A promotional poster for the Oxxxymiron v. Dizaster battle at World Domination VII. 50

Figure 9: Three successive still images from the Oxxxymiron v. Dizaster battle trailer..... 51

Figure 10: An image of Alexander "Restorator" Timartsev. 63

Figure 11: An image of the 1703 bar, with a mural of Peter I on the facade..... 68

Figure 12: Oxxxymiron battling against Johnyboy while wearing a neck bandage. 72

Figure 13: Oxxxymiron battling against Johnyboy, after he removed the neck bandage..... 72

Figure 14: The "Wandering Jew" album cover..... 75

Figure 15: The promotional image for Oxxxymiron's 2017 "Imperivm" tour, depicting him in profile. 78

Figure 16: Another profile image used for the single "Я знаю, что ты делал прошлым летом" (I know what you did last summer), 2023. 78

Figure 17: Slava KPSS gesturing at Dan Cheney 90

Figure 18: Slava KPSS gesturing at Dan Cheney (II)..... 90

Figure 19: Slava KPSS shouting "Personalities!' and gesturing in the air. 91

Figure 20: An example of a "When's the Album (Coming Out)" banner hanging in St. Petersburg. 97

Figure 21: The cover frame for the "Who Killed Mark? video. 99

Figure 22: The cover of Gorgorod (2015) depicts a version of Bruegel's 16th-century painting of the Tower of Babel. 100

Figure 23: A still of Morgenshtern from his vDud apperance. 105

Figure 24: Chumakov slapping Oxxxymiron. This footage was released in the "Who Killed Mark?" video..... 114

Figure 25: The image that ends Part I of "Who Killed Mark?" 121

Figure 26: The image that begins Part II of "Who Killed Mark?"..... 121

Figure 27: The final image of Part II of "Who Killed Mark?" (8:30)..... 130

Figure 28: The first image of Part III of "Who Killed Mark?" (8:35). 130

Figure 29: Oxxxymiron posing the last question "Who killed Mark?"(9:44-9:46) 132

Figure 30: The video's closing shot, panning away from Oxxxymiron (9:46-9:48)..... 132

Figure 31: The cover image to Oxxxymiron's 2024 single "Мир Горит" ("The World is Burning"). It is taken from the official announcement of his designation as a "wanted" individual by the Russian Federation, following his previous designation as a foreign agent. .. 134

Figure 32: An image of Yegor Zhukov in his bedroom (02:24). 137

Figure 33: Fyodorov reading at the beginning of the performance in a replica of Zhukov's room. 138

Figure 34: Fyodorov reading at the end of the performance in front of a jail cell (1:54:00)..... 138

Figure 35: The cover art for "Beauty and Ugliness," painted by Boris Grebenshchikov. 140

Figure 36: Oxxxymiron standing on the banks of the Neva River in the "Oida" video. It is at this moment (2:07-2:08) that he addresses and gestures to the prosecutor's office. 145

Figure 37: Oxxxymiron's knuckle tattoos pictured in September 2022. 146

Figure 38: A poster advertising Oxxxymiron's 2023 world tour. 151

Figure 39: A still image of Oxxxymiron in character, played in videos during his World Tour. 152

Figure 40: The cover art for *The Creative Method* season on the *Bandit's Daughter* podcast. 160

Note on Translation

All translations from Russian to English are my own. Additionally, I use the Library of Congress (LoC) transliteration table for Russian words transliterated into English (2012 version). The exceptions to this are first, last, and stage names whose common spellings do not follow LoC guidelines, such as "Alexander Pushkin."

Abstract

This dissertation conceptualizes public persona in the digital world through the life and works of Russian rapper Miron Yanovich "Oxxxymiron" Fyodorov. It establishes that contemporary persona is an intercommunication of performance, social interaction, and *mediatization,* or the process of crafting public identities specifically for new media spaces. While individuals exert personal control in shaping their personas, I argue that self-presentation is a social activity. Personas are thus negotiated through and across public reception and engagement on traditional and new media platforms. Critical to my argument is how individuals use forms of "silence," such as selective interviewing and retreats from public life, to navigate the self-presentation of their personas.

The presented research is in the form of an extended case study, deconstructing and reconstructing prominent subsets of the Oxxxymiron persona: the battle rapper, the industry rapper, and the public figure. Chapter 1 serves as an introduction, orienting the dissertation's remaining three chapters by providing a literature review in persona and Russian studies, and a limited biography of Miron Fyodorov. This information situates the ensuing case studies in an interdisciplinary framework, which contributes a new analysis of persona with a focus on the use of silence in self-presentation, into the scholarly canon. Chapter 2 presents the battle rap persona through a close reading and analysis of Oxxxymiron's battle rap performances, paying particular attention to the social interaction of persona creation in the battle rap arena. This chapter is

bolstered by scholarly research on the battle rap genre and its predecessor, an African American verbal game called *the dozens*.

Chapter 3 presents a reading of the industry rapper persona through an analysis of the relationship between two of Oxxxymiron's most critical releases: *Gorgorod* and "Who Killed Mark?" It demonstrates how the Oxxxymiron persona is negotiated through creative works, and how his musical output navigates biographical experiences as a form of persona control. Finally, Chapter 4 addresses the public figure, beginning with Oxxxymiron's role in shaping public discourse through his discussions of national issues such as the suppression of free speech and the War in Ukraine. This chapter moves from a focus on Oxxxymiron's speaking out to others' breaking of silence about his private actions through their accusations of grooming and sexual assault. It considers the paradoxical roles of silence and speaking, personal fandom, and the consequences of "new public intimacy," i.e., the role of celebrity in the evolving conceptions of public, private, and intimate spheres in the digital age.

Whence Came I is a multi-disciplinary project, drawing from Russian studies, persona studies, hip hop studies, and performance studies. It puts Svetlana Boym's concept of the "theater of the self" in conversation with Erving Goffman's dramaturgical metaphor of self-presentation in a contemporary persona studies framework. This dissertation research will contribute to various fields by offering a nuanced and dynamic consideration of persona in the digital age. It is proliferated by presentational media and digital social interactions, demonstrating that who we pretend to be is a mediated conversation, full of pauses and rebuttals, rather than a declarative statement. This project asserts that it is not just the language that is used to curate a persona that matters, but also its absence, particularly in the restless and reactive digital age.

Chapter 1: On Man as Maker

Но будучи я столь чудесен, Отколь я происшел? — Безвестен; А сам собой я быть не мог – Гаврила Державин, “бог”	But being that I am so miraculous, Whence came I? ‘Tis unknown. But of myself I could not be. –Gavrila Derzhavin, “God”

Gavrila Derzhavin’s 1784 ode “Бог” (God) celebrates man’s complex being and questions the mystery of his creation, underscoring the inconceivability of man as man’s maker. Centuries later, in a digital world abounding with aliases, handles, avatars, and other markers of online persona, man is both maker and made. Persona building, the process of creating and projecting a public identity, is at the center of this dissertation. Inspired by lines of Derzhavin’s ode, it is inextricably linked to the question “whence came I?” in the dynamic context of self-presentation in the digital age. This dissertation investigates celebrity self-presentation through a case study of Miron Yanovich “Oxxxymiron” Fyodorov. In it, I navigate the concepts of the theater of the self (Boym), self-presentation (Goffman), and the lexicon of persona studies (P. David Marshall, Christopher Moore, and Kim Barbour) to contend that contemporary persona is a creative and social endeavor equally compounded by the perceivable and imperceivable. In this case of Oxxxymiron, the imperceivable is a marked absence from public life and a silence in times of expected responsiveness.

My research presents facets of the Oxxxymiron persona through a web of biography, live performances, albums, interviews, social media posts, and miscellaneous creative projects. It is an explication of the narrative that Miron Fyodorov writes through the public presentation of

Oxxxymiron in performative and digital capacities through persona subsets within the genre of Russian hip hop: the battle rapper, the industry rapper, and the public figure. I frame each persona subset within a larger mediatized identity or public self-presentation curated explicitly for a digital landscape using methods reserved for celebrities in the era of traditional media. Though I draw from both twentieth and twenty-first century theories of persona, mediatization is central to my analysis. The questions that this dissertation addresses are: What are the different facets of the Oxxxymiron persona? How are these facets mediatized, presented, and altered in various contexts? How is biography used to both contextualize and estrange a persona? What roles do silence and the unspoken play in shaping a persona? And finally, what are the consequences of new public intimacy with regard to persona perception? In answering these questions, my research proposes that Oxxxymiron both demonstrates and moves beyond dominant theories of persona in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries.

The case study answers the above questions through a nuanced presentation of the life and works of Miron Yanovich "Oxxxymiron" Fyodorov. The dissertation is organized into four chapters. Chapter 1 serves as the introduction, inserting my work into an eclectic discourse through a limited literature review of works in Russian studies, persona studies, media, and hip-hop studies that influenced my argumentation. It also provides a biographical and career history of Miron Fyodorov. Chapter 2 addresses Oxxxymiron as a persona in the world of Russian a capella battle rap. It gives a history of global battle rap and its predecessors, describes the nuances of the genre in the Russian context, and includes a close reading-based analysis of Oxxxymiron's rap battle performances to demonstrate self-presentation in the dynamic context of a social genre. Chapter 3 deconstructs persona outside of the battle rap arena; in it, I present several musical themes from key albums and singles, including the critically acclaimed

Горгород (Gorgorod) and "Кто Убил Марка?" (Who Killed Mark?) as well as interviews, social media posts, and other forms of presentational media to bring the Oxxxymiron persona to life through its deconstruction. Finally, Chapter 4 offers a lens into the intermingling of reality and persona through a discussion of new public intimacy (Marshall). It delves into Fyodorov's trajectory into public activism and then introduces the accusations of sexual assault and grooming that have landed him within the realm of public reckoning. Ultimately, my research shows the paradox of persona in the digital age: it is the manifestation of a staged individuality presented through the feigned intimacy of digital connection.

1.1 On Persona, Cultural Myth, and New Media in Russian Studies Scholarship

The field of Russian literary studies was my first entry into studying persona within the culturo-historical context of twentieth and twenty-first century Russia. The phenomenon of persona—as character, mask, image, "lyrical I" and other interpretations—is central to the Russian poetic canon and its subsequent scholarship. From Alexander Pushkin's (1799-1837) "Медный Всадник" ("The Bronze Horseman") to Boris Pasternak's (1890-1960) "Гамлет" ("Hamlet"), and Marina Tsvetaeva's (1892-1941) engagement with mythical figures, there exists a plethora of research about poetic uses of character and the development of the poem's speaker. It is in studying the development of poetic voice in Russia's 18th century that I began also to contemplate the *image* of the poet within the Russian cultural context. Specifically, it is Gavrila Derzhavin's 1796 transposition of Horace's "Exegi Monumentum Aere Perennius" ("I made a monument more permanent than bronze") that led me to research persona for this dissertation project.

Written in 23 BC, Horace's "Exegi monumentum aere perennius" influenced what is known as the "monument theme" or "exegi monumentum tradition" in Russian poetry. Though

Mikhail Lomonosov's 1747 transposition is believed to be the first, it is Derzhavin's 1795 rendition of the same Horatian ode that encapsulated the self-reflective and memorializing powers of art that inspired future transpositions of the theme.[1] Derzhavin's most notable successor in this tradition is Alexander Pushkin, whose monument poem bears Horace's "exegi monumentum" in its epigraph. Known more widely by its opening line, "Я памятник воздвиг себе не рукотворный" ("I erected a monument to myself not built by hand"), Pushkin's poem alludes to his oeuvre and proclaims that his poetry will render him immortal and known throughout the ages.[2] It is Pushkin's "I erected a monument to myself…" that influences the trajectory of the theme in the Russian poetic canon. As Soviet scholar Vladislav Alexeivich Zaitsev writes, "Говоря о роли Пушкина в развитии темы 'памятника,' следует особо подчеркнуть могучее воздействие творческой личности гениального поэта на всю последующую жизнь этой традиции" ("Speaking about Pushkin's role in the development of the monument theme, it is necessary to emphasize the genius poet's creative personality's influence on this tradition's subsequent life.")[3]

Indeed, Zaitsev's work is an example of scholarship on the monument theme that focuses on the tradition's twentieth-century poetic interpreters and inheritors. He offers compelling analyses of Valery Bryusov (1873-1924), Anna Akhmatova (1889-1966), and Joseph Brodsky's (1940-1996) interpretations and subtextual renderings of the monument theme in their poetry. In

[1] Vladislav Alexeivich Zaitsev, "Motiv 'pamiatnika' v russkoi poezii ot Lomonosova i Pushkina do Brodskogo" [The Monument Motif in Russian Poetry from Lomonosov and Pushkin to Brodsky], Vestnik Moskovskogo Universiteta, Filologia, Seria 9, 1(1998). 7-22.

[2] Alexander Pushkin, "Ya pamiatnik vozdvig sebye ne rukotvornyi" [I erected a monument to myself not built by hand], 1836, https://www.culture.ru/poems/5577/ya-pamyatnik-sebe-vozdvig-nerukotvornyi.

[3] Vladislav Alexeivich Zaitsev, "Motiv 'pamiatnika' v russkoi poezii ot Lomonosova i Pushkina do Brodskogo" [The Monument Motif in Russian Poetry from Lomonosov and Pushkin to Brodsky], 12.

his 1998 article “Мотив ‘Памятника’ в Русской Поэзии от Ломоносова и Пушкина до Бродского” (“The Monument Motif in Russian Poetry from Lomonosov and Pushkin to Brodsky”), Zaitsev recounts the thematic trends that individual poets imbued into their renditions of monument poems. In addition to discussing traditional versions of these poems, he highlights experimental ones such as Gavriil Batenikov’s (1793-1863) “Non exegi monumentum” (1856) and Vladimir Mayakovsky’s (1893-1930) “Юбилейное” (Jubilee, 1924). It is his analysis of Joseph Brodsky’s “На столетие Анны Ахматовой” (On the Centennial of Anna Akhmatova’s Birth) that compelled me to consider the poet’s persona as a monument in and of itself. Zaitsev writes that the poem recreates “великолепный, поэтически и философски осмысленный образ-портрет Ахматовой” (“a magnificent, poetic and philosophically meaningful image-portrait of Akhmatova.”)[4] It is this piece of scholarship that led me to read texts about poets to explore their mythologies and personas.

Following my introduction to the monument theme, I read biographical and autobiographical texts about poets and their public personas. Texts like Simon Karlinsky’s *Marina Tsvetaeva: The Woman, Her World, and Her Poetry* (1985) and Valentina Polukhina’s *Brodsky Through the Eyes of His Contemporaries* (1992) were my introductions to understanding how personas are constructed and mythology initiated in the realm of the poet. Notably, like Brodsky’s “On the Centennial of Akhmatova’s Birth,” these texts rely on others’ perspectives to articulate an image of the poet. Similarly, poets’ own writing about others’ personas or poetic oeuvres—Marina Tsvetaeva’s 1937 autobiographical essay “Мой Пушкин” (My Pushkin) and Joseph Brodsky’s 1987 essay collection *Less Than One*— are resources about

[4] Vladislav Alexeivich Zaitsev, “Motiv ‘pamiatnika’ v russkoi poezii ot Lomonosova i Pushkina do Brodskogo” [The Monument Motif in Russian Poetry from Lomonosov and Pushkin to Brodsky], 20.

how poets shape their understanding of the *poet* as a cultural role. As I explored these texts, I thought back to the monument theme and its initial purpose: rending the poet immortal. I began to consider what that looks like in the contemporary world, and it occurred to me that persona itself has become an artist's monument to himself or herself. It is through this lens that I began researching poets' public personas in the Russian context.

Russian studies scholarship is rich in research on specific poets and their statuses in Russian cultural mythology. Gregory Freidin's 1987 book *A Coat of Many Colors: Osip Mandelstam and his Mythologies of Self Presentation*, for instance, considers the poet's role in his own mythology. Freidin's project presents Osip Mandelstam (1891-1938) as a generator of a mythic self that both transcended and resonated with then-current political, cultural, and religious narratives. He analyzes Mandelstam's status as a charismatic poet—one defined by the poetic gift as it relates to the extraordinary, divine, and sacred. What is crucial to Freidin's work is the argument that while Mandelstam fashioned himself as a charismatic, this description is earned when it is believed and sustained by his audience. That is, his mythic self is the product of a social interaction, just as digital personas are shaped and negotiated on the Internet. Thus, while the role of the artist in self-presentation is critical in this dissertation, Freidin offers a precedent in considering the indispensability of audiences in realizing self-presentation. This is a factor that is particularly useful in the digital world, where audiences fulfill social functions in their reactions and receptions to online personas.

Another single-author book, Stephanie Sandler's 2004 *Commemorating Pushkin: Russia's Myth of a National Poet*, is an exemplary investigation into poetic mythology in Russian culture. Sandler writes poignantly about the "Pushkin myth" in Russian society. Specifically, she contends that the poet possesses a split identity; he is treated as both "one's

own" (мой, mine) and "everyone's" (наш, ours). She demonstrates how objects and spaces of the Pushkin myth, from writings to monuments and museums, represent Pushkin's status both as a "symbol of Russia and as an immensely beloved friend."[5] Sandler's research is demonstrative of the notion of new public intimacy; the idea that overexposure to celebrities shifts common understandings of public, private, and intimate. Sandler's writing on Pushkin's contradictory identity has influenced my thinking on how public figures develop personas that can be interpreted in different ways. For instance, how audiences can have one view of the persona in its capacity as an artist, and another in its role as a public figure. A typical example of this disparate engagement is when athletes are revered for their physical feats but criticized for publicly sharing their political views. Nevertheless, it is the overall function of poetic identity in the realm of cultural myth that situates this dissertation project.

Svetlana Boym's seminal book, *Death in Quotation Marks: Cultural Myths of the Modern Poet* (1991), addresses the different discourses that intersect with the persona in the Russian poetic context. In the book, she deconstructs the myths that surrounded writers after their literal and figurative deaths, turning away from the publicly negotiated personas and back to the lives these writers once lived to analyze their self-creation alongside their artistry. She describes her analysis as "a reconsideration of the relationship between a literary persona, a biographical person, and a cultural personage," which "will help [me] to elaborate cultural mythologies of the life of a modern poet and the connections between the making of poetry and the making of self."[6] Boym borrows from the lexicon of dramaturgy to explain one of her core

---

[5] Stephanie Sandler, *Commemorating Pushkin: Russia's Myth of a National Poet*, Stanford University Press: 2004, 3.

[6] Svetlana Boym, *Death in Quotation Marks: Cultural Myths of the Modern Poet*, Harvard University Press, 1991, 2.

concepts: the "theater of the self." Through this concept, she contends that the roles individuals occupy in the public sphere are "realized in the course of individual performances."[7] That is, the theater of the self does not rely on specific roles designated within a cultural paradigm; instead, it describes the performance of an individual persona that is in "constant modification."[8] Boym's notion of constant modification is crucial to my dissertation research, as is her prescience in acknowledging the corresponding modification of the cultural landscape. In other words, Boym's work initiates my undertaking of self-presentation within a changing cultural landscape, one that has been oriented toward a mediatized world and the ubiquity of persona across genres and contexts. As she noted, "The role traditionally played by literature has been usurped by film and television, and the poet is substituted by an actor or, in the youth culture, by a rock singer."[9] Boym's discussion of cultural mythology, as it applies to the poet, is a relevant intervention to the image of the rapper in modern Russia. Her consideration of the unspoken elements that contribute to the construction of ideology must be applied to the new media-driven obsession with persona.

Global social media sites such as YouTube, X (Twitter), and Instagram offer direct lines to rappers, as well as insight into their thoughts and daily routines. Internet forums also provide a community for fans and onlookers, instantly connecting rappers with audiences. While her work was published before the burgeoning of the so-called "Internet Age," Boym had the foresight to invite readings of cultural mythology beyond the poet. It is this invitation that enters my work at the junction of Russian studies and persona studies. Returning to the monument theme, the act of

---

[7] Svetlana Boym, *Death in Quotation Marks: Cultural Myths of the Modern* Poet, 29.

[8] Svetlana Boym, *Death in Quotation Marks: Cultural Myths of the Modern Poet,* 29.

[9] Svetlana Boym, *Death in Quotation Marks: Cultural Myths of the Modern Poet,* 11.

claiming immortality through creation is inherently boastful; it assumes that art, and thus the artist, will endure and survive throughout the ages. The braggadocio of Russian hip hop lends itself to the monument theme in this way, presupposing an enduring status vis-à-vis musical lyrics and performances. Taking the monument theme into consideration, I began studying persona in Russian hip hop with a foundation in the monument theme and an invitation from Svetlana Boym to analyze the theater of the self beyond poetry.

Another scholarly influence on my work that moves beyond traditional literary analysis is Richard Stites's *Russian Popular Culture: Entertainment and Society Since 1900* (1992), which analyzes the role of popular culture in Russian and Soviet culture. In his book, Stites presents a chronology of the changing subjects of popular culture from the late Russian Empire through the Russian Revolution and the ensuing Soviet period. He differentiates between each era (from Stalin's rise through Perestroika) and how state control both limited and enabled the emergence of new forms of popular culture. With the advent of the Internet, the public forum at the center of this dissertation —both public engagement with popular culture and the state's ability to control it —changed dramatically. Though state control and censorship are briefly mentioned in Chapters 3 and 4 of this dissertation, it is Stites's scholarly approach to popular culture, alongside Boym's focus on cultural mythology, that influenced my work on persona in the digital age.

Due to chronology, both Stites's and Boym's books exclude the Internet and related new media platforms. Yet these new media platforms, based on the World Wide Web, have changed the paradigm of self-presentation on both the global Internet and the "Runet" (Russian Internet). A look at scholarship on the emergence of the Runet demonstrates a changing trajectory in online engagement from collective to individual models. One of the most captivating arguments

in *Digital Russia: The Language, Culture, and Politics of New Media Communication* (2014) concerns the transfer of the Soviet collective mentality into the hierarchical, "free" World Wide Web. In his chapter titled "The (Im)personal Connection," Vlad Strukov describes how, in the Soviet Union, computers were unregulated sources of technology, unlike typewriters or tape recorders, which were tracked and regulated by Soviet security services.[10] Despite this perceived freedom, post-Soviet citizens' use of computers modeled the collective mentality, thus transforming "personal computers" into shared-use machines for shared purposes. Strukov's application of collective consciousness parallels the development of a new medium of communication, the Internet, with that of the post-Soviet citizen. He claims that it is only with the advent of the blogosphere and social networking sites, around 2005, that Russians are truly prompted to exercise freedom and individuality on the Runet.[11] It is precisely during this transition that Miron Fyodorov, although living outside of Russia, engages with hip-hop communities online while developing his own relationship with the genre. Thus, it is critical to understand that he comes of age at a time when Russophone populations are collectively turning to the Internet to witness and express public presentations of individuality.

Russophone scholars, working primarily in the fields of philology and linguistics, have also contributed to the analysis of Russian hip hop through more traditional fields. For instance, Eleanora Lassan has written several articles on battle rap, including the 2018 "Рэп-баттлы Как Культурный и Лингвокультурный Феномен" ("Rap Battles as Cultural and Linguacultural Phenomenon"), which consider hip hop's linguistic and poetic aspects. In this article, she analyzes the formulation of "I" in the *Oxxxymiron v. Dizaster* battle, positing that the battle

[10] Vlad Strukov, "The (im)personal Connection." In *Digital Russia: The Language, Culture and Politics of New Media Communication*, edited by Michael S. Gorham, Ingunn Lunde, and Martin Paulsen, Routledge, 2014, 11-33.

[11] Vlad Strukov, "The (im)personal Connection," 27.

manifests linguistic demonstrations of the Russian (Oxxxymiron) and American (Dizaster) conceptions of "I" in a way that legitimizes linguistic aggression. She continues this collective take on the genre in "Рэп-баттлы как специфический жанр современной культуры" (Rap Battles as a Specific Genre of Contemporary Culture). In this article, she argues that battle rap encompasses aspects of both written and oral culture, such as the practice of poetic duels, but also transcends these representations. She writes about the mixed registers of battles, where "high" and "low" cultures collide, and suggests that there is an argument to be made for labeling the genre as "metamodern" due to this feature and the genre's use of simulacra (Baudrillard). Lassan's research contextualizes the perspective of battle rap as a collective genre, in which its boundaries are defined in the Russian context as pseudo-literary.

Other scholars take a more quantitative look at rap battles, such as Alina Diveeva, who formulates a relationship between the concepts of "person," "time," and "life," through an analysis of rap texts. Indeed, many scholars view battle rap and hip hop at large as collective narratives that speak to Russian socio-historical contexts. Ilya Kukulin's 2020 article "Playing the Revolt: The Cultural Valorization of Russian Rap and Covert Change in Russian Society of the 2010s" is another example; Kukulin interprets violence and revolt in 2010s hip hop as a manifestation of the mask of the subaltern. While their readings are valid contributions to the collective nature of hip hop, they inadvertently overlook the paradoxical nature of battle rap and hip hop at large: they burst with self-presentations of individuality and uniqueness alongside conformity and strictures. It is in focusing on a single persona, within specific subsets, rather than collective expression, that this dissertation illustrates how this paradox functions in Russian hip hop.

Russian scholarship is abundant with case studies of image, persona, and mythology in the study of Russian rock music and musicians. Elena Avilova's article "Архетип героя в русской рок поэзии" ("The Hero Archetype in Russian Rock Poetry") analyzes archetypes in Russian rock culture, through the example of "cult" rock musicians such as Igor "Yegor" Letov (1964-2008) of the group Гражданская оборона (Grazhdanskaya Oborona), Viktor Tsoi (1962-1990) of Кино (Kino), and Yana "Yanka" Dyagileva. She situates her analysis within the socio-historical context of the term "archetype," demonstrating the connection between their "cult" personas and the term. Ultimately, Avilova's work argues that rock archetypes contribute to the perception of cult rock stars as symbols of fighting for one's beliefs, and that they occupy this role in an allegorical way. Her research aligns with the paradoxical nature of persona; cult-like figures who represent individuality and independent thought in a way that influences others. Olga Nikitina's "Доминанты образа рок героя в русской рок культуре" ("Predominant Depictions of the Rockstar in Russian Rock Culture") situates her analysis within the concept of biographical myth, long connected to poets in the Russian context. She argues that rock music, as a whole, has created a distinct personality representative of biographical myth; she dubs this personality the "герой-одиночка" ("lone hero"). She acknowledges that this representative persona is paradoxical, as its significance depends on the individual characterization of each artist. Avilova and Nikitina's arguments are connected to my research on Oxxxymiron in that I study his persona through a persona studies framework, one that elucidates digital persona as a phenomenon with specific characteristics (see section 1.2). Yet, like they observe, individuals hold markers of their unique self-presentation. In the case of Oxxxymiron, his distinctive characteristic is silence in its many forms; like the lone hero, he fulfills specific persona subsets, but it is his individual characterization upon which his significance relies.

Russophone public writing about hip hop and hip-hop artists is also central to this dissertation. Oxxxymiron, for instance, has been interviewed or featured by *BBC Russia, Meduza, Kommersant, Novaya Gazeta*, and other major Russian-language publications. He is also commonly featured in online resources such as hip-hop sites, blogs, and vlogs. While some pieces are informational, such as reports about a sold-out concert or his upcoming tour, others are analytical in nature. It is in public writing that Oxxxymiron's persona is presented, perceived, and negotiated. It is for this reason that I employ a variety of non-scholarly sources to demonstrate the prolific practice of persona building in the digital age across new media platforms.

1.2 On Persona Studies in the Digital Age

The early Internet's guise of anonymity is the condition that facilitated the proliferation of online personas. A now historical adage from Internet culture speaks to the nature of this idea: "On the Internet nobody knows you're a dog" (see Fig. 1). Derived from the caption of a 1993 *New Yorker* cartoon by Peter Steiner, it remains a phrase used to reference individuals' abilities to present identities on the Internet that do not align with their realities. Another common adage that complicates the contemporary notion of persona is "The Internet never forgets." This phrase is often used as a reproach, as if to warn of the inescapability of the Internet's collective memory. It means that nothing ever truly gets deleted; everything is stored in archives and copies that proliferate the digital space. Regarding persona, this adage speaks to the fact that all forms of online persona, old, altered, and

Figure 1: An image of Peter Steiner's 1993 *New Yorker* cartoon.

new, exist at the same time, their transformation or stagnation documented. Together, they describe the status of persona creation in the digital age: projecting and maintaining a public identity whose versions exist in tandem.

The term "persona" has historical roots in antiquity, psychology, and literature. The term comes from Latin and means "mask," used to describe actors' character roles.[12] The first vestiges of its contemporary meaning come from Jungian psychology. In his quest to describe the human psyche, Carl Jung (1875-1961) identified and described parts of the conscious and unconscious mind. He named the three domains of the conscious mind as the ego, persona, and shadow. Where the ego represents our identities and sense of reality, the persona is a social mask. Sonoko Tonyoda writes that the persona "looks like ourselves, but it is largely influenced by the outer world; therefore, it is a kind of compromise between the individual and society."[13] According to Jung, the conscious mind is a domain used to describe an individual's internal world. Coming from the field of sociology, Erving Goffman developed a dramaturgical analysis of persona from the external world or the realm of social interaction. It is precisely Goffman's analysis that transforms and initiates the concept of persona as it is known today.

Goffman's seminal book *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life* (1956) initiated a groundbreaking analysis of social interaction through self-presentation. Rather than investigate social interactions within academic, political, religious, and other complex social structures, Goffman deviated from the norm to analyze individual interpersonal interactions. Through his study, he developed the social presentation theory, which contends that individuals present

---

[12] P. David Marshal, Christopher Moore, and Michelle Barbour, *Persona Studies: An Introduction* (John Wiley & Sons, 2019), 24.

[13] Sonoko Toyoda, "Persona," International Association of Analytical Psychology, https://iaap.org/jung-analytical-psychology/short-articles-on-analytical-psychology/persona-2/.

themselves (perform) in certain ways to create specific impressions on others (observers or audiences). Goffman's analysis is referred to as dramaturgical in that he adopted the language of theater in his theory, using terms such as "frontstage," "backstage," "front," and "performance" to articulate how individuals present themselves differently in social situations. For Goffman, presentation is one's cumulative engagement in activities in front of an audience that one has some influence over. Related to presentation are the mask (the persona we embody in each situation) and the front or "the expressive equipment of a standard kind intentionally or unwittingly employed by the individual during his performance."[14] In other words, the front encompasses both the mask and the tools we use to perform the mask, such as our clothing, overall appearance, and mannerisms.

Continuing with his dramaturgical lexicon, frontstage, the space where theatrical performances occur, is the space where individuals present themselves, engage in social interactions, and manage perceptions; the frontstage is where we are aware of being observed and accordingly put on our masks. Conversely, the backstage is a space sequestered from the public in which actors can drop their masks and engage in activities or behaviors that are out of public view. In Goffman's framework of social interaction, the backstage is the space where individuals can be themselves, rather than carry out their constructed personas. It is a place where individuals engage in behaviors or actions that could be considered inappropriate for the frontstage (in theater, this would be an actor dropping character, cast members changing costumes, stagehands carrying props, etc.).

While I do not engage with all of Goffman's dramaturgical language, it is essential to understand that the concepts which he described are now inherent to persona research. In my

[14] Erving Goffman, *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, Doubleday 1959, 13.

analysis, I consider how frontstage and backstage, or the realms of public, private, and intimate, have changed through the advent of the Internet age. One example of this difference is how social media platforms can be perceived, by some users, as a place to "drop the mask," and by others as a forum for decorating it. Furthermore, social media sites grant users the ability to engage with one another in real-time, which alters the significance of spaces created for and devoid of performance. Regarding the Oxxxymiron persona, I consider how his frequent retreats from public life constitute a backstage, a liminal space created through silence for deliberate disengagement from public social interactions.

Additionally pertinent to how persona is analyzed in this dissertation are Goffman's concepts of "performance" and "impression management." Performance is the act of presenting oneself through social interaction or observation; it is the assembly of all responses to social interaction. Impression management is the conscious and subconscious process of attempting to control how others perceive you. These two terms are inextricable as individuals perform and alter their personas in relation to the impressions they are making in the moment. What is crucial to understand is that Goffman's dramaturgical framework for analyzing self-presentation is contextualized by the mundane; he studies everyday social interactions, such as students (masks, fronts) responding to teachers (audience). Over time, however, his framework started to be used in the analysis of celebrities and other public cultural figures. That is, Goffman's research has not only remained relevant but has become innate in the interdisciplinary field of persona studies, which intersects communication studies, Internet studies, sociology, and similarly observational disciplines of contemporary life. Thus, despite writing far before the advent of the World Wide Web, Goffman is often employed in the burgeoning analysis of the *online persona*.

It is precisely the greater context of the digital age that has dynamized contemporary understandings of persona.

David Schulman contributes to research on Goffman's contemporaneity with his chapter *Self Presentation: Impression Management in the Digital Age* in the *Routledge International Handbook of Goffman Studies* (2022). While the term "digital age" is used broadly, the Internet is distinguished between three (current) periods described as Web 1.0, 2.0, and 3.0. Since the 1990s, the modern Internet has undergone significant technological evolution and increased user interactivity. Web 1.0 refers to the first version of the World Wide Web (1990s); Web 2.0 refers to the second version (2000s); and Web 3.0 refers to the present version.

Each version is defined by several distinguishing features (see Fig. 2). For instance, on Web 3.0, users can create different types of content (text, image, video, etc.) while also having information and content tailored to their preferences and online behaviors using artificial intelligence. Dynamic platforms and behavior-driven data bolster their usage and interactions, and they can reach large global audiences. What is most pertinent to Schulman's analysis of Goffman is the level of interactivity that Web 3.0 offers for self-presentation and impression management. In his chapter, Schulman demonstrates that the changing landscape of the Internet affects how users present themselves publicly, as well as how they manage these presentations. What differs from

Web 1.0	Web 2.0	Web 3.0
Typically read-only	Strongly read-write	Read-write-interact
Owned content	Shared content	Consolidated content
Visual/interactive Web	Programmable Web	Linked data Web
Home pages	Wikis and blogs	Waves and live streams
Web page	Web service endpoint	Data space
HTML/HTTP/URL/Portals	XML/RSS	RDF/RDFS/OWL
Page views	Cost per click	User engagement
File/web servers, search engines, e-mail, P2P file sharing, content and enterprise portals	Instant messaging, Ajax and JavaScript frameworks, Adobe Flex	Personal intelligent data assistants, ontologies, knowledge bases, semantic search functions
Directories	Tagging the user	User behavior
Focus on the company	Focus on the community	Focus on the individual

Figure 2: A chart defining key features of past and current Web versions.

Goffman's mid-twentieth-century analysis is that the individual's performance is mediated by the Internet's resources and changing technological advancements.

Additionally, technology enables new forms of self-presentation that are inextricably linked to "machines," such as artificial intelligence, data mining, and algorithms that personalize the web experience. While these changes are expected to ground Web 4.0 (future version), they are relevant to Web 3.0, and its boom of artificial intelligence (AI) based technologies. Suppose we are to relate the digital context at the center of Schulman's analysis back to Goffman's lexicon. In that case, we can say that the frontstage is constantly changing, diverting our attention to personalized audiences that affect impression management. Specifically, individuals are continually exposed to new human and machine interactions that affect how they can present themselves, are unable to manage these presentations fully, and the methods and scope of their audience reach. In turn, Schulman's research defines a critical part of the context through which I analyze Oxxxymiron's career trajectory: the ever-evolving World Wide Web dictates the changes to self-presentation and impression management. This is particularly relevant for a hip hop artist who came to prominence through the developments of Web 2.0 and 3.0, which expand user engagement through newer, dynamic forms of customization, feedback, and interaction.

Henry Jenkins' *Convergence Culture*: *Where Old and New Media Collide* is a seminal text to persona studies as it discusses the implications at the verge of old and new media with regard to culture. In passing, he describes the contemporary Internet's system of self-presentation through media. He writes, "Each of us constructs our own persona mythology from bits and fragments of information extracted from the media flow and transformed into resources through

which we make sense of our everyday lives."[15] It is in this vein that my dissertation broaches the idea of self-presentation as both an individual process and a social interaction. Celebrity persona mythology, in particular, is a negotiation of information and perception, where some information is given, whether actual to the individual or not, but also taken to new heights by others. For instance, Oxxxymiron's tattoos have been copied by fans, demonstrating how one piece of information (a tattoo) converts to persona mythology through audiences' interactions with the given information.

Other scholars have expanded Jenkins' consideration of the convergence of old and new media alongside the contemporary development of persona within this convergence: persona studies scholars, P. David Marshall, Christopher Moore, and Kim Barbour are pioneers of the emerging field that considers how individuals present themselves in real life and mediated contexts. The most prolific of the three, Marshall has authored and co-authored dozens of texts about persona and celebrity culture, respectively. Marshall has advocated for the field of persona studies throughout his career by demonstrating that celebrity culture permeates the creation and editing of ordinary people's conceptions of the public self. Thus, he contends, celebrity culture is deserving of closer scrutiny for its impact on broader cultural changes.

One of the changes Marshall addresses in his work is the coincidence of celebrity culture with cultural movements related to self-help and sentimentality. He argues that together these led to a societal push for individualization beginning in the 1970s. Marshall writes that it was the "burgeoning discourse of celebrity—the extra-textual dimension of the celebrated and the famed—that was the location for the production of the idiosyncrasies of public individuals that

[15] Henry Jenkins, *Convergence Culture: Where Old and New Media Collide*, New York: New York University Press, 2006, 4.

was much more systematic in maintaining and supporting individuality in contemporary culture's organization."[16] Celebrities became models of individualization and individuality, encouraging the public to follow suit. In contemporary discourse, this trend has given way to influencer culture, a phenomenon that refers to the influence of ordinary people turned public figures on the behaviors and purchasing trends of others. Influencers began to act as celebrities once did in traditional media, becoming spokespeople for specific brands, aestheticizing and glamorizing the mundane, and "selling authenticity." The paradoxical idea that one can sell authenticity is predicated upon a shared understanding of the social world in which individuals engage, referred to by Charles Taylor as a "social imaginary."[17] Roland Barthes' concept of myth also fits into this discuss, in that enacting persona is akin to a system of communication that supersedes language.[18] It is in thinking through individuality and authenticity in persona as paradoxes that I engage the concept of mythmaking as an alternate form of biographical disclosure; a process used to ground a persona rather than provide a subjective account of one's life.

In his work, Marshall distinguishes contemporary self-presentation from its prior form as a product of "representational media" sources such as books, radio, newspapers, and television that "attempt to embody a populace."[19] He contends that we are now living in a world dominated by self-presentation through "presentational media" or "identifying media that is performed, produced and exhibited by the individual or other collectives and not by the structure of

---

[16] P. David Marshall, "Persona Studies: Mapping the Proliferation of the Public Self," *Journalism* 15, no. 2 (2014): 157, https://doi.org/10.1177/1464884913488720.

[17] Charles Taylor, "Modern Social Imaginaries," *Public Culture* 14, no. 1 (2002): 91–124, https://doi.org/10.1215/08992363-14-1-91.

[18] Roland Barthes. *Mythologies*. Translated by Annette Lavers, Hill and Wang, 1972, 15-25.

[19] Marshall, "Persona Studies: Mapping the Proliferation of the Public Self," 160.

representational media, which is almost by definition large public and private media corporations."[20] That individuals can upload, share, and mediate online content is central to understanding how presentational media functions, as are the roles of social media networks. It is the manifestations of these capabilities—uploaded videos, text-based social media posts, interviews with online publications—that comprise my source material when analyzing Fyodorov's self-presentation as Oxxxymiron.

In 2020, Marshall, along with co-authors Kim Barbour and Christopher Moore, published the first comprehensive reader on the field of persona studies, titled *Persona Studies: An Introduction* (2020). This volume situates the field's influences through prominent scholarly ideas, as well as contributes individual and collective definitions relevant to the lexicon necessary for analyzing persona in the digital age. The first central idea the authors introduce is John Fiske's concept of the "art of making do." In his 1989 book, *Understanding Popular Culture,* Fiske argues that it is people who make culture by the ways and means in which they engage with cultural artifacts and adapt them to their personal lives. He argues that individuals have agency and deliberately engage in the act of self-presentation within specific systems.[21] This idea is related to performance and impression management (Goffman). Fiske and Goffman both demonstrate how people present and reassemble their identities within social interactions; their performances are informed by their judgments and assumptions (of the audience, social setting, etc.). Performers' awareness of social settings is a key aspect of Chapter 2 of this dissertation, in which I discuss the curated elements of the battle rap arena, as well as the interactive aspects of persona creation.

---

[20] Marshall et al., *Persona Studies,* glossary.

[21] John Fiske, *Understanding Popular Culture*, Second edition, Routledge: 2010, 232, https://doi-org.proxy.lib.umich.edu/10.4324/9780203837177.

Social interactions in the online space look different than in-person interactions, where individuals communicate through words, expressions, and gestures. Scholars consider actions such as creating and publishing profiles, commenting, and adding likes and other reactions to digital posts as examples of interactivity. Marshall, Moore, and Barbour categorize these interactions as "intercommunication" and categorize them within three different registers: professional, private, and intimate. In terms of a non-celebrity persona, the professional domain refers to a more formal career related self-presentation (job postings, resumes, LinkedIn); the private domain refers to a more casual family and friend oriented self-presentation (posting photos, writing post descriptions); and lastly, the intimate domain refers to a more authentic and vulnerable self-presentation that is reserved for close friends (commenting in private group chats, sharing memes). In conjunction with these registers is the term intercommunication or the strategic blending of public, private, and intimate in online self-presentation. The authors write that intercommunication "implies interpersonal exchange as being a form of intermediary between these different ways of communicating."[22] For my research purposes, intercommunication is a means of understanding the duality of biography as it pertains to self-presentation and perception, or the alternate ways it is used to both form and undermine, or expose, a persona. This concept is most relevant to Chapters 3 and 4, but it exists in different forms throughout the dissertation.

Another vital contribution of Marshall, Moore, and Barbour's is a five-point framework for analyzing contemporary persona. This framework consists of five recognized dimensions of persona: *publicness, mediatization, performativity, collective construction,* and *intentional value*

[22] Marshall et al., *Persona Studies,* glossary.

or value, agency, reputation, prestige (VARP).[23] The authors consider these dimensions to be "key to understanding the configuration of online identity in the contemporary era."[24] Each dimension is situated within the technological realm; the first addresses how the Internet enables individuals to share with and grow audiences; the second addresses how online personas are produced through the utilization of "multiple technologies and formats operating under various conditions;" the third, and most crucial to this dissertation, *performativity*, acknowledges that online personalities are made up of many sides or faces (Goffman) that are enabled and constrained by various technologies and online spaces, and are "neither entirely 'real' or 'fictional'."[25] Thus, an online persona is an amalgam of different but interconnected public performances for specific, changing audiences. Correspondingly, persona is not static, but evolving, and responsive to internal and external factors. In this dissertation, performativity is one method for discussing the passive and active aspects of self-presentation, such as Oxxxymiron's use of silence as an example of passive performativity.

The remaining two dimensions of persona that the authors identify relate to entities beyond the performer and the technologies at their disposal. Collective construction refers to the fact that online personas generate collective activity through actions such as using specific social media platforms. Each platform has its own collective activities, such as friending, following, commenting, that allow for online personas to engage with "multiple collective publics."[26] This is different from collectivity through representational media. In that context, individuals are

[23] Marshall et al., *Persona Studies*, 68.

[24] Marshall et al., *Persona Studies*, 68.

[25] Marshall et al., *Persona Studies*, 69.

[26] Marshall et al., *Persona Studies*, 71.

considered part of a single broader public; in the context of presentational media, online personas are connected to different collective publics. For users of Web 3.0, the Internet's hyper-algorithmizing and personalization further refine what collective publics users are exposed to. Collective construction is thus, in part, guided by technological advances. In my reading, this concept is related to impression management, in that the audience's reactions or anticipated reactions to performance contribute to a collective construction of persona.

The fifth and final dimension for assessing persona refers to the representational elements of an individual's investment in their online persona: value, agency, reputation, and prestige or VARP. Value relates to an online persona's significance and, in the case of celebrities, potential for monetary earnings. As is expected, agency refers to an online persona's ability to enact or exert power, such as celebrities who campaign for or against a specific cause. Going further, the authors contend that online personas can influence the reputation of offline personas, where online personas present how one wishes to be perceived. That is, online personas can project desired qualities that are then applied by audiences to offline reputations. Finally, prestige completes the VARP acronym. This dimension invokes the idea that online persona development generates respect or admiration from audiences.[27] The provided definitions of VARP are singular, though the authors describe their interactions, such as how value begets reputation. This interactivity will be explored throughout the dissertation, with a particular focus on reputation and the connected concept of new public intimacy, which will be introduced in Chapter 4.

[27] Marshall et al., *Persona Studies*, 78.

1.3 On Persona Research in Music and Cultural Studies

Outside of persona studies, in the literary context, persona has long referred to a dramatic speaker, a voice separate from that of the poet. While this definition applies to hip-hop texts, such as the recurring character "Mark" in Oxxxymiron's *Gorgorod*, the more ubiquitous form of persona is that of the artist's self-presentation, as this dissertation presents. Rock music scholarship in the American context has provided several persona-oriented case studies that have impacted my conception of celebrity persona in the digital age. Texts like David R. Shumway's *Rockstar: The Making of Musical Icons From Elvis to Springsteen* (2014) and Philip Auslander's *In Concert: Performing Musical Persona* (2021) are recent examples of scholars' writing about musical persona. These texts examine how musical artists present themselves to audiences, rather than their enactment of characters. Authors who write about stage persona as a public presentation of a curated-self offer case studies in understanding the creation and mediation of stage persona, as well as their function and cultural impact across time.

In *Rockstar: The Making of Musical Icons From Elvis to Springsteen,* Shumway argues that *star personas*, or the stage personas of now-iconic rock stars, were instrumental forces that enacted cultural change or embodied cultural significance.[28] Shumway's work is an example of persona studies in action in that it identifies a unique expression of self-presentation. As persona studies scholars have noted, everyone performs different personas based on a set context. For Shumway, the "star persona" is the cultural articulation of a highly skilled, popular, and influential self. His significant contribution to my thinking is the proposal to read a genre's cultural significance through persona. He moves away from scholarship that foregrounds music's

[28] Shumay focuses on the star persona, one he differentiates from celebrity; David R. Shumway et al., *Rock Star : The Making of Musical Icons from Elvis to Springsteen* (Johns Hopkins University Press, 2014).

lyrical and performative elements as filters for viewing broader cultural changes and proposes instead that personas be the first line of analysis. For Shumway, persona *is* the filter through which lyrical and performative elements can be analyzed and reflected in culture. While Shumway assigns culturally relevant character types to his case studies (such as Elvis as a sexualized male object of public gaze), I aim to narrate Miron Fyodorov's construction of Oxxxymiron through a broader analysis of self-presentation as it relates to intercommunication and impression management. I highlight persona in different capacities to show how the artist's cultural significance as an arbiter of influence changes depending on the micro publics to which it is presented.

Philip Auslander's book *In Concert* is similarly situated in case studies. It presents an analysis of a range of performers across genres, from The Beatles to Lady Gaga to B.B. King. In it, Auslander uses the term "musical persona" to define the way that these and other artists present themselves in front of audiences, considering different visual means like physical gestures and stage effects. Like Shumway, he argues that performances of music are mediated through constructed personas that warrant investigation as forces connected to, but not exclusive from, music itself. Auslander considers that the persona is the original performance, not the musical and lyrical elements themselves. He breaks away from the debates between musicologists and performance studies scholars to argue that a new lens is needed to study musical persona as a performance connected to, but not exclusive from, music itself. The idea that the performed persona is significant to itself *and* to the music it creates aligns with the persona studies concept of intercommunication. In my interpretation, musical persona and music are different forms of the artist communicating with audiences; my interest remains in how and what the persona communicates through self-presentation on and off stage. Related to

Auslander's work is Simon Frith's *Performing Rites: On the Value of Popular Music (1998)*. In the book, Frith argues for the consideration of listening as a performance in and of itself.[29] That is, he contends that the music we listen to, and how we engage with it, from our physical actions to psychological considerations of the work, is a form of performance. This concept applies to battle rap, where audiences, both in person and virtual, contribute to the performance with their physical and digital reactions. The number of views a battle gets, for instance, is a symbol of users' engagement with the content as well as a value sign for the artist whose self-presentation is tied to audience engagement. Moreover, the idea of engagement with a musical persona also plays a role in fandom and perception, concepts that are explored in Chapter Four.

In terms of hip hop scholarship, the field includes some seminal works whose insights complement my analysis of persona. Gregory Dimitriadis' 2001 *Performing Identity Performing Culture: Hip-hop as Text, Pedagogy, and Lived Practice* is the first ethnographic approach to how young people relate to hip-hop "texts" broadly defined.[30] Dimitriadis' book simultaneously documents the history of hip hop from underground live performances with specific geographical and racial connections to a sprawling "mediated narrative" with regional distinctions. Much of the book deals with how hip hop is a generator of culture and how Black American youth specifically identify with this culture. In its own way, it details how cultural forces (creators, receivers) intercommunicate. However, it is Chapter 5, co-authored with George Kamberelis, that introduces mythologization in the realm of hip hop. The authors lean on the idea of "conversationalized public discourse" (or public conversations) as an arbiter of the changes seen in hip hop character types. They write, "In addition, conversationalized public discourse blurs the

---

[29] Simon Frith, *Performing Rites: On the Value of Popular Music,* New York: 1998, 360.

[30] Greg Dimitriadis, *Performing Identity/Performing Culture: Hip Hop as Text, Pedagogy, and Lived Practice*, Intersections in Communications and Culture , rev. ed., (Lang Publishing Inc, 2009), XIV.

line between information and entertainment and between the public and private. Among other things, this blurring helps render constructed selves and worlds durably real."[31] For instance, authors describe the transition from the "gangsta" figure in hip hop beginning in the mid-to-late 1980s to a *psychologized* version of the gangsta type in the early-to-mid 1990s.[32] Rappers like Tupac "2Pac" Shakur and Christopher "Biggie Smalls" Wallace personalized and psychologized narratives in their music, elevating their biographies and psyches to the realm of public image. With this shift, these rappers become "mythic figures," a result of the blurring of public and private within their self-constructed narratives.[33] This is explored further in the chapter, where the authors use 2Pac as a case study in the symbolic mediation and co-creation of identity. This type of mythologization is evident in the persona of Oxxxymiron, as underscored by the artist himself and his audiences. His musical output often displays the inner workings of his psyche, usually in an opaque way, and other times on full display, as we will see in the analysis of "Who Killed Mark?"

Dimitriadis and Kamberelis also write about how the youth described relating to 2Pac during his life and after his death. They document how these young people looked to his story as a reflection of their own lived experiences, citing examples like the relatability of his negative experiences with police and the tenderness he publicly extended to his single mother, Afeni Shakur. However, the authors also describe how the youth turned 2Pac into an idol after his death. Their significant contribution relates to the notion of conversationalized public discourse; they reveal that much of the information young people used to mythologize 2Pac after his death

---

[31] Dimitriadis, *Performing Identity/Performing Culture*.128.

[32] They define the gangsta figure as "a larger-than-life character whose exploits existed at the surface of exaggerated violence and brutality;" Dimitriadis, *Performing Identity/Performing Culture*, 129-130.

[33] Dimitriadis, Performing Identity/Performing Culture, 132.

came from conversations amongst themselves. Different unsubstantiated rumors and theories emerged, like the claim that 2Pac did not, in fact, die in 1996.[34] The authors conclude that Tupac Shakur's life was "a kind of dialogic fodder from which to construct a particular iconic or mythological formation."[35] I read this construction as a form of reputation building and demonstrating admiration or prestige before the emergence of online culture. The fact is that young people adopted aspects of the 2Pac persona and applied them to Tupac Shakur's biographical narratives, which resulted in mythologization as a means of enhancing reputation and prestige. While the authors note that mythologization and iconic formation have occurred for decades across the entertainment industry, their focus on the public image of the psychologized gangsta contributes to my analysis of Oxxxymiron, who endures a similar treatment. Whereas 2Pac's mythologization occurred after his death, Oxxxymiron's occurs as his career develops, both through his own actions and the perceptions of his audiences.

2Pac's mythologization is far from a singular case study in hip hop scholarship and public writing. Marshall Bruce "Eminem" Mathers III has served as a prominent scholarly case study for his use of multiple performed personas. In Mathers' case, persona refers to a *character* rather than a presentation of oneself. Anna Hickey-Moody, professor of intersectional humanities at Maynooth University in Ireland, categorizes three of Mathers' personas in her article *Eminem's Lyrical Personae: The Everyman, the Needy Man, the Hegemon.* She frames her work within representations of masculinity and categorizes the three personas within this context. She identifies Marshall Mathers (which is also the rapper's legal name) as the everyman; Slim Shady

[34] Dimitriadis, Performing Identity/Performing Culture, 137.

[35] Dimitriadis, Performing Identity/Performing Culture, 146.

as the needy man; and Eminem as the hegemon.[36] Hickey-Moody ultimately concludes that these characters are different representations of the same working-class White male experiences. In essence, they are fictionalized and hyperbolized configurations of Marshall Bruce Mathers' lived experience. Like Marshall, Moore, and Barbour's, Moody's research addresses the coexistence of different facets of persona and their interconnection with the artists' biographical reality. This thinking is relevant to Chapter 3, which discusses how musical output influences specific readings of persona.

Hip hop scholarship is historically, but not exclusively, focused on the American context. Though now considered a global genre, there is still a tendency to reference core tenets of American hip hop, as the genre's original context, in the analysis of local idioms. Travis Harris acknowledges these facts in his advocacy for a new wave of hip hop scholarship. Harris first marks the inception of hip hop studies as the first wave, the period from which hip hop was deemed a context worthy of scholarly analysis. The second wave is when scholarship branches from hip hop studies into "global hip hop studies." This marks the time when scholars began writing about hip hop culture outside of the United States. Yet, they still viewed local idioms as derivative or appropriative of American hip hop and Black culture.

While in the late 1990s and early 2000s appropriation of Black American culture was at the center of global hip hop studies discourse, Harris has sought to base the analysis of local hip hop cultures without this explicit comparison. Rather than undermining local hip-hop cultures by assessing them in comparison to Black American models, Harris proposes critically and objectively engaging with hip-hop as a single culture with local expressions. That is, he moves

[36] Anna Hickey-Moody, "Eminem's Lyrical Personae: The Everyman, the Needy Man, the Hegemon," *Culture, Society and Masculinities* vol. 1, no. 2 (2009): 213, https://doi.org/10.3149/csm.0102.213.

away from "global hip hop" to a singular discipline of hip hop that is inherent in its Blackness and African origin. He argues that distinguishing between the two with an artificial line detracts from one's understanding of hip hop, and that a "continual focus on Hip Hop as an African diasporic phenomenon is necessary to collapsing global Hip Hop into Hip Hop."[37] Harris' framework allows for engagement with hip hop as a tradition that is no longer solely influenced by foreign models but develops organically in various cultural idioms along a spectrum spanning from white supremacy to anti-racism. This model aims to preserve the Black origins of hip-hop culture without imposing them on localized racial dynamics or socio-cultural paradigms.

While Harris' framework is noteworthy, it does not account for the duplicitous and spontaneous nature of cultural expressions of authenticity. In her 2019 doctoral dissertation, Dr. Alena Aniskiewicz discusses the global and national implications of authenticity (in the Polish context), offering a lens through which to view the changing role of the supra-national African American roots of hip hop. Her research underscores how artists" keep it real" (remain authentic) while negotiating different contexts, from mediating their identities through historical perceptions of hip hop, to occupying national conceptions of collective identity.[38] Central to authenticity, Aniskiewicz demonstrates, is reception or the idea that authenticity and meaning are "constructed through a wide, social confluence of texts and context."[39] This thinking complements theories of mediatized identity in persona studies scholarship. In "Monitoring Persona: Mediatized Identity and the Edited Public Self" (2015), Marshall argues that

---

[37] Travis Harris, "Can It Be Bigger Than Hip Hop?: From Global Hip Hop Studies to Hip Hop," *Journal of Hip Hop Studies.* Vol. 6, no. 2 (2019): 6, https://doi.org/10.34718/27NK-BX98.

[38] Alena Aniskiewicz, "Cultural Remix: Polish Hip-Hop and the Sampling of Heritage" (Thesis, 2019), http://deepblue.lib.umich.edu/handle/2027.42/151384.

[39] Alena Aniskiewicz, "Cultural Remix," 34.

presentational media systems have transformed not only self-presentation but the value of self in the contemporary world. He writes:

> While most of the representational media and cultural regime was concerned with revealing the true self, the presentational era expressed through online culture may be emerging as a moment where the search for the true and inner psychological self no longer defines our culture; instead we are increasingly comfortable with the public mask and the strategic persona that we use to negotiate this pervasively mediatized public world.[40]

Marshall notes that presentational media blends the public, private, and intimate as equal domains of self-presentation, lending to an individual's valuation of how representations of these domains are presented to others, rather than valuing an internal change in the self. This all comes together in Mark Fisher's idea (paraphrased by Marshall, Moore, and Barbour) that hip hop "is entirely a spectacle of individualism."[41]

This dissertation is a deconstruction of that idea, showing the different elements of the spectacle through a thorough analysis of one artist's self-presentation. One element of self-presentation is biography, the use of specific lived experiences to construct a narrative for one's public persona. As such, the following sections provide background information about Miron Yanovich Fyodorov, from his childhood through key points in his early career trajectory. They are intended to inform readers of points that become critical to both his self-presentation and public perceptions of his persona.

1.4 On the Life and Times of Miron "Oxxxymiron" Fyodorov

The online presentation of Miron Fyodorov's biography is central to understanding the Oxxxymiron persona. As is held firmly in persona studies, I work within the notion that persona

---

[40] P. David Marshall, "Monitoring Persona: Mediatized Identity and the Edited Public Self," *Frame* 28, no. 1 (2015): 130.

[41] Marshall et al., *Persona Studies,* 34.

does not equal identity; that is, our private identities and public facing personas blend and influence the receptions of one another.[42] While there is no purpose in attempting to delineate absolutely between person and personal identity, biographical information does provide a grounding for audiences to understand the origins of some elements of persona. For that reason, this dissertation will provide information about the life of Miron Yanovich Fyodorov.

For a twenty-first-century artist functioning in the era of presentational media, there is a surprisingly limited amount of biographical information publicly available about Miron Fyodorov. He is selective in giving interviews and circulates talking points about his personal life when the topic arises. He has shared some photos from his youth on social media pages before deleting them. Still, information about his life and personal relationships primarily comes from Wikipedia pages and Oxxxymiron fan sites whose authors are anonymous contributors. Some fan site authors seem to work from public records: sites like "Oxxxyfan.ru" list personal and professional details about his parents, such as their names and academic credentials. Other sites are dedicated to his romantic history, displaying "evidence" that was scoured from social media posts, song lyrics, and rap battles, to construct timelines of relationships and breakups. Cross-referencing interviews can corroborate some of the information from these sites, but most of it exists unsubstantiated in the digital abyss of Oxxxymiron fandom.

Direct interviews with Fyodorov would seem to be the only method for obtaining or asking questions about his biography. Over the years, I made several attempts to speak with Fyodorov through his manager, Zhenya Murodshoeva. In 2018, while spending a few weeks in Moscow and St. Petersburg and making several requests, I was told that I could potentially interview Fyodorov, just two days before I was set to return to the United States. That interview

42 Marshall et al., Persona Studies, 2-3.

never came to fruition, thwarted by the opening of Fyodorov's first brick-and-mortar store in Moscow called Oxxxyshop. The following year, I reached out to Ivan Nechepurenko, a *New York Times* journalist, for advice; he managed to secure an interview with Fyodorov for the publication in May 2019. Nechepurenko said there were two ways to increase the likelihood of a conversation: going to Russia and being persistent. I had the persistence, but global circumstances thwarted my ability to travel to Russia in 2020 and beyond.

Without a verifiable source and no prospect for an interview with Fyodorov himself, I contacted one more person who I thought might understand my situation: Dr. Yan Fyodorov, Miron Fyodorov's father. As a professor of mathematics at King's College London, I felt that Dr. Fyodorov would understand my plight and the professional nature of a doctoral student's request.[43] In an email, I explained to Dr. Fyodorov that I sought a reputable source to verify simple biographical information; I did not feel comfortable citing "Oxxxyfan.ru" as a source in my dissertation. I communicated that I would seek Institutional Review Board (IRB) approval and would only ask pre-screened questions about biographical details made public in non-interview sources such as Oxxxymiron's Wikipedia page. Dr. Fyodorov graciously denied my inquiry but validated an assumption I have long held. He wrote:

> Unfortunately, I can hardly provide you with any information about Miron. Such information is, in fact, an integral part of his image as an artist, and he has his clear strategy of what should/should not be available in the public space. I wouldn't want to inadvertently undermine his efforts. You may of course send me your list of questions, and I will forward them to Zhenya Murodshoeva. But there is very little chance of them being answered. I am afraid that his abstention from commenting is a very conscious choice.[44]

---

[43] Kings College London, "Professor Yan Fyodorov," King's People, https://www.kcl.ac.uk/people/yan-fyodorov

[44] Zhenya Murodshoeva is Fyodorov's agent, with whom I had already been in contact; Yan Fyodorov, email message to author, October 26, 2022.

This response addressed my unstated claim that Miron Fyodorov was intentional about controlling public narratives related to his biography. His use of recycled talking points, selective interviews, and curated social media posts is a deliberate choice in the creation and maintenance of his public persona. Moreover, they are bolstered by the silence of those around him, lending to the elusiveness of his public figure. With the significant exception of the three women who publicly came forward with allegations of sexual assault and grooming in March 2025, no other individuals have shared biographical information about Miron Fyodorov that he had not already discussed himself.[45] Control of the limited biographical information is an intentional step in the curation of Oxxxymiron. That is, it is not meant to be verifiable or corroborated in terms of Miron Fyodorov's life; rather, it exists as a limited context for the self-presentation of Oxxxymiron. Taking this into consideration, I approached the biographical puzzle, whose pieces are strewn about the Internet, with the intention of highlighting major points in Fyodorov's life, which are often invoked in his battle rap and hip-hop careers, to understand the self-presentation of Oxxxymiron better. Using Russian and English language interviews, articles, and fan pages, I present a limited biography of Miron Yanovich Fyodorov.

1.4.1 On Miron Yanovich Fyodorov: Emigration, Coming of Age, and Education

Miron Yanovich Fyodorov was born on January 3, 1985, in Leningrad, USSR, to Jewish parents. His father, Yan Valeryevich Fyodorov, has a doctorate in theoretical and mathematical physics. He works as a professor in London, and his mother, Olga Leonidovna Sudakova, studied to be a librarian. There is no public information about whether Fyodorov's parents are still married or if he has any siblings. When Fyodorov was nine years old, the family moved to Essen,

[45] The allegations are made by Vera Markovich, Vika Kuchak, and Vika Mikhailova and discussed in Chapter 4. Markovich initially makes a statement in November 2021.

Germany, where his father took an academic position following the collapse of the Soviet Union. While the opportunity was beneficial for his father, the young Fyodorov met challenges in Germany. He reports having had issues with his classmates due to his inability to speak German and his "different views on life."[46] Other than these details, we know that a seminal moment in his life occurred in Essen: thirteen-year-old Miron Fyodorov was introduced to hip-hop music when he listened to The Fugees' 1996 album *The Score.*[47] Even with his limited understanding of English, Fyodorov felt drawn to the lyrics, and his fascination with hip hop took off from there.

In 2000, when Fyodorov was 15 years old, his family immigrated to the U.K., settling in Slough, a town thirty-two kilometers west of London. He has referred to Slough as "one of the most depressing places in the U.K." and "not a very pleasant place."[48] Nevertheless, it is in Slough that another pivotal moment occurs in Fyodorov's young life: he began to take his education seriously. His secondary school history teacher, an Oxford University alumna, encouraged Fyodorov to apply to Oxbridge.[49] He applied and was accepted to the University of Oxford in 2004. In an interview, he equates Oxford to the fictional Hogwarts School of Witchcraft and Wizardry, a place "completely out of" his world.[50] The juxtaposition of his life in Slough as an immigrant and state-school student and his perception of Oxford University are exacerbated by misconceptions. In a 2018 English language interview with Vlad "DJ Vlad"

---

[46] Andrei Britenkov, "Oksford nichevo ne dal, krome neskol'kikh depressivnykh let: Oksimiron ot Peterburga do Britanii i obratno" [Oxford didn't give anything, other than several depressive years: Oxxxymiron from St. Petersburg to Britain and back], *Saint-Petersburg.ru,* July 1, 2019. https://saint-petersburg.ru/m/culture/britenkov/371760/.

[47] Andrei Britenkov, "Oksford nichevo ne dal, krome neskol'kikh depressivnykh let: Oksimiron ot Peterburga do Britanii i obratno,"

[48] Vlad Lyubovny, (@DJVlad). *Oxxxymiron on Russian Hip Hop, Battle Rap, Dizaster, Putin (Full Interview*), February 21, 2018. 5:13-5:19, hxttps://www.youtube.com/watch?v=HLx2boiXAvY.

[49] "Oxbridge" is a common portmanteau of the U.K.'s top ranked universities, Oxford and Cambridge.

[50] Vlad Lyubovny, *Oxxxymiron on Russian Hip Hop, Battle Rap, Dizaster, Putin (Full Interview),* 5:21-5:28.

Lyubovny of *Vlad TV*, Fyodorov acknowledges that while he was "good enough" for acceptance, he cites stereotypes about Oxford that are tinged with self-consciousness about his personal admission to the university. The first is that, contrary to popular belief, Oxford is not more expensive than any other state college in the U.K., all of which have the same tuition rates for residents. The second is more personal: he was not admitted on merit alone but on his status as both an immigrant and a state-school student. He tells DJ Vlad that his admission was "50% my achievements, 50% affirmative action."[51] This exact minimization of his intellectual abilities, coupled with his detachment from Oxford, is evident in other public-facing interviews and his overall self-presentation.

Fyodorov enrolled at Oxford in 2004 and studied medieval literature at Balliol College, one of Oxford's oldest and most prestigious colleges.[52][53] His recounting of how he ended up studying medieval literature is threefold. He has publicly claimed to have chosen the major because he did well in English and felt that it was rare for Russians to study this literary period.[54] Moreover, he has specifically linked the decision to a broader curiosity, stating: "I think that came from the same place as my rap–I'm interested in words. But I don't have an academic mind at all."[55] While Fyodorov has joked that there is no nerdier course of study, he has also called the

---

[51]Vlad Lyubovny, Oxxxymiron on Russian Hip Hop, Battle Rap, Dizaster, Putin (Full Interview), 4:41-6:44.

[52] Iana Tsyptsyna, "More than punch lines and rhymes: Dizaster v Oxxxymiron," The Oxford Student, November 11, 2017, https://www.oxfordstudent.com/2017/11/11/punch-lines-rhymes-dizaster-v-oxxxymiron/

[53] There is debate about which college was founded first, but Balliol is one of three having been founded in the 13th century. Oxford, "History," https://www.ox.ac.uk/about/organisation/history.

[54] Alexander Gorbachev, "Oksimiron ob Oksforde, trave, ideologii, i problemah russkovo repa." [Oxxxymiron on Oxford, weed, ideology, and problems with Russian rap], Afisha Daily, https://daily.afisha.ru/archive/volna/archive/rusrap_oxxxymiron/.

[55] Shaun Walker, "The man who was raised in Slough and raps in Russian," The Independent, November 17, 2012, https://www.independent.co.uk/news/world/europe/the-man-who-was-raised-in-slough-and-raps-in-russia-8324127.html

major “pointless” and expressed regret in not attending the London School of Economics to study International Affairs instead.[56] Similar to his comment about not having an academic mind, Fyodorov has repeatedly stated that he learned nothing while at Oxford, adding that he reached “the height of his intellectual development between the ages of 14 and 16.”[57] Instead of learning, he claims to have spent most of his university time planning and attending social events for the Oxford Russian Society.[58] He ultimately graduated with a third-class degree in 2008, completing his requirements in four years, rather than the standard three.[59] Fyodorov took a year off from his undergraduate studies after he was diagnosed with manic depression. In one interview, he described taking a leave of absence, but in another, the interviewer states that Fyodorov was kicked out and forced to retake exams, and thus, re-enroll in Oxford.[60] Regardless of the classification of his time off from university, the nature of it is undisputed. While Fyodorov has doubted if manic depression,

Figure 3: Oxxxymiron's X (Twitter) post about his mental health. He refers to being diagnosed as "manic depressive" in the comments section.

[56] Alexander Gorbachev, “Oksimiron ob Oksforde, trave, ideologii, i problemah russkovo repa.” [Oxxxymiron on Oxford, weed, ideology, and problems with Russian rap].

[57] Alexander Gorbachev, “Oksimiron ob Oksforde, trave, ideologii, i problemah russkovo repa.” [Oxxxymiron on Oxford, weed, ideology, and problems with Russian rap].

[58] Alexander Gorbachev. “Оксимирон об Оксфорде, траве, идеологии, и проблемах русского рэпа.”

[59] A third-class degree is the lowest of the bachelor’s honors degrees offered by Oxford and reflects a weighted average of 40-49%.

[60] Shaun Walker. “The man who was raised in Slough and raps in Russian.”

now known as bipolar disorder, was an accurate diagnosis for his condition at the time, he has publicly documented his mental health struggles. He has acknowledged struggling with lifelong mood swings and alternating periods of feeling down or agitated in social media posts (see Fig.3).[61] His music has also referred to mental health disorders, such as the 2017 track "Биполярочка" ("Bipolar Disorder") and a line in 2021's "Хоп-Механика" ("Hop-Mechanics") that alludes to borderline personality disorder: "Перечеркни мои болезни, Демна Гвасалия" ("Strike out my illness, Demna Gvasalia.")[62] The song makes additional references, as do other tracks; one of these is at the center of a later dissertation chapter, which recounts Fyodorov's history over a period of time, including his psychological struggles at the height of his Russian rap career.

After graduation, Fyodorov moved to London, where he worked odd jobs. In a 2012 interview with Shaun Walker of *The Independent*, he describes living in London for four years after graduation, working just enough to pay his £275 rent in a council estate.[63] In another interview, conducted in 2016, he claims to have worked for three years before becoming unemployed for an additional two years while trying out London's open mic nights and performing in underground clubs as he formed his sound.[64] Despite the discrepancies between these descriptions, they both demonstrate that Fyodorov left Oxford without a professional plan

[61] Miron Fyodorov (@norimyxxxo), "Coping with extreme mood swings on a daily basis since '04. Two decades in the shut up your inner demons business. A brand you can trust. Me," X, January 1, 2016, 9:09 AM., https://x.com/norimyxxxo/status/684738671631822848

[62] This references the Georgian Fashion designer and current head of *Balenciaga*, Demna Gvasalia, who drew the cover for Russian rockstar Zemfira's 2021 album *Borderline*, a struck-through transliteration of the album title in Cyrillic.

[63] Shaun Walker. "The man who was raised in Slough and raps in Russian."

[64] Yana Davydova, "The Russian Rapper from the UK Suburbs Who Studied at Oxford," *Dazed,* September 6, 2016, https://www.dazeddigital.com/music/article/32690/1/oxxxymiron-russian-rap-interview.

or a concerted focus on his musical career. Yet, he still managed to develop the sounds and persona of Oxxxymiron between 2008 and 2012, before relocating to Russia and becoming a cultural sensation.

What is known about Miron Fyodorov is recycled information: leaving Russia as a child, living in Germany and the UK, discovering hip-hop, attending Oxford, and, less frequently, dealing with a mental health diagnosis. These points are connected in several ways to one another, but there is little else to draw connections to, and that is seemingly by design. It is Fyodorov's move in 2012 that initiates the Oxxxymiron persona as it is broadly recognized: a boastful, intellectual Russian rapper who becomes an instant classic. Developing that persona, however, takes years, and it begins with a different moniker.

1.4.2 A Limited Career Trajectory, from MC MiF to CEO

Fyodorov started rapping under the name MC MiF as a teenager. The moniker is comprised of the "Mi" from his first name (Мирон, Miron), and the "F" (Фёдоров, Fyodorov) from his last, together spelling out МиФ (MiF), which translates to "myth." The symbolism of the name "myth" is fitting for an artist who so intentionally curates his self-presentation and persona through personal mythology. MC MiF got his start in informal, after-school freestyle battles against his peers. At this time, he was convinced that he was the first person to rap in Russian; it was not until he turned fifteen that Fyodorov got Internet access and learned of Russia's existing rap industry.[65] He used the Internet to learn about the older generation of professional Russian rappers and a then-contemporary online Russophone rap community that

[65] Vlad Lyubovny (@DJVlad), Oxxxymiron on Russian Hip Hop, Battle Rap, Dizaster, Putin (Full Interview), 9:18-9:22.

interacted on forums like Hip-Hop.ru.[66][67] Fyodorov participated in online battles on various Russophone rap forums throughout the years. He describes these battles to DJ Vlad as such: participants would send pre-recorded tracks to be used against a random opponent, and successful participants would be judged and moved to a new round; the process, he states, could go on for years.[68] He implies that online battles were pivotal to growing his Russian rap career in another interview, telling Yana Davydova of *Dazed*: "I came forth out of about 3000 MCs in the largest Russian online battle at the time, and it gave me a lot of exposure – I even started doing concerts after that."[69] What is significant is that Fyodorov claims that his entry into these forums was a result of searching for like-minded friends, as he struggled making friends in person in both Germany and the U.K.[70] He utilized the web to engage in social interaction first and foremost; it is through the Internet that he found a sense of belonging.

By the time he was winning online battles, Fyodorov had begun using the stage name *Oxxxymiron.* Like his former moniker, the name incorporates several personal elements: the "Oxy" is taken from Oxford, the triple X symbolizes the explicit nature of his rap style, and Miron, the artist's first name, supplants the "moron" of "oxymoron." *Oxxxymiron* highlights two themes that are integral to Fyodorov's life: his elite education and his foreign (to Russia) upbringing. In the press, these facets of Fyodorov's biography are used to describe him as a

---

[66] Ivan "Noize MC" Alekseyev's entry into Russian rap predates Fyodorov's, but they are the same age.

[67] Andrei Britenkov, "Oksford nichevo ne dal, krome neskol'kikh depressivnykh let: Oksimiron ot Peterburga do Britanii i obratno."

[68] Vlad Lyubovny (@DJVlad), Oxxxymiron on Russian Hip Hop, Battle Rap, Dizaster, Putin (Full Interview 11:28-11:48.

[69] Yana Davydova, "The Russian Rapper from the UK Suburbs Who Studied at Oxford."

[70] Jim Taylor, "Oksimiron: 'Molodyh vse slozhnee zastavlyat' nenavidet.'" [Oxxxymiron: 'It's becoming harder to get the youth to hate'], *BBC News Russian,* February 12, 2018, https://www.bbc.com/russian/features-43023140.

unique artist and *the* oxymoron of the Russian rap world: an educated rapper! While his elite higher education is impressive in some circles, in others, namely in the battle rap arena, it becomes fodder for his opponents to define him as pretentious and out of touch. It is also a theme he discusses self-consciously, as exemplified in earlier cited interviews.

In 2008, Oxxxymiron first began performing at open mic sessions in London's underground club scene, where he was introduced to grime music. Grime is described as: "[…]an eclectic style of British rap music that emerged in London in the early 2000s. Evolving from the UK garage music scene of the 1990s in London, grime music also incorporates influences from hip-hop, rap, and hardcore techno. Grime music is characterized by fast beats, electronic sounds, UK accents, and frenetic energy;" the genre's quick speeds influence Oxxxymiron's rap style.[71][72] From 2008 to 2010, Oxxxymiron was signed to Optik Russia, a sub-label of the German record label Optik Records; he left Optik Russia in 2010 following the 2009 closure of Optik Records. It is with Optik Russia that he released his first track, "Лондон Против Всех" ("London Versus Everybody") and his first music video for the song "Я Хейтер" ("I'm a Hater") in 2008. The latter sets the tone for the early Oxxxymiron persona: an antagonist who disses other rappers. The song is comprised of an intro, two verses, and a chorus, which reads: "Я хейтер, я ненавижу ваш рэп, ваш трек, ваш текст/ Мягкий, как паштет/ Homie, это наш век! Каждый лошпед/ Осознает, что у него продаж нет/ Я хейтер, я ненавижу ваш флоу, ваш слог, ваш хоп/ Неважно, за что/ Homie, это наш год, до тебя дошло/ Oxxxymiron и Optik Russia в ваш рот" ("I'm a hater, I hate your rap, your track, your lyrics/ It's soft like pate/ Homie, it's our era! Every douche realizes he has no sales/ I'm a hater, I hate your flow, your style, your hop/ It

[71] Yana Davydova, "The Russian Rapper from the UK Suburbs Who Studied at Oxford."

[72] "Grime Music Guide: Understanding British Grime Music - 2025," MasterClass, June 21, 2021, https://www.masterclass.com/articles/grime-music-guide.

doesn't matter why/ Homie, it's our year/ Oxxxymiron and Optik Russia made it into your mouth.")[73] His rhymes are reminiscent of Vladimir Mayakovsky's. As S.G. Kusenko describes, "Маяковский стал несравненным мастером составной рифмы, рифмы, составленной из двух или трёх слов, расширив её смысловые возможности" ("Mayakovsky became an incomparable master of compound rhyme, rhymes composed of two or three words, expanding its semantic possibilities.") [74] An example of compound rhyme can be seen in the chorus of "I'm a Hater," more specifically the rhymes between "ваш текст," "паштет," and "наш век" as well as "ваш флоу,""за что," and "дошло." These rhymes are also instances of double rhymes, which are similar to but not synonymous with compound rhymes. In Russian rap, double rhymes are those that incorporate two sets of rhyming words at the end of two bars. For instance, "ваш текст"/"как паштет" and "наш век"/"продаж нет" would constitute double rhymes. These types of rhymes are inherent to American rap, but at the time that Oxxxymiron entered the scene, they were not as prevalent in Russian rap, so his usage of

Figure 4: An opening still frame from the "I'm a Hater" video.

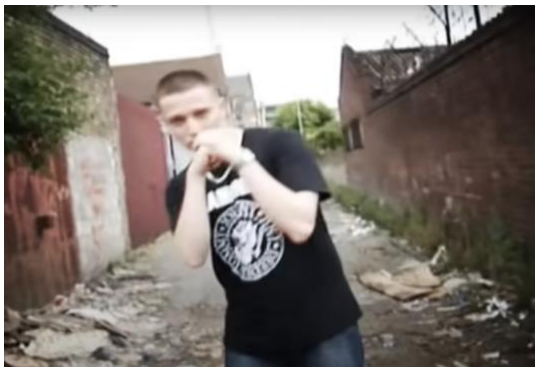


Figure 5: An opening still frame from the "I'm a Hater" video.

[73] Rusrapuk," Oxxxymiron – Ya Hejter." [Oxxxymiron – I'm a Hater], YouTube. August 22, 2008, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=t5x3Ke21hUA.

[74] S.G. Kusenko, "Funktsii rifmy v stikhe Mayakovskogo" *[The function of rhyme in the poetry of Mayakovsky], Intellectual Potential of the 21st century: Stages of Knowledge,* Vol. 8 (2011), 44-47, https://cyberleninka.ru/article/n/funktsii-rifmy-v-stihe-mayakovskogo/viewer

double rhymes distinguished him from his contemporaries.[75][76] Oxxxymiron has even said that his work, beginning in 2008, started a "new wave" of double rhyming in the Russian hip-hop scene.[77]

The "I'm a Hater" video also marks Oxxxymiron's public entrance into the Russian rap industry, and it is later featured on the 2012 album *MiXXXtape I* (2008-2011). Like the chorus, the video is full of rap cliches, including the juxtaposition of high-class interiors and a rough urban setting, drug use, and dancing women, among others (see Figs. 4 and 5)[78]. No longer an underground performer, Oxxxymiron comes to the scene with confidence in his rap skills and understanding of hip-hop culture, against the collective Russian hip-hop community. The video also served as a promotional tool, getting his name out to a larger audience.

It is during his time at Optik Russia that Fyodorov meets Dimitri "Schokk" Hinter, a more established Russophone rapper working in Germany. The two began collaborating in 2008, and Schokk's influence on Oxxxymiron's early output is apparent: Schokk's modus operandi was directly dissing Russian rappers and the community at large. After establishing himself in the Russophone hip-hop scene, Oxxxymiron first performed in Ukraine. Then, in 2010, he and Schokk toured countries of the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS) together, and later that year co-founded, with a third partner, an independent record label called *Vagabund* (wanderer, rover). The label released its first album, Oxxxymiron's debut, *Вечный Жид* (*The*

---

[75] A bar is also known as a "line" in rap.

[76] Yana Davydova, "The Russian Rapper from the UK Suburbs Who Studied at Oxford."

[77] Vlad Lyubovny (@DJVlad), *Oxxxymiron on Russian Hip Hop, Battle Rap, Dizaster, Putin (Full Interview*),13:40-14:00.

[78] Rusrapuk, "Oxxxymiron – Ya Hejter." [Oxxxymiron – I'm a Hater], YouTube, August 22, 2008, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=t5x3Ke21hUA

Wandering Jew), in September 2011.[79] Their tenure and friendship, however, were short-lived: Fyodorov left Vagabund in November 2011 due to a personal conflict with Hinter.[80] This conflict involves a public feud with Russian rapper Roman "Roma Zhigan" Chumakov, the handling of which puts Fyodorov and Hinter at odds; this feud and these relationships are covered in depth in Chapter 3.

Oxxxymiron relocated to Russia following his departure from Vagabund. It is this relocation that accelerated his rap career and his stardom; he was even recognized as *GQ Russia*'s Person of the Year for 2012.[81] Beginning in 2013, Oxxxymiron began performing in the *Versus Battle* League. This online a capella rap battle league was founded in that same year by Alexander "Ресторатор" Timartsev (Restorator, restaurateur) and was based in Fyodorov's hometown, St. Petersburg.[82] While not the first Russian rap battle league, Versus Battle became the most popular Russian league both domestically and internationally. Oxxxymiron is considered one of the best Russian battle rappers, though he only performed in five Versus battles between 2013 and 2017: Oxxxymiron v. Krip-a-Krip (2013), Oxxxymiron v. Dunya (2014), Oxxxymiron v. Johnyboy (2015), Oxxxymiron v. ST (2016), and Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS (2017). He also headlined a single battle in English, Oxxxymiron v. Dizaster (2017), hosted in Los Angeles, California by the pioneering battle rap league, *King of the Dot* (KOTD).[83]

---

[79] This album references the medieval folkloric character referred to as the wandering Jew; the album/term has also been translated as "The Eternal Jew."

[80] I use their last names, rather than stage names, as this was a personal conflict between the two men.

[81] Idov, Mikhail. "Otkrytie goda Oxxxymiron: 'Ya ne erudite, ya standartnyj intelligentishka." [Discovery of the year Oxxxymiron: 'I am not an erudite, but a standard intellectual]. GQ. October 11, 2012. https://www.gq.ru/heroes/otkrytie-goda-oxxxymiron-ya-ne-erudit-ya-standartnyj-intelligentishk

[82] I will refer to Versus Battle as "Versus" throughout. I will also use the transcription "Restorator" throughout.

[83] King of the Dot (KOTD) is a North American league, founded in Canada in 2008. Its events take place in both Canada and the United States, with competitors representing both countries.

In that battle, he competed against the Lebanese American veteran battle rapper Bashir "Dizaster" Yagami. In 2018, Oxxxymiron returned to Versus as a coach in the Fresh Blood league, providing mentorship to a group of novice battle rappers who competed against another group of novices coached by veteran rapper Alexander "Smoky Mo" Tsyhov.

Oxxxymiron's battles have amassed tens of millions of views on Versus' hosting platform, YouTube. The platform's free access model contributed to the league's massive viewership, which is what earned Oxxxymiron the recognition of being one of the most viewed battle rappers in the world; his battle against Johnyboy has the highest viewership of his career, with 59 million views as of March 1, 2023.[84] It was his 2017 battle against Vyacheslav "Slava KPSS" Mashnov, however, that transcended the hip-hop community and made Oxxxymiron a popular name amongst Russian public figures, intellectuals, and politicians, including the Russian opposition figure, anti-corruption advocate, and political activist, Alexey Navalny.[85] Coming at the height of his popularity, this battle puts Oxxxymiron in the spotlight with new and diverse collective publics. He becomes widely known as a masterful rapper whose texts are peppered with literary, historical, philosophical, and hip-hop-specific references that can require repeated listening and context knowledge. While performing intermittently on the Versus stage, Oxxxymiron released his most critically acclaimed album, *Gorgorod,* in 2015.[86] The album's release further propelled his fame, landing him domestic and international interviews, including a spot on Russia's leading late-night talk show, *Вечерний Ургант* (*Evening Urgant*). His overall

[84] TheWriterSam, "Is the World's Biggest Battle Rapper Now Oxxxymiron of Russia?, *The Source,* February 11, 2018, https://thesource.com/2018/02/11/is-the-worlds-biggest-battle-rapper-now-oxxxymiron-of-russia/.

[85] Alexey Navalny, "Pro battl Oksimirona i Gnojnovo." [About the battle between Oxxxymiron and Gnojny], Navalny Blog, August 14, 2017, https://navalny.com/p/5496/.

[86] This album is analyzed in discussed in Chapter 3.

success and popularity led to Oxxxymiron becoming the first *Reebok Classic* spokesperson in Russia in 2016.[87] He also embarked on his first stadium tour in 2017, which was titled the "Imperivm" tour, taking a name from the tattoo that once spread across Fyodorov's knuckles (see Figs. 6 and 7).[88] The concept of "empire" can be found in Oxxxymiron's track, "Что такое империя?" ("What is an Empire?"), released with an accompanying video in 2019, and then re-released in a 2021 mixtape[89]. In the song, Oxxxymiron concludes that an empire is the result of self-made dreams; it is ideas that manifest and come to fruition through hard work and "do it yourself" principles. These are characteristics he attribute to his own celebrity trajectory in Russia.

Figure 6: Oxxxymiron showing his "Imperivm" knuckle tattoos.

The Imperivm tour consisted of concerts across Russia and two international shows in Minsk, Belarus, and Kyiv, Ukraine. The tour's first concert took place in a sold-out venue, the 22,000-seat Olympic Stadium in Moscow. This feat became synonymous with his popularity at the time, as Yaroslav Zabalyev of Gazeta.ru notes in 2017: "В течение уходящего года рэпер Оксимирон из просто популярного

Figure 7: Pins depicting Oxxxymiron's knuckle tattoos. Sold by his official store "Oxxxyshop."

[87] Masha Bliznets, "Oxxxymiron stal litsom Reebok Classic (vnezapno)." [Oxxxymiron became the face of Reebok Classic (unexpectedly)], *GQ,* June 28, 2016, https://www.gq.ru/style/oxxxymiron-stal-licom-reebok-classic-vnezapno

[88] The Flow.ru, "Foto Dnya: Oksimiron zabil tatu 'Imperium' na pal'tsah." [Photo of the Day: Oxxxymiron tattoos 'Imperium' on his fists], *The Flow,* September 20, 2022, https://the-flow.ru/foto/foto-dnya-oksimiron-imperium.

[89] Miron Fyodorov, "Shto takoe imperia?" [What is an empire?], *miXXXtape III: Smutnoe Vremya [miXXXtape III: The Time of Troubles],* November 12. 2021, Spotify. The original video can be found here: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=t1TLjsIiT-8.

субкультурного артиста превратился в одно из главных действующих лиц русской жизни" ("In the course of the passing year, Oxxxymiron has transformed himself from simply a popular subcultural artist to one of the leading figures of Russian life.")[90] In 2017, in addition to the tour and rap battle against Slava KPSS, Fyodorov became the CEO of an independent record label, Booking Machine, and took on his first acting role in director Victor Ginzburg's film adaptation of Viktor Pelevin's *Empire V.*[91][92] Taking into account all of these creative and promotional endeavors, 2017 can indeed be considered the height of his popularity and influence on the Russian cultural scene.

Fyodorov's time at Booking Machine included expanding the artist roster and inaugurating the Booking Machine Festival, a joint concert of Booking Machine artists held in Moscow. Throughout his tenure, the label's artists publicly appeared as a close-knit group, with Oxxxymiron at the helm of interactions. He also appeared as a featured artist on others' tracks. In 2018, seven Booking Machine artists released a 9-minute single titled "Konstrukt," in which each artist raps a verse. Oxxxymiron begins his verse alluding to the label's exclusivity, rapping that one could gain access to the Bohemian Grove or an Illuminati ceremony more easily than one could become a Booking Machine artist.[93] He describes their crew as a "закрытый круг" (" a closed circle.")[94] These lines, and the whole of Oxxxymiron's verse, are indicative of the

---

[90] Yaroslav Zabalyev, "'Kak Mayakovskij:' Oskimiron spel pered revolyutsiej." ['Like Mayakovsky:' Oxxxymiron performed before a revolution], *Gazeta.ru*, November 7, 2017, https://www.gazeta.ru/culture/2017/11/06/a_10973264.shtml

[91] Mashnov performs as Slava KPSS, and under other monikers, in addition to Gnojny.

[92] These two endeavors were undertaken as Miron Fyodorov, but they were made because of Fyodorov's success as Oxxxymiron.

[93] The Bohemian Grove refers to a Northern California campground synonymous with the "old boys' club" attitude; rich and powerful men use the campground for gatherings with artistic, natural, and ritualistic elements and themes.

[94] The artists are May Wave$, Jeembo, Loqiemean, Thomas Mraz, Tveth, Souloud, Markul, and Oxxxymiron, with Oxxxymiron's longtime friend and producer Porchy contributing the opening verse.

exclusivity he honed as a stage and public persona: selective about interviews, public appearances, friends, and employees who began as friends. Despite the camaraderie and his success, Fyodorov retired from Booking Machine as CEO and artist in August 2019 while performing on the Booking Machine Festival stage.[95]

Oxxxymiron's career is marked by moments similar to his retirement from Booking Machine, including intentional retreat from the public, silence, and secrecy. The next stage in his career will counter that through the release of new singles and albums, alongside his development as a public figure who stands against Russian authoritarianism, censorship, and the War in Ukraine. As he becomes more politically outspoken, he becomes a more prominent public figure. It is precisely his outspokenness that elicits an unprecedented response with the power to shift Oxxxymiron's career trajectory: multiple women accuse Miron Fyodorov of sexual assault and grooming in March 2025.

As the following chapter covers, Oxxxymiron's swift rise is a result of his success in Russia's a capella battle rap scene. It is within the strictures of this genre that the Oxxxymiron persona is built, both by the artist himself and his opponents, whose role in the arena is to deconstruct and define him. In Chapter 2, I look at different aspects of battle rap personas to construct a narrative of self-presentation at the interconnection of text, physicality, and social interaction

[95] Miron Fyodorov (oxxxymironofficial), *P.S.*, YouTube, August 25, 2019, 3:22-3:35, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1FYOURWJxyE.

Chapter 2: On a Life of Conflict in the Battle Rap Arena

In October 2017, Oxxxymiron competed against Bashir "Dizaster" Yagami in one of North America's premier rap battle competitions: World Domination VII, a then-annual event hosted by Toronto-based league King of the Dot (KOTD) (see Fig. 8).[96] Dizaster is a prominent figure in the global battle rap community. He is one of KOTD's most prolific battler rappers, having competed in approximately 120 battles to date; he is known for his aggressive stage persona and shocking lyrics.[97] Comparatively, Oxxxymiron is touted as a viral rap sensation across the Russophone world. Despite having only competed in six career battles to date, Oxxxymiron has captivated broad Russian-speaking audiences for his literary and "high culture" laden performances.[98] How did two battlers with disparate experiences end up headlining one of battle rap's most significant events? The answer is their view counts, a mark of popularity and prestige.

Figure 8: A promotional poster for the Oxxxymiron v. Dizaster battle at World Domination VII.

[96] King Of The Dot Entertainment, "#WDVILA Official Flyer," Facebook, September 28, 2017, https://www.facebook.com/KOTDTV/posts/wdviila-official-flyerkotd-world-domination-7oxxxymiron-vs-dizasterday-1-will-be/10154896013616551/.

[97] VerseTracker, "Dizaster | Battle Rapper Profile," accessed August 1, 2025, https://versetracker.com/rapper/dizaster.

[98] This figure includes the battle versus Dizaster.

In KOTD's official promotional trailer for the event, Dizaster is shown breathing through a respirator mask, standing amidst smoke, and yielding a bladed weapon.[99] Oxxxymiron is then introduced by a distorted voiceover that announces: "Everybody talks about views, but nobody knows one of the highest viewed battle rappers isn't even American."[100] A video clip of the Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS battle, which took place a month before the KOTD trailer was released, is then shown with its staggering view number superimposed: 22 million.[101] The video received 10 million views overnight alone, and another 5 million over the following 48 hours.[102] To illustrate the magnitude of these numbers, Dizaster has approximately 82 million total views across 120 battles; that's an average of roughly 68,333 views per battle. While Dizaster's numbers seem low in comparison, they still make him one of the most viewed KOTD battlers of all time. In the trailer, the two are equated as "the highest viewed battlers in the world."[103]

Figure 9: Three successive still images from the Oxxxymiron v. Dizaster battle trailer.

[99] King of the Dot Entertainment, "*KOTD - #WDVIILA - Oxxxymiron vs Dizaster (Trailer) | #WDVII,*" YouTube, September 14, 2017, 01:40, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NxsU-JL-G9U.

[100] King of the Dot Entertainment, "*KOTD - #WDVIILA - Oxxxymiron vs Dizaster (Trailer) | #WDVII,*" 00:31-00:40.

[101] 22 million views were accurate at the time of the video's release. By September 2023 the number was at 57 million; Mardean Isaac, "The Rapper and the Foreign Agent," *News Line Magazine,* September 4, 2023, https://newlinesmag.com/review/the-rapper-and-the-foreign-agent/.

[102] Lenta.ru, "Kolichestvo Prosmotrov Battla Oksimirona I Gnojnovo Perevalilo Za 10 Millionov." [The Battle between Oxxxymiron and Gnojny has surpassed 10 million views], *Lenta.ru.* accessed August 15. 2017, https://lenta.ru/news/2017/08/15/ten_million/.

[103] King of the Dot Entertainment, "*KOTD - #WDVIILA - Oxxxymiron vs Dizaster (Trailer) | #WDVII,*" YouTube, September 14, 2017, 01:04-1:10, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NxsU-JL-G9U.

In contemporary battle rap, like in most Internet-based genres, a high view count is indicative of a battler's success, both as a lyricist and as a personality. The two are not mutually exclusive, in that a good lyricist can fail to entertain and captivate in a way that drives popularity and viewership. KOTD founder Travis "Organik" Fleetwood touches on this when speaking with *Vice* reporter Matt Williams, stating:

> These days, it's not just about your rapping skill, and I know that sounds so bad to say, but it's about being an entertainer and a public figure. When you look at boxing and wrestling and stuff like that, the thing that attracts people is entertainment. You could be an amazing rapper, but if you're not amazing outside of that rapping, fans aren't really gonna follow your social media or anything, they're just gonna watch your battles. So, you really wanna take advantage and be entertaining and understand all the aspects of battle rapping, from vocal projection to selling yourself as a character.[104]

Fleetwood equates "selling oneself as a character" with other learned skills, such as vocal projection, suggesting that it is not innate but rather something learned and practiced. Fleetwood also compares battle rap to wrestling, a physical but sensationalized sport that, in modern times, serves to entertain through narratives (storylines, characters, and preconstructed tensions). The implication is that battle rap does require lyrical skill, as wrestling involves physicality. Still, lyrical skill and entertainment are both learned and necessary for entertaining, which is the core function of the contemporary genre. Roland Barthes famously calls wrestling a *spectacle* in his essay "World of Wrestling," arguing that it serves to dispel reality through expectation. In the realm of spectacle, character types are useful devices in that they fulfill, or deceive, this expectation.[105] It is this background that allows me to interpret Fleetwood's comment on how persona drives entertainment.

---

[104] Williams, Matt. "Meet the Man Behind Drake's Favorite Battle Rap League, King of the Dot." Accessed August 1, 2025. https://www.vice.com/en/article/king-of-the-dot-organik-interview-kotd-ovo/.

[105] Roland Barthes. *Mythologies*.

Like wrestling, the subgenre of Russian a capella battle rap is also expectations-driven and rooted in predictability, with every battle representing the same form of verbal duel. Texts are pre-written, and while specific lyrics are unpredictable, animosity, disparagement, shock, calculated reactions, and other tactics are expected in the delivered texts. It is the battlers' approach to this predictability through their stage and online personas that elevates the spectacle. In this vein, this chapter offers a close reading of Oxxxymiron as a performed persona across six recorded battles: *Oxxxymiron v. Krip-a-Krip* (2013), *Oxxxymiron v. Dunya* (2014), *Oxxxymiron v. Johnyboy* (2015), *Oxxxymiron v. ST* (2016), *Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS* (2017), *and Oxxxymiron v. Dizaster* (2017). Most of these performances will be referenced to illustrate points relevant to the collective nature of persona creation. *The Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS* battle will be analyzed in depth, as it is demonstrative of how battle rappers exploit the strictures of the genre through the creative use of language and the deconstruction of their opponents.

To situate my analysis, this chapter begins with a brief literature review and a history of battle rap in the United States, starting with its predecessor, *the dozens,* and concluding with a short overview of the battle rap scene in the Russian context. Thus, the following section presents a selected scholarly history of battle rap, beginning with its roots in verbal games, continuing into the scholarship on identity building within hip hop, and ending with a history of Russian a cappella battle rap from approximately 2012 to 2019. It gives readers a sense of the works and ideas that influenced my conception of the Oxxxymiron battle rap persona subset.

2.1 On the Dozens as a Precursor to Battle Rap

Unlike hip hop, widely accepted to have originated in 1973 in the Bronx, New York, battle rap has an ambiguous beginning. Once an underground phenomenon, it became popularized in the early aughts by new media, from films like Curtis Hanson's *8 Mile* to

platforms like YouTube.[106] Alongside its cultural history, battle rap has scholarly origins beginning in the early 20th century. In scholarship old and new, battle rap is either studied as a linguistic or general sociological phenomenon related to race, racialization, class, masculinity, misogyny, or misogynoir. This scholarship begins with research on a so-called predecessor of battle rap; the African American linguistic game called *the dozens.*[107]

American psychologist John Dollard was the first to publish research about the dozens. He was introduced to the dozens while studying personality development in Black children. Noticing the game's significance in the communities he was studying, he began researching the game itself. Dollard's 1939 article titled "The Dozens: A Dialectic of Insult" opens with a description that reveals the game's essential components:

> I have seen a joking relationship arise between two friends in exactly this spontaneous way; indeed, these two men are noted for this behavior and provide much amusement to others in their particular circle. […] It is only by innuendos and indirect references that the forbidden subjects may be touched upon. A sally on the part of one calls for a retort, usually of a kind that would be most offensive if it were meant seriously. Both friends seem to have an unconscious perception and agreement on how far the joking may go. It does not touch upon actual weaknesses. It is done only when other persons are present. A playful attitude surrounds the whole affair, and it apparently gives great satisfaction to the participants. It is from such a behavioral ground that "the Dozens" springs.[108]

Dollard's categorization of the dozens as a "joking relationship" is integral to his conception of the game's function, but also to its enduring legacy. The idea being that both participants operate within the same conditions, understanding that what they say to one another is meant to be in

---

[106] Marshall "Eminem" Mathers plays the main character in *8 Mile*, which incorporates elements of his biography.

[107] By the 1950s, when other scholars are studying the practice, "the dozens," is outdated to its practitioners who instead call it sounding. Over the years it has also been referred to as signifying, burning, woofing, cracking, harping, and other terms. While scholars argue that these terms are not analogous and there is nuance between them, such as the relationship between participants (family members or acquaintances) and the regional distinction of participants, they are often used interchangeably. In this chapter, the game will be referred to as *the dozens*; the only exception to this is in direct quotes from sources who may call the game by a different name but refer to the same practice.

[108] John Dollard, "The Dozens: Dialect of Insult," *American Imago, vol.* 1, no. 1 (1939): 3–25. JSTOR.

good fun, no matter how insulting their words may be. Also of note are three other elements: two participants, a joking exchange of banter and insults, and the presence of an audience. These elements remain central to the practice as it evolves throughout the decades, including in its manifestation in contemporary battle rap.

The dozens is widely accepted to be a verbal practice of exchanging insults amongst friends, born in African American communities. While scholars have not come to a consensus about the origin of the dozens, or the name of the game itself, its racial and gendered components have been central to scholarship.[109] This begins when Dollard assigns the dozens a social function which aligns with what would later result in the frustration-aggression hypothesis. He insists that the game's social function is in being a "valve for aggression in a depressed group"; in his interpretation, the dozens is an outlet for African American men and boys to channel the frustration of the injustices they face in reality, which they are unable to release in other situations due to their social and political status in then-contemporary society.[110] Thus, the dozens meet two criteria for Dollard's hypothesis: the game causes frustration levels to be high and allows for social pressure against aggressive behavior to be weak. Playing the dozens is a means for African American men to release the pent-up frustration due to their social and political realities in a safe environment.

What Dollard initiates is a body of scholarship that revisits the social function, or functions, of the dozens of times and again. Other notable scholars who wrote on the dozens include Roger Abrahams, whose 1962 article reframes the game's function through a linguistic

---

[109] Chapter 2, "The Name of the Game," of Elijah Wald's *The Dozens: A History of Rap's* Mama offers a comprehensive summary of the proposed origins of the term "the dozens." Wald begins by acknowledging that there is no solid evidence of the term's origins partially due to African Americans' need to persevere history orally rather than in writing.

[110] John Dollard, "The Dozens," 22.

analysis of devices its practitioners use: playing, sounding, and signifying, and Harry Lefever, who posits that the dozens are a non-violent mechanism for social control. He writes that: "…it is a survival technique, a protective device against being victimized."[111][112] Other scholars wrote about white communities' engagement with the dozens, such as Millicent Ayoub and Stephen Barnett, Bruce Jackson, and Simon Bronner.[113] Much of the scholarship on the dozens through the 1990s elucidates the game's origins, disputes its psychosocial function, or analyzes its ritualized character in various communities. It is essentially studied as a sociological phenomenon that gives insights into social interaction, broadly speaking.

Nevertheless, there exists a later body that recognizes the lineage between the dozens and hip hop. Elijah Wald's *The Dozens: A History of Rap's Mama* (2012*)* is perhaps the most comprehensive and straightforward study of the dozens. In his book, Wald discusses the history and discourses surrounding the dozens and contextualizes the practice in different time periods, geographical regions (in the United States and, at times, globally), and both racial and interracial communities. He seamlessly moves between scholarly interpretations of the term *the dozens* to its generational reincarnations through *yo mama* jokes, battle rap, and hip hop at large. By placing these practices in conversation, Wald demonstrates the continuity of form and condition from the dozens through battle rap, as seen in the number of participants, the presence of an audience, and the joking manner. It is this continuity that forms the genre's strictures, requiring

---

[111] Harry G. Lefever, "'Playing the Dozens': A Mechanism for Social Control," *Phylon , vol.* 42, no. 1 (1981): 73–85, https://doi.org/10.2307/274886.

[112] Roger Abrahams 1962 article is titled "Playing the Dozens."

[113] Ayoub and Barnett published "Ritualized Verbal Insult in White High School Culture" in 1965 to much criticism; Bruce Jackson penned a public response in 1966 titled "White Dozens and Bad Sociology." Simon Bronner reignites the topic in 1978 with his article "A Re-Examination of Dozens among white American Adolescents."

participants to perform within its confines, but to do so in a unique way. That is the paradox of the genre: staying within the boundaries while you surpass them.

To be clear, Wald does not claim a direct lineage from the dozens and rap in the sense that the latter becomes the former. Indeed, he makes a clear distinction between the two, as the dozens is still practiced today. What he does, however, is demonstrate how the dozens influence the contemporary hip hop practices of public feuding and battling. Public feuds are commonly known as "rap beefs." They are personal situations between individuals, such as accusations, that are made and reciprocated in the public sphere (in performances, tracks, interviews, and the like) and are then publicly reciprocated. For instance, in the chapter titled "Rapping, Snapping, and Battling" Wald describes how the rap group N.W.A. dissed former member, O'Shea "Ice Cube" Jackson, for leaving the group by releasing a skit titled "Message to B.A." (Benedict Arnold); Ice Cube responds with "No Vaseline," which, among outrageous accusations, also includes a threat to lynch his former groupmates. [114] Wald cites an interview with Jackson in which he states that his threats are not literal, it's just part of the dozens, which his former groupmates will understand.[115] Rap beefs can be taken personally; however, demonstrating that one or both parties have moved beyond the joking relationship and have taken physical or other actions to demonstrate their displeasure. A timely example of this is the public feud between rappers Kendrick Lamar and Drake. Drake made the situation personal when he filed a defamation lawsuit against Lamar and Universal Music Group after the release of "Not Like Us" (May 4, 2024), Lamar's track that accuses Drake of being a pedophile.[116]

---

[114] Elijah Wald, *The Dozens: A History of Rap's Mama,* (Oxford University Press, 2012), 187.

[115] Elijah Wald, *The Dozens,* 188.

[116] Sidney Madden, "New Drake Lawsuit Claims His Label Pushed 'Not Like Us' Diss to Defame Him," *NPR*, January 15, 2025, https://www.npr.org/2025/01/15/g-s1-42924/drake-umg-defamation-lawsuit-not-like-us.

The other practice that Wald attributes to the dozens is battle rapping. He writes that rap battles first appeared in live performances as a form of skill exchange to entertain or sway a crowd but later morphed into a performance in their own right. Like other scholars, he cites a 1981 recorded exchange between New York rappers Mohandas "Kool Moe Dee" Dewese and David James "Busy Bee Starski" Parker as the starting point of what is known as battle rap. This is considered the first recorded rap battle, and it made an immediate and lasting impact on hip hop at large. Copies of the recording were shared throughout New York and as a result "(…) freestyle battling became a basic measure of rap skill, not only onstage but in parks and schoolyards."[117] Although the genre of battle rap remained largely underground, the *practice* became essential for aspiring rappers. Thus, Wald highlights that battling is a skill that is learned and practiced, something that Dr. Jooyoung Lee elaborates in his 2016 book *Blowin Up: Rap Dreams in South Central* (2016).

In *Blowin' Up: Rap Dreams in South Central,* Lee provides a comprehensive description of the practices and terms related to battle rapping that are pertinent to this chapter. Specifically, these include rocking the mic, freestyling, and prewriting. At the center of it all is freestyling, what Lee defines as "the ability to improvise rhymes."[118] He describes how freestylers are made through rhyming practice; of the rappers Lee spoke with, some practiced rhyming by studying the dictionary, others rhymed mentally and orally throughout their days, riffing off workplace conversations.[119] As improvisors, freestylers utilize practice rhymes to engage in ciphers or

[117] Elijah Wald, *The Dozens*, 195-196

[118] Jooyoung Lee, *Blowin' up: Rap Dreams in South Central* (The University of Chicago Press, 2016), 75.

[119] Jooyoung Lee, *Blowin' up,* 78-81

battles over a musical beat.[120] This is markedly different from prewriting rhymes; freestyling means showcasing your lyrical repository, whereas prewriting is the equivalent of writing and performing a script. In the world of freestyling, prewriting rhymes is considered fraudulent.[121] Lee writes: "But by the rules of the scene, rappers who use their prewritten rhymes indiscriminately run the risk of being called out for spitting writtens. It's one of the graver accusations in the scene, exposing cracks in rappers' lyricism and self-presentation."[122] The difference between free styling and prewriting is an important distinction between the underground rap battles dominant in the early 1990s and 2000s and the social-media-driven battles that appear in 2008 and beyond.

Lee's study focuses on *Project Blowed*, an open-mic workshop in South Central Los Angeles. The workshop teaches rappers how to properly hold a microphone so they can project clearly; rocking the mic, in literal terms, means holding the mic. Many come to the workshop having performed in ciphers or other informal venues rather than on stages, so they require training in microphone usage. In figurative terms, rocking the mic means performing well: it's the whole process of projection, breath control, rapping to the beat, and crowd work. In battle rap, if there are issues with the crowd hearing you and receiving your lyrics, then you're failing to entertain and captivate an audience. The audience's reaction to a rapper's work is a measure of their success or failure in a battle, so the emcee's focus should be on working the audience. What Lee's work elucidates is that *naturally having* a stage presence is a misconception; it is not

---

[120] Ciphers are communal freestyle sessions in which multiple participants take turns freestyling and riffing off one another, rather than competing. Ciphers offer a way to practice one's rhyming and lyricism and to stay up to date on others' skills.

[121] Some use of prewritten rhymes is tolerated. For instance, it is accepted to sparingly reuse rhymes around different rappers in different ciphers or to creatively employ the prewritten rhyme in a way that conceals its original usage.

[122] Jooyoung Lee, *Blowin' up*, 89.

something innate, it is learned and practiced. This notion is central to developing a persona in later pre-written battle rap culture.

Together with co-authors H. Samy Alim and Lauren Mason Carris, Lee published an article titled: "'Short Fried-Rice-Eating Chinese MCs' and "' Good-Hair-Havin Uncle Tom Niggas': Performing Race and Ethnicity in Freestyle Rap Battles."[123] In it, the authors argue that battle rappers "perform the Other" using dominant language ideologies and racial and ethnic stereotypes.[124] They intentionally move beyond what they call the "black-white racial binary" to examine how Blackness, Asianness, and Latinidad are formed in rap battles by Black emcees. For instance, they analyze the language and gestures used by the Black emcee "Flawliss" against a Filipino American emcee, a Latino emcee, and other Black emcees.[125] They cite his use of stereotypes, encompassing physical features and professions, and colorist language as ways in which he styles the Other. Their examples illuminate stereotypes in battle rap beyond their surface usage, giving nuance to the topic of Black stereotypes used by both Black and non-Black artists. Through these examples, the authors argue that race and races are "created and contested in interaction." [126] In other words, battle rap is a performance that allows its participants to both create and negotiate social meaning. This point is integral to understanding this dissertation chapter, in which I discuss how specific tropes and language are used to define battlers' personas.

---

[123] H. Samy Ali, Jooyoung Lee, and Lauren Mason Carris., "'Short Fried-Rice-Eating Chinese MCs' and 'Good-Hair-Havin Uncle Tom Niggas': Performing Race and Ethnicity in Freestyle Rap Battles," *Journal of Linguistic Anthropology* 20, no. 1 (2010): 116–33, https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1548-1395.2010.01052.

[124] Alim et al., "'Short Fried-Rice-Eating Chinese MCs' and 'Good-Hair-Havin Uncle Tom Niggas,'" 119.

[125] Flawliss is one of the rappers whom Jooyoung Lee studies at Project Blowed.

[126] Alim et al., "'Short Fried-Rice-Eating Chinese MCs' and 'Good-Hair-Havin Uncle Tom Niggas,'" 128.

In the early 1990s, through the early 2000s, underground freestyling was the predominant method of battle rapping globally. This changes when social media and similar promotional platforms enter the scene (Web 2.0). Not only were rappers able to promote themselves on these platforms, but they also joined newly formed online battle leagues like King of the Dot.[127] Thus, the preeminence of prewritten, or a capella battles, begins. This transition is not exclusive to the American hip hop scene, as the same process occurs in the Russian context, albeit later. The following section briefly recounts Russia's history with battle rap, with a focus on the *Versus Battle* League.

2.2 On Battle Rap's Beginnings in the Russian Context

Like other hip-hop genres, battle rap has subgenres that differ in style and form. The main subgenres represented in Russophone hip hop culture are freestyle and a capella.[128] Freestyle battles are those in which rappers improvise lyrics over a musical beat. In contrast, a capella battles are those in which rappers deliver pre-written and memorized lyrics without musical accompaniment. Both subgenres took hold in Russia in the early 2000s, with freestyle battles remaining more of an underground "street" phenomenon and a capella battles rising to cultural prominence with the development of technological capabilities in Web 2.0.

The first venue for Russophone a capella battle rap was the abstract space of the Internet. These so-called "online battles" appeared in the early 2000s through websites like Hip-Hop.ru. In those battles, participants were asked to submit audio recordings on a specific topic; two

[127] Jooyoung Lee, *Blowin' up,* 220.

[128] Lee uses "prewritten" to describe these types of battles but Russian artists, such as Oxxxymiron, refer to them as "a capella" so this is the term I will use throughout.

rappers were then paired in a battle using these recordings as their performances. According to journalist Denis Balin, twenty-one rappers participated in the first Hip-Hop.ru battle; that number increased to the thousands as the years went on.[129] Some of Russia's most famous rappers, like Ivan "Noize MC" Alexeiv, Nikita "St1m" Legostev, and Oxxxymiron, were frequent participants in online battles. Some rappers also participated in informal freestyle battles, but it is a capella battle rap that flourishes in Russia. While speaking to DJ Vlad, Oxxxymiron says that a capella battle rap was the next logical step to freestyle battles, which he calls "repetitive and boring […] the same old shit."[130] For Fyodorov, a cappella battles were "way more entertaining 'cause you could literally deconstruct the opponent in advance."[131] Whereas freestyle battles showcase one's ability to "rhyme" impromptu, a capella battles demonstrate a performative dynamism: an artist's ability to critique their opponent's public persona through skilled rhyming and performance. Performers are given time to "research" their opponents–they skim social media pages, listen to earlier performances, and ultimately create new identities for their opponents, to insult them in front of a live audience as if they were doing so spontaneously. For a capella battles to be successful, battlers must do their research on their opponent, and then they must memorize their texts. But to truly entertain, they must engage in a performance that balances their own stage personas with their opponent's deconstruction.

In 2012, the first a capella battle rap forum appeared in Russia. The first Russian video-based battle rap league, SLOVO, was founded in 2012 in Krasnodar, Russia, by Anton "Mr.

---

[129] Denis Balin, "Battl-Rep Umer i Vot Pochemu: 5 Faktov o Smerti Zhanra." [Battle-Rap Died and This is Why: 5 Facts about the Death of the Genre], *5 T,* August 7, 2021, https://www.5-tv.ru/tabloid/286452/battl-rep-umer-ivot-pocemu-5-faktov-osmerti-zanra-21-1/.

[130] Vlad Lyubovny, *Oxxxymiron on Russian Hip Hop, Battle Rap, Dizaster, Putin (Full Interview*), 12:15-12:20.

[131] Vlad Lyubovny, *Oxxxymiron on Russian Hip Hop, Battle Rap, Dizaster, Putin (Full Interview)*, 12:25-12:31.

Hyde" Belogai and Sergei "PLC" Truschev.[132] It quickly expanded to include regional leagues in cities across Russia, including St. Petersburg. The St. Petersburg affiliate, SLOVO SPB, became the main competitor of what would become Russia's most famous battle league, Versus Battle, hosted in the same city.[133] Established in 2013, Versus is the project of Alexander "Restorator" Timartsev and Yan Oktov (see Fig. 10).[134] When speaking with DJ Vlad, Oxxxymiron suggests that he had a hand in bringing Versus to life, as he describes discovering a capella battle rap on YouTube in 2006 or 2007, he says: "I was kind of obsessed with the idea of having something like that in Russia as well. And, you know, it took me about five, six years to convince someone to, you know, give it a go. Umm, and yeah, one of the people that I was talking to was Restorator, who is now running Versus."[135] Whether Oxxxymiron was involved in bringing the genre to Russia is not of importance in terms of the league's existence. Instead, what his claim signifies is his own perceived instrumentality and connection to the genre even before its existence in the Russian context; it demonstrates a supposed actualization of a capella battle rap's origin alongside Oxxxymiron's battle career. That

Figure 10: An image of Alexander "Restorator" Timartsev.

[132] "Slovo" is the transliteration of "слово" which means "word" in Russian.

[133] It is colloquially known as "Versus" and will be referred to as such throughout.

[134] Genius, "Restorator," https://genius.com/artists/Restorator.

[135] Vlad Lyubovny, *Oxxxymiron on Russian Hip Hop, Battle Rap, Dizaster, Putin (Full Interview*), 12:32-12:49

is, he self-styles a myth that he is inexorably linked to Versus before the project is even launched.

Western leagues inspired Versus Don't Flop, founded by Rowan "Eurgh" Faife and Freddie "Cruger" Scott-Miller in the U.K., and King of the Dot (KOTD), launched in Toronto by Organik, both in 2008. The leagues' battles are similarly laid out, with the opponents standing face-to-face amongst the judges and audience members while the performance is recorded for dissemination on the Internet or other forums.[136] Battles are split into three rounds, and the competition is judged after the final round. In each league, battlers are amongst a crowd, though their placement is slightly different. Finally, each league records its battles and disseminates them on various platforms; Versus was exclusively hosted on YouTube.

League names are also a point of interest, in that they express varying values in their monikers; they allow leagues to convey a specific ethos. The name *KOTD* represents the eventual winner, someone who accomplishes dominating in the digital space in its use of the words "king" and "dot" (for "dot com"). Contrastingly, *Don't Flop* is a warning to all participants against delivering a bad performance (or "flopping"). In terms of Russian leagues, *Slovo* emphasizes the spoken word; *Versus Battle,* however, indicates confrontation, with the preposition *versus* meaning "against," as in one subject against another, and "battle" presupposing aggression. In other words, the name Versus Battle indicates competition, wherein two personalities confront one another; it is not the result that matters, but the conflict itself, the performance of persona deconstruction between two opposing sides. It is less collective than the other league titles, which both relate to all participants: anyone can become king of the dot, as

[136] Some KOTD battles first premiere on PayPerView before they are uploaded to the KOTD YouTube page.

much as anyone can poorly perform. Contrastingly, Versus can only highlight oppositional forces; a point that will be analyzed alongside other aspects in the following section.

2.3 On the Feigned Intimacy of the Versus Battle Arena

At the start of a Versus rap battle, the opponents and judges are introduced. Then, the opponents deliver their texts in three staggered rounds, with each battle rapper performing their first, second, and third rounds respectively. Ultimately, both are judged by a panel of three to five hip-hop insiders – rap journalists, bloggers, comedians, and other rappers – who crown one battle winner. There is no prize or advancement to another battle or championship; the winner simply wins. While the winner is a surprise, most aspects of these battles, from the location, structure, audience, and battlers, are predetermined. Restorator, the league's host, even has a catchphrase that audiences can expect at the start of a battle: "Пошумим блядь!" ("Make some fucking noise!") Though the texts themselves are not available to audiences in advance, they are known to be pre-written, so they lack the element of surprise found in freestyle battles. It is in this controlled environment that spontaneity is feigned in the Versus arena.

One of the most significant paradoxes of Russian battle rap lies in its incompatible exclusivity and virality. Versus battles generate an attitude that their world is simultaneously attainable and unattainable. Most of the league's battles take place in a St. Petersburg Bar *1703,* and audience members must be invited to attend.[137] Taping sessions can be long, and audiences are restricted from specific actions so as not to impede production; parts of performances are often repeated and rerecorded to make up for issues such as performers forgetting their lyrics.[138]

---

[137] Yuri Dud (@вДудь), "Restorator – Ob Oksimirone, Tsenzure I Bable." [Restaurateur – About Oxxxymiron, Censorship, and Money], YouTube, March 7, 2017, 20:03-20:20, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=baLHI-u8h5g.

[138] Yuri Dud (@вДудь), "Restorator – Ob Oksimirone, Tsenzure I Bable," 22:26-23:14.

While a dress code does not appear to be in place, the homogeneity of the audience is visible, as YouTube host Yuri Dud notes that watching a battle is the first time he encountered this type of "жанр зрителей" ("genre of viewers"): "чуваки, которые такие модные одеты в рэп стиле" (dudes who are fashionably dressed in the rap style).[139] Dud's comments highlight the collective aspect of self-presentation in the genre, where the in-person audience serves as a model micro-public for the virtual viewer, as if to demonstrate what a battle rap fan should look like. This also speaks to the collective nature of self-presentation: the visuals of the in-person audience contribute to virtual audiences' perceptions of the genre and thus the performers. Restorator claims that a battle is a "тусовка" (tusovka, informal party) which colloquially means a group of people who share a common interest, unlike a studio audience if the battles were to be hosted on television.[140] He goes so far as to call the idea of a television audience "искусственно" ("artificial"), ignoring his own comments about how Versus' audience is controlled in various ways.

Through Restorator and Dud's conversation, the description of Versus battles becomes contradictory: the crowd is exclusive and unique but homogenous and curated; a battle is a spontaneous party that is staged, recorded, and re-recorded when needed; and battlers are supported in their free speech but also censored by the league's administrators.[141] Moreover, the battles themselves have a predictable format, deriving from the Western leagues they emulate. Participants are either invited by the league organizers or called out by another battler. When two opponents are paired, they study one another – their opponent's previous battles, other music (if

[139] Yuri Dud (@вДудь), "Restorator – Ob Oksimirone, Tsenzure I Bable," 20:41-20:49.

[140] Yuri Dud (@вДудь), "Restorator – Ob Oksimirone, Tsenzure I Bable," 26:20-26.40.

[141] Yuri Dud (@вДудь), "Restorator – Ob Oksimirone, Tsenzure I Bable," 26:50-27:39.

they are recording artists), social media output, and other information they acquired publicly or through private means – and they use this information to write insulting texts against their opponent to entertain a crowd. This research and writing are done in advance of a battle, which can be months or weeks. Due to the genre's predictable format, battle rappers must impress the crowds with their personal performances to both differentiate themselves and make the battle a success. All these predetermined and closely controlled factors accentuate the league's paradoxical nature: elements must fit in for performance, and performers must stand out. To put it in Goffman's terms, the frontstage must be static for the characters to stand out.

Ultimately, one can argue that Versus does fulfill its goal of successfully entertaining audiences, in that approximately 92.3% of Russians between the ages of 14 and 25 followed Russian rap battles through 2018.[142] Another source writes that a media analysis firm reports that battle rap has been the focus of two thousand publications between December 2016 and December 2017.[143] Oxxxymiron was Versus' indisputable star, as evidenced in the views his battles garnered; at one point, his battles were the most viewed in the world.[144] The first battle that indicated how successful both Oxxxymiron and Versus would be was *Oxxxymiron v. Johnyboy* (2015); this battle amassed over 1 million views overnight and, as of April 2023, had a total of 60 million views, making it the most viewed rap battle on YouTube.[145] In just two years,

---

[142] Denis Balin, "Battl-Rep Umer i Vot Pochemu: 5 Faktov o Smerti Zhanra."

[143] Newsru, "Battl reperov Oxxxymiron i Gnojnovo stal nastoyashim sobytiem ne tol'ko dlya sotssetej, no i dlya traditsionnyh SMI." [The battle between rappers Oxxxymiron and Gnojny became a real event not only on social media, but also in traditional mass media], *NEWSru.com*, August 15, 2017, https://www.newsru.com/russia/15aug2017/recordbattle.html.

[144] TheWriterSam, "Is the World's Biggest Battle Rapper Now Oxxxymiron of Russia?."

[145] The Flow.ru,"Battl Oxxxymiron i Johnyboy Za Sutki Nabral Million Prosmotrov / Novosti." [Battle between Oxxxymiron and Johnyboy gets over one million views in 24 hours / news], *The Flow.ru*, April 14, 2015, https://the-flow.ru/news/versus-battle-oxxxymiron-johnyboy-nifiga-sebe.

another battle recorded over 13 million views in three days: 2017's viral *Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS (Gnojny);* over eight hundred of the two thousand aforementioned publications were dedicated to this battle alone.[146]

Understanding the popularity of rap battles in the Russian context, as well as their paradoxical nature, is essential to framing Oxxxymiron's self-presentation in the battle rap arena. After all, it is in the confines of a staged, pre-written battle that Oxxxymiron establishes a unique rap battle persona that captivates Russophone audiences. In the following sections, I demonstrate how he functions within the battle arena, from his use of camera work to other performative tactics, paying particular attention to the contrasting verbal strategies of self-presentation within battle performances: what I describe as *offensive* and *defensive*.

2.4 On Gimmicks and Crowd Work in Battle Performances

Three of Oxxxymiron's six battles took place in the 1703 bar in St. Petersburg; a battle cohosted by the Slovo league took place elsewhere but is included in this discussion (see Fig.

Figure 11: An image of the 1703 bar, with a mural of Peter I on the facade.

[146] Newsru, "Battl reperov Oxxxymiron i Gnojnovo stal nastoyashim sobytiem ne tol'ko dlya sotssetej, no i dlya traditsionnyh SMI."

11).[147][148] His battle against Dunya was held on stage at a concert hall (billed as a special "Main Event" battle). The Dizaster battle was held in a venue in Los Angeles, where the battlers looked to be slightly elevated compared to the crowd. In what I will refer to as the "1703 battles," he is hyperaware of the social aspect of performance, such as working the crowd and the camera. These and related performative elements demonstrate how he uses the physical space of the arena as a method of impression management regarding his battle rap persona.

Each of the 1703 battles begins with the rappers introducing themselves to the camera before joining the gathered crowd. In each of his four introductions, Oxxxymiron is asked to introduce himself, describe his opponent, and explain how the battle was set up. There are slight differences in his language, but the general tone is serious; even when he makes jokes, he delivers them deadpan. For instance, in the Krip-a- Krip battle video, he introduces himself as "Меня зовут Oxxxymiron и я алкоголик" ("My name is Oxxxymiron, and I'm an alcoholic") with a stern face, as if he were attending an addiction support meeting (there is laughter in the background from a person who is not on camera).[149] Contrastingly, he introduces himself using the formal patronymic, first name, surname format: "Янович, Мирон Фёдоров aka Oxxxymiron" ("Yanovich, Miron Fyodorov") in the Johnboy battle, but when asked "Кто ваш оппонент?" ("Who is your opponent?") he replies, "печалька" (pechal'ka).[150] This word is the

[147] Figure 10: Ian I. "1703, Bar, Pub, Saint Petersburg, Ligovskiy Avenue, 50П," *Yandex Maps,* accessed August 6, 2025, https://yandex.com/maps/org/1703/1853235568/.

[148] 1703 is the year that St. Petersburg was founded. The bar is located on 50 K 3 Ligovsky Prospekt.

[149]VersusBattleRu, "Versus #3 (sezon I): Oxxxymiron VS Krip-a-Krip," [Versus #3 (season I): Oxxxymiron VS Krip-a-Krip],YouTube, September 14, 2013, 00:07-00:09, (page no longer available; copy of original in author's possession).

[150] VersusBattleRu,"Versus #1 (sezon III): Oxxxymiron VS Johnyboy." [Versus #1 (season III): Oxxxymiron VS Johnyboy], YouTube, April 12, 2015, 00:11-00:17, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MVouMFKmaeI, (page no longer available; copy of original in author's possession)

diminutive of печаль (pechal'), which means "sorrow." Rather than name his opponent, he uses the term "little sorrow" instead, alluding to his perception of Johnyboy's persona. In his introduction for the ST battle, he calls his opponent "человек который самоутверждался за счёт несчастного Филиппа Киркорова в «Давай до свидания», ведёт передачу на Black Star радио, короче занимается всем тем, что бы я не пожелал и врагу" ("A person who asserted himself at the expense of poor Philip Kirkorov in 'Let's Say Goodbye,' hosts a show on Black Star radio, and to put it simply, does everything that I wouldn't wish on an enemy.")[151] This description relates ST to the general ethos of his label, Black Star Records, headed by patriotic rapper Timur "Timati" Yunusov. Oxxxymiron rejects ST's persona vis-à-vis his association with Black Star (made through the references) without even naming him. Despite this insult, he does give ST credit later, saying that he has competed in two battles, whereas some others who have called him out are basically nobodies. It is through these introductions that Oxxxymiron lays out his approach for the battle, such as whether he will afford his opponent any respect. The introductions are the virtual audience's first glimpse into the battlers' stage personas, both through their self-presentation and the presentation of their opponents.

As for other performative elements, Oxxxymiron occasionally engages in prop work. In his battle against Dunya, he pulls a mirror out and puts it in front of his opponent as he raps: "Эй, Дуня, зачем искать того, кто проебет?/ Сейчас он смотрит тебе в глаза" ("Hey Dunya, why seek that which will fuck you up?/ He's looking in your eyes right now.")[152] Similarly, after saying "давай баттл по фактам" ("let's battle by fact"), he pulls out a manila envelope of

[151]VersusBattleRu, "Versus #5 (sezon III): Oxxxymiron VS ST." [Versus #5 (season III): Oxxxymiron VS ST]. YouTube, June 19, 2016, 01:17-01:29, (page no longer available; copy of original in author's possession).

[152]VersusBattleRu, "Versus Main Event #1 (sezon 2): Oxxxymiron VS Dunya." [Versus Main Event #1 (season 2): Oxxxymiron VS Dunya], YouTube, April 15, 2014, 40:06, (page no longer available; copy of original in author's possession).

“evidence” that he threatens will reveal the details of Slava KPSS’s sexual relationship with a man who looks like a “typical transgender person” in Thailand.[153] When a battler incites a “battle by facts” as Oxxxymiron does, he indicates that he will bring up “real” information from his opponent’s life. This trope, however, is paradoxical. When it is used, it implies the coming of a sensational or distorted scenario that simply cannot be taken as fact – whether it conveys facts or not. While Oxxxymiron’s first stunt garners a positive reaction from the crowd as it is used to complete and dynamize a punchline, the second one is met with silence, even though Oxxxymiron directly addresses the in-person audience to ask for witnesses. These divergent reactions are examples of impression management, moments when Oxxxymiron receives a direct response from the crowd based on his performance, which he must then overcome or exceed in subsequent sections.

Perhaps the most memorable and most successful of Oxxxymiron’s prop related actions occurs in his battle against Johnyboy. Throughout the battle, Oxxxymiron wears a large white bandage on his neck. In his third round, he looks directly at Johnyboy and raps:

> Да ты сам посмотри, бар с названием каким: тут не просто трактир, а семья
> Может, ты и вынесешь меня из 1703, но не 1703 из меня
> Один семь ноль три, Один семь ноль три – это Питер, детка, и мне якорь иной здесь не нужен
> Эмигрировал мелким, не жил двадцать лет тут, но я коренной петербуржец
> Ну а ты лимита тут, ведь ты – имитатор[154]
>
> Look for yourself, what’s the name of the bar? It’s not just a pub, it’s a family.
> Maybe you can take me out of 1703, but you can’t take 1703 out of me.
> 1-7-0-3, 1-7-0-3, that’s Peter baby, and I don’t need another anchor,
> I emigrated young, didn’t live here for 20 years, but I’m a native Peterburger.

---

[153] VersusBattleRu, “Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Slava KPSS (Gnojny).” YouTube. August 13, 2017, 1:04:16, https://www.YouTube.com/watch?v=v4rvTMBCJD0, (page no longer available; copy of original in author's possession).

[154] VersusBattleRu,“Versus #1 (sezon III): Oxxxymiron VS Johnyboy,” 27:15-27:48.

And you're the migrant worker here, since you're an imitator.[155]

The allusions he makes are both to the city of St. Petersburg–founded in the year 1703–as well as to the bar, "1703," which hosts *Versus* battles. Since he is a battler in the *Versus* league, Oxxxymiron is showing his allegiance to the league and vice versa. What is more important is that he identifies with the city of St. Petersburg/Leningrad, one that he left for Germany, and subsequently England, as a child. The city is so integral to his persona that, as he delivers the second bar, Oxxxymiron peels off the bandage to unveil a tattoo of the year *1703.* While Boym asserts that cultural myth does not necessarily depend on written language, in battle rap, written language often harkens back to iconography, working together to promote a specific ethos. In revealing his tattoo during a battle, it becomes a manifestation of his persona – a sign of the cultural mythology he is constructing around himself. He identifies not only with Petersburg culture, but the literal bar hosting the battle, and the Versus league itself. In naming these connections, he also others Johnyboy, showing him that he's not an insider in any

Figure 12: Oxxxymiron battling against Johnyboy while wearing a neck bandage.

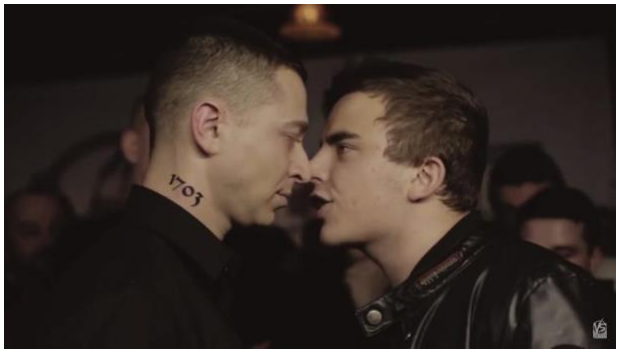


Figure 13: Oxxxymiron battling against Johnyboy, after he removed the neck bandage.

[155] The derogatory term " comes from the Soviet term "лимитчик" which can be translated as "migrant worker" or "quota worker." This term referred to non-resident, typically provincial workers who were recruited to work in Moscow and St. Petersburg factories based on quotas.

capacity: in the city, the bar, or battle rap. As Alim and Lee contend, battle rap is a genre that mediates each participant through the entire social interaction. That is, each battle consists of both self-presentation and participants delivering information to audiences about their opponent. In these examples, Oxxxymiron contributes to both the audience's and his opponents' perceptions of his persona.

Another critical component of Oxxxymiron's self-presentation is his crowd work. Since battles are performed in front of live crowds but simultaneously recorded for virtual audiences, I consider camera work to be part of crowd work. In each of the 1703 battles, Oxxxymiron stands on the left side of the screen (from the virtual viewer's perspective). This positioning is not significant except for in the Johnyboy battle, as he needs his tattoo to be facing the camera for the reveal to work. Though Oxxxymiron faces his opponent throughout the battle, he breaks this gaze to look at both the in-person crowd and the camera for emphasis. For instance, after Johnyboy delivers a weak punchline in his first round, Oxxxymiron turns and looks directly at the camera with pursed lips and gives a thumbs up; in this way, his camera work is a way to mockingly "congratulate" Johnyboy.[156] In the ST battle, he raps at the camera for an extended period while discussing different personality traits. He begins quoting from "Лондон против всех" ("London v. Everybody") and the in-person crowd raps along with him. This track is significant in that it is the first one Oxxxymiron released (2008), years before the debut of his first album, *Вечный Жид* (*The Wandering Jew*). While focusing on the camera, he manages to captivate the audience that surrounds him, which also demonstrates their knowledge of his music (and their presumed fandom).

[156] VersusBattleRu,"Versus #1 (sezon III): Oxxxymiron VS Johnyboy," 8:14.

Performative elements, from bodily positioning to gestures, allow us to analyze how a persona relates to the micro publics to which it appeals. Oxxxymiron's comfort with the camera is clear throughout his battles, as is his crowd interaction. He even addresses the World Domination VII crowd in English, *his third language,* multiple times, as its collective noise was disrupting his flow. He is visibly comfortable in front of the camera and audiences, lending a confidence and sense of ease to his battle rap persona, just as he describes in the single "Who Killed Mark?" Yet, it's not just Oxxxymiron's actions in the arena that speak to his persona. In fact, how his opponents describe him is a key element of self-presentation in the battle rap arena.

2.5 On the Insult of Ethnicity: Jewishness in the Battle Rap Arena

The Oxxxymiron persona is a combination of identity markers, some pared down and others played up for the sake of entertainment. One of those is the Jewish identity, a feature of Oxxxymiron's that Fyodorov himself claims is exaggerated for the battle rap arena. Biographically, Fyodorov is Jewish. Due to his reticence, his personal relationship with Judaism and Jewish culture is unclear. Nevertheless, in the world of hip hop, he understands that he is a "Jewish character" and anticipates that his battle rap opponents will use this fact to create narratives and insults in their texts. Fyodorov addresses this characterization in an interview with Felix Sandalov of *Afisha Daily* (2015), stating:

> Для меня упоминание собственного еврейства — это скорее хип-хоп-фишка по аналогии с тем, как американские негры своё происхождение подают, отсюда название альбома «Вечный жид» и все прочее. Баттл-рэп — это брат-близнец рестлинга: и в одном, и в другом у каждого персонажа есть своя особенность (один — пуэрториканец, другой — карлик, а третий — коммунист), поэтому в рэпе я со своей кошерной темой. Некоторые ошибочно думают, что это болезненная гордость за свой народ, но те, кто знает лично, понимают, что я угораю.[157]

[157] Felix Sandalov, "Oksimiron beseduet s samim soboj v proshlom." [Oxxxymiron talks to himself about his past], *Afisha Daily*, December 23, 2015, https://daily.afisha.ru/music/13-bez-prava-na-zabvenie/

> For me, the reference to my personal Jewishness is closer to a hip-hop schtick like how African Americans present their origin. That's where the title of my album, *The Wandering Jew*, comes from. Battle rap is the twin brother to wrestling, in both each personality has his particularity. One is a Puerto Rican; another is a dwarf; a third is a communist. That's why I have my kosher theme. Some mistakenly think this is a sick pride for my people, but those who know me personally understand that I'm cringing.

Like in Barthes's essay "World of Wrestling," Oxxxymiron describes how character types are essential to the entertainment experience in battle rap. In his case, the Jewish character type is a deliberate choice to distinguish himself in an insular world. Moreover, he addresses a disparity between his personal and public relationships with Judaism, without giving any details about the former. What this signifies is an intentional use of a biographical detail as a contextual framework for the Oxxxymiron persona. In other words, Fyodorov engages with his biography in a deliberate and controlled way that benefits audiences' understanding of his self-presentation as a battle rap character.

Jewishness first appears in Oxxxymiron's first studio album, *Вечный Жид* (*The Wandering Jew*). The title "Wandering Jew" is a reference to the medieval legend of an elderly Jewish man who taunted Christ on the way to his crucifixion and was destined to wander the Earth in punishment. The album cover (see Fig. 14) includes imagery, such as the staff related to both the legendary wanderer and wandering itself. For instance, the title refers to Oxxxymiron's belonging to the *Vagabund* (wanderer) label. While the term "жид" (zhid, Jew) is used in a set phrase here (вечный жид, wandering Jew), it has a derogatory context. The appropriate way to refer to a Jewish person

Figure 14: The "Wandering Jew" album cover.

would be “еврей/еврейка” (evrei, evreika; Jewish man, Jewish woman). Despite, or perhaps *due to* its derogatory nature, “zhid” is used throughout rap battles, so it is important to understand this distinction.

In addition to the album’s title, it includes an eponymous track that mixes Jewish references with stereotypes. For instance, in the first verse he raps, “Насмешил, посмотри на меня в профиль — ростовщик” (“You made me laugh, look at my profile – a money lender”).[158] Here, the stereotype of the Jewish money lender alludes to another, that of the long or “hooked” Jewish nose.[159] As Henrietta Mondry writes, the “hooked nose was a caricature of Jews” in Russian media as early as the 1880s, and it becomes a marker of “Jewish ethnic difference.”[160] Contrastingly, in the final verse Oxxxymiron rejects his Jewishness by rapping: “Мне не ближе дети Иакова/ Я изгой везде, ненавижу всех одинаково” (“I’m no closer to Jacob’s children/I’m an outcast everywhere and I hate everyone equally”).[161] In this line, he uses the term “Jacob’s children” to refer to the patriarch whose children are considered the forefathers of the twelve tribes of Israel. By rejecting his proximity to Jewishness, Oxxxymiron plays on the concept of the wanderer as an outcast. Moreover, he also displays his early attacks on other rappers by stating that he “hates everybody equally,” suggesting that being an outcast is both because of his differences (as a Jewish rapper) and his own actions (being an antagonist).

---

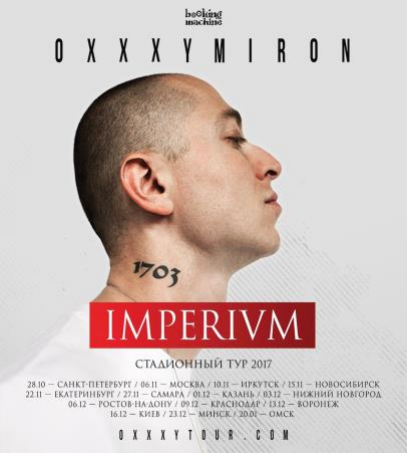
[158] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), “Vechnyj Zhid.” [The Wandering Jew.]

[159] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), “Vechnyj Zhid.” [The Wandering Jew], YouTube, October 31, 2019, 00:45-00:47, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MiSfRHhWxKU.

[160] Henrietta Mondry, *Exemplary bodies: Constructing the Jew in Russian Culture, since the 1880s,* Academic Studies Press, 2010, 47. https://doi-org.proxy.lib.umich.edu/10.2307/j.ctt21h4wgs; Henrietta Mondry, *Exemplary bodies: Constructing the Jew in Russian Culture, since the 1880s,* Academic Studies Press, 2010, 114, https://doi-org.proxy.lib.umich.edu/10.2307/j.ctt21h4wgs.

[161] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), “Vechnyj Zhid.” [The Wandering Jew], *1:21-1:26*.

Like in these lyrics, Oxxxymiron employs stereotypes in rap battles to disarm his opponents; by using the same stereotypes and language as they would or even furthering their language to neutralize their insults. For instance, in round one of the battle between Oxxxymiron and Gleb "Krip-a-Krip" Volkov, Krip-a-Krip refers to the "Wandering Jew" album title to insult Oxxxymiron; Oxxxymiron responds with a more elaborate and disparaging comment about himself while insulting Krip-a-Krip.[162] He raps: "Но нафига я столько лет брёл, запад истоптал/ Если меня убьёт теперь твой запах изо рта?/ Я не шучу, шмон невыносимый/А ведь мой нос большой и запахи вдвойне интенсивней ("Why the fuck did I wander for so many years, wearing down the West/If the thing that's gonna kill me is the stink of your breath/I'm not joking, the shakedown is unbearable/ I mean my nose is big and odors are doubly intensive.")[163] Here, he calls back to his own album (*The Wandering Jew*) and makes another reference to the anti-Semitic caricature of the Jewish nose when insulting his opponent. In addition to these references, he often uses his profile in promotional images (see Figs. 15 and 16).[164][165] Moreover, in rap battles, the battlers are shown in profile for much of the performance. Oxxxymiron is well aware that his ethnicity is on display in the perverse world of battle rap, where everything visible or apparent is fodder for insult. As such, he creatively plays with stereotypes to disarm his



[162] This is Versus Battle's third hosted battle.

[163] VersusBattleRu, "Versus #3 (sezon I): Oxxxymiron VS Krip-a-Krip," 17:52-18:02.

[164] Miron Fyodorov (@norimyxxxo), "Mezh tem tur prodolzhaetsya. Bilety: http://oxxxytour.com." [Meanwhile the tour continues. Tickets: http://oxxxytour.com], X, November 17, 2017, https://x.com/norimyxxxo/status/931517294911639553.

[165] Miron Fyodorov, *I Know What You Did Last Summer*, August 25, 2023, Spotify.

opponents, demonstrating not only that he is aware of the stereotypes they will use against him, but that they are visible parts of his own self-presentation, thus making them ineffective insults.

In other instances, Oxxxymiron adopts his opponents' language, proving that he can skillfully amend his prewritten texts to respond to their insults. This is evidenced in the same battle against Krip-a-Krip when his opponent alludes to rapper Roma Zhigan, who had a public feud with Oxxxymiron and his creative partner Schokk. This feud resulted in an altercation that was recorded and partially released. The footage released showed Roma Zhigan slapping Schokk in the face; the "open secret" that had existed for many years was that Oxxxymiron had also been slapped, although this footage had not gone public. When Krip-a-Krip raps: "Конечно, я вспомню ролик с Роминым холокостом/ Я ржал так долго, что из-за морщин был похож на мопса" ("Of course, I remember the clip of Roman's Holocaust/ I laughed so hard that my face looked like a pug's"), he refers to the footage with the line "Roman's Holocaust."[166] That is, he equates the public humiliation of the Jewish rappers with the mass murder of Jews in the Holocaust.

Figure 15: The promotional image for Oxxxymiron's 2017 "Imperivm" tour, depicting him in profile.

Figure 16: Another profile image used for the single "Я знаю, что ты делал прошлым летом" (I know what you did last summer), 2023.

Oxxxymiron responds to Krip-a-Krip's Holocaust reference in his first round and showcases his lyrical skill by amending a pre-written text on the spot, rapping: "Услышишь новый трек жида, он что-то снова пищит/ Это анти холокост и гой станет золою в печи" ("You'll hear the Jew's new track, he's

[166] VersusBattleRu, "Versus #3 (sezon I): Oxxxymiron VS Krip-a-Krip," 2:27-2:34.

peeping something again/ It's the anti-Holocaust and the goy will burn to ash in the oven.") [167] This tactic is called a "flip" as Oxxxymiron describes to the BBC Russia: "Иногда я использую то, что в баттл-рэпе называется "флип". Когда противник заканчивает раунд, можно начать его же словами, швырнув их ему обратно в лицо. Можно сделать то же самое где-нибудь в середине. Это немного сложнее, но все эти приёмы существуют" ("Sometimes I use what we call a "flip" in battle rap. It's when your opponent ends a round and you can begin with the same words, throwing them back in his face. You can do the same in the middle of a text. It's a little more complicated but all these techniques exist.")[168] It is in this way that Oxxxymiron co-opts and undermines his opponent's language to neutralize the crude joke and flip the insult back to Krip-a-Krip; by inverting the language he reverses the intended harm, disempowering his opponent and elevating his status in the battle.

Like Krip-a-Krip, Alexander "Dunya" Parkhomenko also makes crude references to the Holocaust and uses derogatory language to describe Oxxxymiron's Jewishness. What is interesting is that many of his opponents first make a "wandering Jew" reference before furthering their stereotypical or antisemitic language.[169] This is also a typical trope – using an opponent's lyrics or titles against him – but these punchlines usually fall flat. For a known reference to work in an already predictable genre, one needs to elevate one's creativity to make it work. Oxxxymiron's opponents usually cannot do so, making his use of "the wandering jew" the more memorable one, which further elevates his persona as a battle rapper. There are also other approaches that opponents take to target Oxxxymiron's Jewishness. Deniss "Johnyboy"

---

[167] VersusBattleRu, "Versus #3 (sezon I): Oxxxymiron VS Krip-a-Krip," 5:32-5:39.

[168] Jim Taylor, "Oksimiron: 'Molodyh vse slozhnee zastavlyat' nenavidet.'

[169]Krip-a-Krip, Dunya, ST.

Vasilenko attempts to relate to Oxxxymiron's Jewishness, stating: "Вы думали, скажу: 'Мирон мне был с роддома другом'/И мы в натуре обрезались у одного хирурга/ Я был его фанатом, но он выбрал Шокка, сука! Таких ждал слов, Иуда? Ну, тогда ты что-то спутал/ Я мог сказать, мы были круче Сойера и Финна/ Эх, как ужинали мы с тобой мацою у раввина" ("You thought I'd say "Miron's been my friend since the maternity ward/that we were circumcised by the same surgeon/ that I was his fan, but he chose Schokk, bitch! /Did you expect those words, Judas? Then you got something confused. I could have said that we were cooler than Sawyer and Finn/Eh, how we dined on matzo at the rabbi's place.")[170] While this final line elicits a laugh from the crowd, none of the Jewish references are used as punchlines; instead, they support a longer narrative that Johnyboy builds in his first round about their "pseudo-conflicts" outside of the genre of battle rap. That narrative also fails, and Johnyboy ultimately loses the battle.

One reason that stereotypical and derogatory language works in battle rap is because of its universality within a specific context; it's assumed that everyone will understand the references used and how they are meant to reflect upon the person against whom they are used. Most of the language mentioned above used against Oxxxymiron is either related to his musical work (*The Wandering Jew*) or well-known references to the Jewish experience (the Holocaust, matzo). Vyacheslav "Слава КПСС, Гнойный" ("Slava KPSS," "Gnojny") Mashnov turns his derogatory marks about Jewishness into longer narratives, using them to make statements both about his and Oxxxymiron's personas, rapping in his first round: "[…]но мне до пизды еврейские сказки/ Я не слушаю «Горгород», не читаю Тору, и не зависаю на Эхо Москвы/ Странно, в Правом Секторе любят лысых/Но тебе бы там дали пизды" ("[…]but I don't

[170] VersusBattleRu,"Versus #1 (sezon III): Oxxxymiron VS Johnyboy," 11:12-11:31.

give a shit about Jewish fairytales/ I don't listen to 'Gorgorod,' I don't read the Torah, and I'm not hung up on Echo of Moscow/It's strange, the Right Sector loves bald people/But they'd fuck you up over there").[171] Here, Slava KPSS rejects Jewishness by negating his relation to what he broadly defines as stereotypically Jewish cultural texts: Oxxymiron's albums *The Wandering Jew* and *Gorgorod*, the Torah, and the liberal radio station "Echo of Moscow" which is associated with Jewish liberal intellectuals. These texts are used to other Oxxxymiron in a different way. Here, rather than saying what Oxxxymiron is not, Slava KPSS chooses to negate his own relation to Jewish texts. By showing that he is not associated with Jewish texts, he implies that Oxxxymiron is.

In the final lines of this same verse, Slava KPSS flips the reference again. He makes fun of Oxxxymiron's physical appearance by joking that he looks just like the far-right "skinheads" who would violently attack him for being Jewish. The name "Right Sector" is also used by a coalition of Ukrainian nationalists, implying that they too would attack him (for being Russian). This sense of irony appears again in his second round when he raps: "Мы тут на войне, да/ Ты, сбежал покинув форпост/ Просто стараешься держаться в стороне/ Как те немцы, что допустили холокост" ("We're at war here, yeah/You ran off, abandoned your outpost/ You're basically trying to stay away/ Like the Germans who let the Holocaust happen.") [172] Here, Slava KPSS equates his Jewish opponent with German bystander of Nazi atrocities. He plays with the idea that Oxxxymiron is not a victim, but someone who watches the actions from afar.

---

[171] Mashnov raps under different monikers including the two listed here. The name 'Slava KPSS" is a play on the nickname for Vyacheslav as well as a common phrase used in Soviet times; Slava KPSS literally means Glory to the CPSU (Communist Party of the Soviet Union). The stage name "Gnojny" means "Foul;" "Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Слава КПСС (Gnojny), 18:16-18:27.

[172] VersusBattleRu, "Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Slava KPSS (Gnojny)," 35:41-35:49.

Throughout the battle, Slava KPSS writes broader narratives to other and deconstruct Oxxxymiron. This creative use of language leads to a clever association of Oxxxymiron with figures that he, a Jewish character, would not be associated with otherwise. Essentially, insults unexpectedly harp on biography, allowing him to shape Oxxxymiron's persona within the performance. As will be demonstrated in the following sections, Slava KPSS is Oxxxymiron's most skilled opponent. Not only does he format his insults in creative ways, but his texts are laden with historical and literary references, a characteristic that many praise Oxxxymiron for. It is in using the same skills as Oxxxymiron that Slava KPSS can deconstruct his opponent's persona.

2.6 On the Necessity and Failure of Universal Tropes in the Battle Rap Arena

Jewishness is a specific element of Oxxxymiron's persona that his opponents mention in various capacities in their attempted punchlines and insults. Other personal elements include his feud with Roma Zhigan and Schokk, his elite higher education, and his life abroad. Though these aspects are supplanted with universal tropes, namely, emasculation and charges of homosexuality; the same tropes that Oxxxymiron uses against his opponents in different battles. Much like the use of an opponent's lyrics, universal tropes must be used in a way that makes a new statement; as Lee and Alim contend, battle rap is a space to challenge and create social meaning. Yet, in Oxxxymiron's battles, the uses of homosexual taunts, both as offensive and defensive tactics, fall flat, as we see in the "battle by fact" example in the Slava KPSS battle.

Another prevalent trope relates back to the dozens: making comments about someone's mother. Related to the genre of "yo' mama" jokes, derived from the dozens, these jokes have had more success in the battles that Oxxxymiron performed in because they were approached creatively. For instance, in round two against Krip-a-Krip Oxxxymiron begins by saying that

Krip-a-Krip asked him not to offend his mother, he follows this by saying "Твоя мать – прекрасная женщина!" ("Your mother is a wonderful woman!") before building a narrative about how Krip-a-Krip's mother must work so hard in a blue-collar job to support her useless son.[173] He twists this trope to show Krip-a-Krip's negative side by creating a positive storyline about his mother. Similarly, Johnyboy does the same in battle against Oxxxymiron, rapping "Твоя мама — королева, ведь только королева могла воспитать принцессу" ("Your mom's a queen, after all only a queen could raise a princess.")[174] These pseudo-compliments to the rappers' mothers are actually emasculating insults to their sons, demonstrating Alim and Lee's point that battle rap is a space that can invert or mutate social meaning through the personal attack of a persona.

While universal tropes can contribute to one's understanding of a battle rapper's self-presentation, battler-specific insults are the ones that shape the public's perception of a rapper through his opponent's words. Having already discussed the use of Jewish and antisemitic themes in Oxxxymiron's battles, I will turn my attention to a close reading of the main themes in the Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS battle: education, emigration, and national belonging.

2.7 On Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS: A Clash of Archetypes that Oxxxymiron Loses

Given the nature of the competition, battlers often hear the same or similar insults from various opponents. The repetition of tropes and narratives is a construct that prompts battlers to be creative with their insults to entertain a new crowd. In their August 2017 battle, Slava KPSS skillfully plays with common themes used against Oxxxymiron to deconstruct his persona. What

[173] VersusBattleRu, "Versus #3 (sezon I): Oxxxymiron VS Krip-a-Krip," 11:30-12:30.

[174] VersusBattleRu,"Versus #1 (sezon III): Oxxxymiron VS Johnyboy." 9:05-9:07.

he does differently is build narratives, bolstering his caustic punchlines with lengthy descriptions, whereas Oxxxymiron approaches the battle abstractly, using extended metaphors and comparison to attack his opponent. While both rappers' texts include lines that are insightful to understanding self-presentation and persona in the battle rap context, it is ultimately Slava KPSS who more successfully attacks his opponent's persona and wins the battle.

The Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS battle is cohosted by the rappers' home leagues (Versus and Slovo); it takes place in a larger venue with both rappers' supporters in the audience. In the introductions, Slava KPSS plays up his "антихайп" ("antihype") persona; this stands for an ethos of provocation, controversy, and disregard for the mainstream. His social media presence embodies a performative allegiance to antihype, offering spectators persona as a continuation of performance, lending to Svetlana Boym's observation of the "theater of everyday life." Slava KPSS's persona is closely tied to text, both the text of his rap battles and the spontaneous characters he sends out one tweet at a time. So when he appears in the introductory segment, wearing sunglasses indoors in a dark venue, waving around a flask, and describing his opponent as "Tick-tock-boom, tiki-tiki-ti-punk, steampunk, bitch!" it is very much in character.[175][176] He strongly emphasizes his persona from the very beginning of the battle, which sets up the audience's expectations in a way that Oxxxymiron does not match; his introduction, and his energy throughout the battle, are more passive and tame compared to Slava KPSS's.

2.7.1 On Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS, Round One

In Oxxxymiron's first round, he uses an extended metaphor about the Batman universe to compare Slava KPSS to himself. He contends that he is both Batman and Christopher Nolan

[175] He mimics a line of Oxxxymiron's in the battle against Johnyboy.

[176] VersusBattleRu, "Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Slava KPSS (Gnojny)," 1:52-1:55

(director of 2008's *The Dark Night)* in that without the two the Joker (Slava KPSS) would not exist. His claim is that Slava KPSS, who has been taunting him on social media for the past year, is only relevant because of the attention he gets for speaking about Oxxxymiron. Hence why he calls Slava KPSS out to battle. In using this extended metaphor, he contrasts their statuses in the hip hop community, essentially arguing that he is a veteran and Slava KPSS is a nobody who won't make a lasting impression in the culture. He even compares their approaches to battle rap, taunting "Писал декабрь, январь, февраль, март, апрель, май/Июнь, июль. И ты думал, текстoк — Tech N9ne, бо!/ Я писал неделю плюс-минус два дня/ Я тебя боюсь в тридцать раз меньше, чем ты боишься меня" (You wrote in December, January, February, March, April, May/June, July, and you thought your little text was like Tech N9ne!/ I wrote for a week, give or take two days/ I'm thirty times less afraid of you than you are of me).[177][178] The notion of writing quickly relates to an admission Oxxxymiron makes after *Gorgorod's* release and its positive public reception: he claims to have written the album in the few weeks before its release.[179] Here he tries to elevate himself over Slava KPSS by insinuating that he needs less time to write insults, therefore he is a better rapper.

Since the texts are pre-written, battlers can only respond impromptu to a certain degree, such as using a flip or interjecting a response elsewhere in their text. In this battle, however, Slava KPSS's first round coincidently challenges Oxxxymiron's point about not needing as much time to write; he makes fun of how long it took Oxxxymiron to release an unoriginal and

---

[177] Tech N9ne is the stage name of American rapper Aaron Dontez Yates. He is known for his fast-paced rapping which Oxxxymiron mimics when he delivers the first two quoted lines.

[178] VersusBattleRu, "Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Slava KPSS (Gnojny)," 8:35-8:45.

[179] Andrei Nedashkovsky, "Porchy i Oxxxymiron: 'Bol'she, Chem Sem'ya.' Chast' 1." [Porchy and Oxxxymiron: 'More than Family.' Part 1], *TheFlow.ru,* April 1, 2016, https://the-flow.ru/features/porchy-oxxymiron-2016-part-1.

underwhelming second album. KPSS's prewritten text challenges this idea as it harps on a pain point: how long it took Oxxxymiron to release his second album. He raps:

> Я утверждаю, что как творец ты умер
> И не заслуживая славы культового рэп-певца
> Я не признаю твои заслуги, поэтому, когда читаю, я напоминаю тебе отца
> Поговорим о твоём альбоме, разберём с хладнокровием Лаврентия Берия
> Ты плохо учился в своём Гриффиндоре
> Если русские что и умеют, то это разваливать империи
> Все ждали четыре года, и он как мог нагнетал интригу
> И всё, что ему пришло в голову — записать аудиокнигу
> Причём банальную антиутопию[180]
>
> I declare that as a creator, you've died
> And you don't deserve a cult rappers' honor
> I don't accept your accomplishments so when I spit my rhymes, I remind you of your father
> Let's talk about your album and analyze it in Lavrenty Beria's cold-blooded manner
> You didn't do well in your Gryffindor
> If there's something Russians are good at, then it's destroying empires
> Everyone waited four years for it, he tried his best to intrigue them
> And all that he came up with was to record an audiobook
> A trivial dystopia, by the way!

His verse is a direct attack on *Gorgorod* and by proxy, Oxxxymiron. He does not just reject the album, he critiques its plot, quality, and the length of time audiences waited for it, in detail. His following lines add a more spirited language on the same topic, he even mockingly asks Oxxxymiron if George Orwell and Evgeny Zamyatin ever wrote about the unknown topic "трагическая любовь посреди антиутопии" ("a tragic love story amidst an anti-utopia.")[181] What is more is that Slava KPSS energetically and performatively works the camera and the crowd from the very beginning of the performance. For instance, he stares into the camera as he begins his text, looks at it again and shrugs when calling Gorgorod an "audio book," and takes

[180] VersusBattleRu, "Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Slava KPSS (Gnojny)," 14:59-15:33.

[181] VersusBattleRu, "Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Slava KPSS (Gnojny)."

his sunglasses off after making a point that elicits a positive responds from the crowd, and then he throws the glasses into the crowd. He is not only outperforming Oxxxymiron in deconstructing one another's personas, but he is using unexpected actions to elevate the spectacle of an expectations-driven genre. It is in these actions that the Slava KPSS persona challenges the Oxxxymiron persona, and deflates it, as a result.

Slava KPSS also diversifies his attacks on Oxxxymiron. He jabs at his status as an emigrant, his education, and, more poignantly, the paradox and hypocrisy of his self-presentation. While other opponents were unsuccessful in citing Oxxxymiron's words against him, Slava KPSS manages to do so by inverting the trope; that is, he uses his words not in the punchline, but as a set up. This is evident in his first round when he states: "Раньше был «против всех», теперь ты вроде свой" ("Before you were "against everybody," but now you're apparently one of us.")[182] He others Oxxxymiron in this sarcastic way but also makes direct comments that challenge Oxxxymiron's Russianness. One example, mentioned above, is the way he speaks about Russia as if Oxxxymiron is not familiar with the culture ("If there's something Russians are good at…). He makes another one of these declarations in another, more complex section at the end of his first round. These verses read:

> Ты скажешь: 'Я не политик, я артист, я не пишу заявления — я пишу треки'
> Но, как и политик — ты популист, иначе зачем примазался к теме
> Чо, блядь, так болел за Россию, что на нервах терял ганглии/Но, когда тут проходили митинги, где ты сидел? В Англии
> Лондон, Лондон, научи нас жить — как нам без тебя обустроить Россию?
> Ты выдаёшь бульварный роман за политическую сатиру/Но не называешь имён — там список еврейских фамилий
> А в России традиция не называть имена, когда идёт речь о крысе в своём коллективе
> А я везу вам революцию, как встарь, по дороге из Тушино
> У этой телеге вращаются оси — футуристы скинули с корабля современности Пушкина

[182] VersusBattleRu, "Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Slava KPSS (Gnojny)," 16:41-16:43.

А вы до сих пор цеплялись за Оxxxу, ведь он же живой...
Но только живой пример, что любой за четыре года может исписаться и стать никем

You say "I'm not a politician, I'm an artist, I don't write petitions
But like a politician, you're a populist, otherwise why would you mention the topic?
What, you fucking missed Russia so much that you started losing ganglia to nerves
But when there were mass demonstration, where were you? In England
London, London, teach us how to live, how will we build Russia without you?
And you pass off your tabloid novel as political satire
But you won't name names, it's just a list of Jewish surnames
But in Russia, the tradition is not to name names when it means outing a rat in your own collective
But I'm bringing you the revolution of old, from the road out of Tushino
The cart's wheels are spinning, the Futurists threw Pushkin off the ship of modernity
And until now you kept Oxxxy, because he's alive
But you're just living proof that anybody can run out of ink and become a nobody in 4 years

As he delivers this section of his first text, Slava KPSS becomes more animated, rapping faster and gesturing to both the crowd and the camera. The text is full of references meant to discredit Oxxxymiron as both an artist and Russian insider. First, Slava KPSS attacks Oxxxymiron for being politically neutral, highlighting that making a statement that "one is not into politics" *is* a political statement. Then, he points out that Oxxxymiron was not in Russia during the mass anti-government demonstrations (2011-2013). Rather, he was in England where his family emigrated to. He strengthens this point with two references, one to the Russian writer Alexander Herzen (1812-1870) who lived in exile in London for a period of time in the 1850s to the 1860s ("London, London teach us how to live!) and another to an essay by Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn (1918-2008) titled "Как нам обустроить Россию" ("Rebuilding Russia") who also famously lived in exile for approximately 20 years. Here he conflates Oxxxymiron with other Russians who enjoy life abroad while trying to change or impact Russian culture from the outside.

Slava KPSS continues to skillfully engage Russian high culture throughout the verse. For instance, the phrase "по дороге из Тушино" ("from the road out of Tushino") refers to the early

17th century pretender to the Russian throne often referred to as the second false Dmitry; the following line "футуристы скинули с корабля современности Пушкина" ("the Futurists threw Pushkin off the ship of modernity") is a reference to Vladimir Mayakovsky whose poetic trajectory began with a call for the rejection of literary tradition. He finishes the verse by saying that Oxxxymiron has become a nobody in just four years. Together, these lines place Oxxxymiron into the context of outsiders, Russians and pretenders who try to influence and change culture with their non-Russian perspectives and experiences. Moreover, Slava KPSS connects himself to Russia's revolutionary traditions, demonstrating that he is the insider in the situation, a real creative force who is ready to put an end to Oxxxymiron's cultural influence. It is this mission that he intends to carry out in his next two battle rounds.

2.7.2 On Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS, Round Two

The atmosphere of round two is more tense and activated, with both rappers picking up the speed and intensity of their deliveries and using more physical reactions and gestures in relation to the camera and crowd. While Oxxxymiron makes a few good punchlines against Slava KPSS, he spends most of his round criticizing battle rap in general, calling out the administrators of Slovo SPB and Versus, as well as the state of the genre. He rebounds from a focused, albeit weak, attack on Slava KPSS in round one, to an energized but misdirected attack on the genre in round two. Moreover, throughout Oxxxymiron's second round, Slava KPSS directs the attention to himself through a use of gestures and actions, thus elevating his presence in the arena before even delivering his second text.

The height difference between Oxxxymiron and Slava KPSS is notable; the latter towers over the former, which also makes him easier to spot when the camera pans through the crowd and back to the battlers. Nevertheless, it is not his height, but his stage presence that affects the

audience's perception of the two personas during the performance. Slava KPSS uses the camera in a way that manifests his "antihype" persona. For instance, he regularly breaks the "fourth wall," staring directly into the camera to demonstrate his boredom as a well to display a mutual sense of exasperation as his opponent's talking points. He also does something that surprises the crowd: while Oxxxymiron is accusing Slovo SPB's administrator Denis "Ден Чейни" (Dan Cheney) Chudinovsky of allegedly stealing the idea for Slovo SPB from a friend, Slava KPSS responds by facing Cheney and giving him the "middle finger." The crowd, including Restorator, erupts in laughter and applause. Seconds later, while Oxxxymiron is still rapping, he moves to another corner of the performance space and does it again, this time the camera capturing him at a different angle (see Figs 17 and 18).[183] In doing so, he defuses the punchline with his antics and takes the attention away from Oxxxymiron. His performance is simply unmatched in terms of how he works the crowd without even speaking.

Slava KPSS's second round text is just as strong as his first, bolstered by his performative gestures and actions. In this round, he stays focused on attacking his opponent, even moving into Oxxxymiron's atmosphere of the abstract to deconstruct his persona and performance. The text is

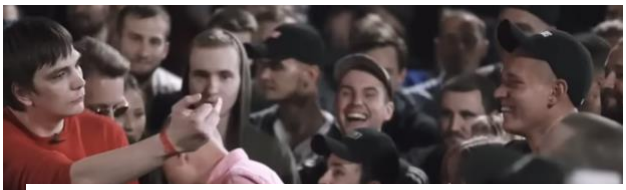


Figure 17: Slava KPSS gesturing at Dan Cheney

Figure 18: Slava KPSS gesturing at Dan Cheney (II).

[183] VersusBattleRu, "Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Slava KPSS (Gnojny)," 26:58-26:70, 27:08.

a rebuttal to Oxxxymiron's second round, which suggests that Slava KPSS was able to amend his prewritten text during the performance. In it, he criticizes Oxxxymiron's skill and status as a battle rapper and the criticism of battle rap that he just delivered. He also delves into abstract territory by addressing the overall point of a rap battle, stating:

> Но Мирону не нужны панчи, он интересный и так
> Сегодня ты смотришь баттлы без панчей, а завтра — порнуху без баб
> Личности, личности, личности
> Блядь, какие личности?
> Они верят, что я пил мочу, или что ты встречался с Соней Грезе[184]
> Или что у тебя во рту столько белка, что можно испечь целый противень безе
> Ведь баттл — территория постправды
> Тут не важно какой факт настоящий
> Так какие личности, долбоёб, тут решает количество панчей[185]
>
> But Miron doesn't need punches, he's interesting without them
> Today you watch a battle without punchlines, tomorrow you watch porno without women
> Personalities, personalities, personalities!
> What fucking personalities?
> They believe that I drank piss and that you dated Sonya Greze
> Or that there's enough egg white in your mouth to bake a whole sheet of meringue
> Afterall, a battle is a post-truth territory
> Here it doesn't matter what fact is accurate, so what personalities, moron, here it's the amount of punches that matter.

As he shouts "personalities, personalities" he points his hands in the air (see Fig 19). This reference, at the center of this verse, comes from Oxxxymiron's final round in the battle against Johnyboy – a battle Slava KPSS quotes or alludes to several times throughout. After referring to Johnyboy as one of many posers in the genre, Oxxxymiron raps: "Дело не в количестве панчей, не в качестве рифм —

Figure 19: Slava KPSS shouting "Personalities!' and gesturing in the air.

[184] Sonya Greze is a Russian blogger turned rapper.

[185] VersusBattleRu, "Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Slava KPSS (Gnojny)," 38:41-39:27.

дело в личности, что за ними" ("It's not about the number of punches or the quality of the rhyme, but about the personality behind them.")[186] He essentially tells Oxxxymiron that anyone can copy a successful rhyme or punchline, but not everyone has the persona needed to captivate. Similar to what Organik says, Oxxxymiron suggests that it's the persona that makes the battler. Contrastingly, Slava KPSS states that it's not about personality, it's about punchlines. Indeed, he argues that the veracity in a punchline is irrelevant, it's the delivery of punchlines that matters. In this way, he diffuses Oxxxymiron's second round by flipping his line from the Johnyboy battle and insinuating that performing a persona will not allow him to succeed in this battle.

Like Oxxxymiron, Slava KPSS plays with the concept of battle rap's demise from the perspective of a true battler. He notes that he's involved in the scene and has participated in nearly triple the number of battles as Oxxxymiron, making him the real professional. His intention here is to devalue Oxxxymiron's status as a battle rapper, saying that if the genre is going to die it's because he (Slava KPSS) will take out Oxxxymiron. The crowd erupts in cheers and chants of "Gnojny!" that last several seconds before he's able to deliver the final line: "И я должен констатировать причину и время смерти-—17:03" ("and I am supposed to pronounce the cause and time of death: 17:03.")[187] This final line is meant to be taken as Oxxxymiron's time of death, a clever use of the year of St. Petersburg, Russia's, founding, and the date tattooed on Oxxxymiron's neck. Through his direct attacks on Oxxxymiron's Russianness, intelligence, belonging, and biographical notes, Slava KPSS manages to deconstruct Oxxxymiron's persona in just two rounds. It is if he manifests his position on the roles of punches and personalities in the arena.

---

[186] VersusBattleRu,"Versus #1 (sezon III): Oxxxymiron VS Johnyboy." 52-26:58.

[187] VersusBattleRu, "Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Slava KPSS (Gnojny)," 42:09-42:15.

2.7.3 On Oxxxymiron v. Slava KPSS, Round Three

Throughout Slava KPSS's second round, Oxxxymiron demonstrates a discomfort rarely seen in other battles. For instance, he verbally responds to Slava KPSS's text under his breath, turning to a friend at one point to ask "what, do I not have punchlines?" and frequently changing his posture and looking down as his opponent raps at him. This behavior predicates his even more abstract shift in the third round, declaring that "хочется поговорить о книгах." (I feel like talking about books) and telling Slava KPSS "ты можешь пока поспать" (you can sleep for now). [188] As he begins to tell a story about a "great book" (великая книга) the crowd begins to laugh, in disbelief that he *wants to talk about books*. In this opening, Oxxxymiron interrupts the spectacle, taking the third round to an abstract discussion rather than performing the insults expected of him. He begins to talk about the novel *A Hero With a Thousand Faces* (Joseph Campbell, 1949), its themes, and its influence on him at a specific point in his life, using it as a segue to his main point:

> Я помню первые баттлы в России
> Там считалось, что нужно врага
> Чтобы вынести, наверняка обложить километрами стояка
> После в дело пошла деконструкция
> Все врага развинтили старательно
> Но под всей психологией кухонной
> Лежит коллективное бессознательное
> И за каждым любым, даже хоть бытовым
> Проявлением негатива двух отдельных людей
> Виден древний мотив столкновения архетипов[189]
>
> I remember the first battles in Russia
> People thought you had to take your opponent out by covering them in kilometers of dick
> After that came deconstruction, everyone took their enemies apart
> But under all the armchair philosophy lies a collective unconscious

[188] VersusBattleRu, "Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Slava KPSS (Gnojny)," 42:45-42:47.

[189] VersusBattleRu, "Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Slava KPSS (Gnojny)," 44:51-45:21.

And behind every demonstration, even every mundane one, of negativity between two people
The ancient motif, the clash of archetypes comes to light

As he delivers this and related verses, Oxxxymiron speaks to the camera, using his hands while he talks and moving around the performance space, even going behind and then reaching around his opponent; it is as if he's trying to reclaim the space but struggling to bypass an obstacle. His language loosens into more direct attacks on Slava KPSS, equating himself to a "hero" in the world of archetypes and his opponent is an antagonist. This is all to say that his discussion of archetypes is used to buttress his final insults on Slava KPSS, ruminate on the end of the battle, and claim that this battle is just practice for his upcoming performance against Dizaster. In the end, Oxxxymiron's gamble – he says he is "throwing away his third round" by going on this tangent – fails. Instead of performing what is expected of him, Oxxxymiron begins to rap abstractly as if he were thinking aloud and trying to defend the very performance he was delivering.

Contrastingly, Slava KPSS continues with a similar approach as before in his third round. Using extended verses to attack Oxxxymiron's hypocrisy as an "anti-mainstream" artist who is performatively mainstream, his predilection for "dragging female fans to his dressing room," his perceived pretentiousness, and other specific characteristics that he identifies. Towards the end of the round, he emphasizes Oxxxymiron's fore fronting of persona, rapping:

За весь твой творческий путь нихуя, кроме рефлексии
'Я, я, ' – о своей фигуре весь написанный материал
Ты так много пиздишь о культуре, но хоть где-то её осмыслял? Нет.
Даже в ссаной песне про вейп мы сказали намного больше
Весь твой рэп ни о чем, потому что он только об Окси [190]

Your entire creative trajectory is nothing but reflection

[190] VersusBattleRu, "Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Slava KPSS (Gnojny)," 58:41-59:06.

> "Me, me, me! – all of your material is about you
> You fuck around so much about culture, but have you ever actually thought about it? No.
> Even in our shitty song about vaping, we said a lot more.
> All your rap is about nothing, because it's only about Oxxxy

In his final round, Slava KPSS ironically performs as expected and deconstructs Oxxxymiron's persona while stating his distaste for the focus on "personalities" in the battle rap genre. He goes on to win the battle.

In a now deleted Instagram post, Oxxxymiron addresses the battle and its outcome. One of the points he touches upon is why he believes he lost the battle, arguing:

> Потому что, как и на прежних баттлах, ушёл в лирические отступления, которые мне реально интересно писать, в отличие от бесконечного "сетап-панч, сетап-панч". Возможно, я по жизни слишком зациклился на том, как я в своё время повлиял на баттлрэп – а вместо этого мне самому стоит поучиться у баттловиков, чей мир с тех пор перерос в нечто иное и самостоятельное. Хотя гонка за количеством панчей все ещё кажется мне довольно унылым подходом к баттлам…Не будь проигрыша – я бы, наверное, так и не осознал, что нужен апгрейд. Апгрейд будет.[191]
>
> Because like in past battles, I went into a lyrical aside, which is actually interesting for me to write, instead of the never ending "set up-punch, set up-punch." It's possible that I've been too fixated on how I influenced battle rap in my time. Instead, I should learn from the battlers whose world has changed into something different and independent, although the race to a punch count still seems to me a dull approach to battles…But without the loss I would, probably, never realize that an upgrade is needed. An upgrade will come.

This introspection seems in direct response to Slava KPSS's critiques that Oxxxymiron thinks too much about himself, and he doesn't have a "pulse" on the "dying" battle rap genre. Oxxxymiron inserts his opinion within this statement – that the current set up is boring – which almost invalidates this reflection. This type of statement is demonstrative of the persona he has built, where acknowledging a fault appears to be a necessary, but not particularly desired, public

[191] Rap.ru, "'Apgrejd Budet, Narniya Poka Podozhyet:' Oxxxymiron Prokommentiroval Battl s Gnojnym." ['An upgrade is coming, meanwhile Narnia is waiting:' Oxxxymiron commented on the battle with Gnojny], *Rap.ru*, August 14, 2017, https://www.rap.ru/news/9111.

behavior. This statement is meaningful in that even his self-imposed “upgrade” never occurs; Oxxxymiron participates in just one more career battle weeks after this loss (Oxxxymiron v. Dizaster). This makes his battle against Slava KPSS his final battle in Russian. Like the years between album releases and the pauses in public presentation, this proposed development in the battle rap arena takes on a form of an extended pause.

With this, Oxxxymiron’s battle rap persona becomes a thing of the past. He retreats from global headlines and battle stages (World Domination VII) and enters a period of detachment from his public persona. As we will see in Chapter 3, Oxxxymiron’s choice to step away from the genre is a personal, rather than professional one. This is all revealed in his 2021 track “Кто Убил Марка?” (Who Killed Mark?), in which he discusses his career trajectory and deconstructs the persona he has built through the years.

Chapter 3: On "Death" and "Resurrection" on Oxxxymiron's Terms

On the evening of October 29, 2021, a nondescript advertisement appeared on Moscow's New Arbat Avenue (see Fig. 20).[192] Its design was simple: capitalized white text reading "КОГДА АЛЬБОМ," (Kogda Al'bom, When's the Album [Coming Out]) appeared on a black background. No punctuation. No imagery. Over the next two days, similar billboards and banners appeared across nine Russian cities, some including a logo or fine print connecting the ads to a partnership with the Russian streaming service, СберЗвук (SberZvuk).[193] To the uninitiated, the ads were meaningless. This, however, was a campaign for insiders, of which there were millions, if we count streams, downloads, and platform views. While nothing about the ad's aesthetic was remarkable, the capitalized, unpunctuated question at their center was revelatory. Those who knew *knew*. The Russian hip-hop outlet, The-Flow.ru, posted an article with a video displaying the banner, mere hours after it appeared. Its title reads: "В Москве на

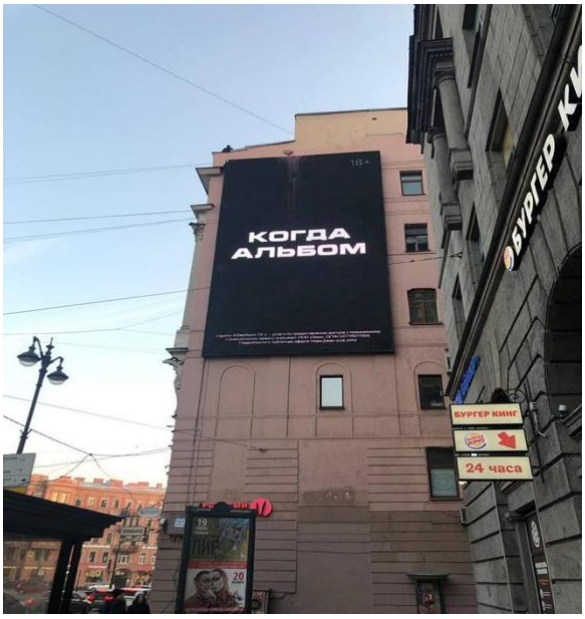


Figure 20: An example of a "When's the Album (Coming Out)" banner hanging in St. Petersburg.

[192] The Flow.ru, "Bannery Oksimirona 'Kogda Al'bom razmestil SberZvuk" [SberZvuk posted Oxxxymiron's 'When's the album?' banners], November 1, 2021, https://the-flow.ru/news/oksimiron-sberzvuk.

[193] The Flow.ru, "Bannery Oksimirona 'Kogda Al'bom razmestil SberZvuk"

Новом Арбате появился баннер ‘Когда альбом?’: Оксимирон, это ты?” (“A ‘When’s the album [coming out]?’ banner appeared on Moscow’s New Arbat [Avenue]. Oxxxymiron, is that you?”)[194] Miron Fyodorov, who had not released an album since 2015, and had decreased his social media output after his final rap battle, was indeed behind the campaign. The words “KOGDA AL’BOM” were a signal that a long-awaited musical release was forthcoming. For years after the release of his *Gorgorod* and its ensuing *Imperivm* tour, Fyodorov was met with a constant refrain on the Internet: “Kogda al’bom?” Comments on his social media posts met the question so often that it became a meme.[195] Having been taunted by the question, Fyodorov turned it back to audiences through the ad campaign.

Despite the initial speculation online, the ads were unclaimed for two days. Then, on November 1, 2021, Oxxxymiron released a single titled “Кто убил Марка?” (Kto Ubil Marka, Who Killed Mark) on streaming platforms and shared it to his social media pages. He would release two albums in rapid succession shortly thereafter: the first on November 12, 2021, a compilation of previously released tracks and features titled *MiXXXtape III: Смутное Время (Smutnoe Vremya,* The Time of Troubles) and the second on December 1, 2021, titled *Красота и Уродство (Krasota I Urodstvo,* Beauty and Ugliness). The latter was his first original album release in six years. On the day of the single’s release, the Internet was abuzz with fans expressing their excitement at Oxxxymiron’s reentry into public life by posting humorous renditions of the standard Paschal greeting, “Христос Воскрес! Воистину воскрес!” (“Christ is Risen! He is risen indeed!”) subbing versions of Fyodorov’s name where appropriate. Even

[194] The Flow.ru, “V Moskve na Novom Arbate poyavilsya ‘Kogda al’bom?’” [A banner for ‘When is the Album?’ appeared on New Arbat Street in Moscow], *The Flow.ru,* October 29, 2021, https://the-flow.ru/news/kogda-albom-banner.

[195] The Flow.ru, “Bannery Oksimirona ‘Kogda Al’bom razmestil SberZvuk”

Oxxxymiron's manager Zhenya Murodshoeva got in on the fun, posting to X (Twitter): Ночь с Хэллоуина на День Всех Святых традиционно считается единственным днём в году, когда духи умерших могут вернуться на землю" ("The night between Halloween and All Souls' Day is traditionally considered the only day on which souls of the dead can return to earth.")[196] The notion that Oxxxymiron was returning to the earth fit with the elusiveness he had honed over the prior year; a mark of silence that culminates over the years as one of his prominent persona traits.

The theater of the ad campaign is related to a reconceptualization of Oxxxymiron initiated through the release of "Who Killed Mark?" (see Fig. 21).[197] In this track, Fyodorov battles an internal opponent: he describes and deconstructs the Oxxxymiron persona that he had spent years building. He does so as he recounts his rise to fame over the past ten years and the internal struggles it caused. And he addresses major career events, primarily his contentious relationships with two rappers: Dimitri "Schokk" Hinter, a former collaborator and friend, and Roman "Roma Zhigan" Chumakov, an antagonist whose

Figure 21: The cover frame for the "Who Killed Mark? video.

[196] Zhenya Murodshoeva (@zhenyam_). "Noch' s Hellouina na Den' Vseh Svyatyh traditsionno shitaetsya edinstvennym dnyem v godu, kogda duhi umershih mogut vernutsya na zemlyu." [The night from Halloween to All Saints' Day is traditionally recognized as the only day of the year when souls of those who have passed can return to Earth], X, November 1, 2021, 2:24 AM, https://mobile.twitter.com/ZMurodshoeva/status/1455058084360073216?cxt=HHwWgMC93crns7EoAAAA, (link no longer accessible, original copy in author's possession).

[197] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?" [Who Killed Mark?] YouTube, November 1, 2021, 10:31. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=q92DWs1MwRA

actions off the stage put Fyodorov in a tailspin. In the age of digital permanence, Fyodorov confronts the tense dynamic of a human being veiled by a public persona; one who spends years concerned with his public-facing self, rather than grappling with his reality. He maneuvers through this dual personal-but-public-history in "Who Killed Mark?" like a rap battler is trained to, by giving his own detailed accounting thereby removing others' ability to control his narrative and diss or degrade him.

3.1 On *Gorgorod:* Format, Themes, and Meaning

Four years after his debut album *The Wandering Jew*, Oxxxymiron releases his second studio album *Gorgorod*.[198] This marked the beginning of a pattern of pause, in which Oxxxymiron either delayed creative releases or retreated from public life altogether. *Gorgorod* is released on November 13, 2015 (see Fig. 22), nearly a year after its original release date of August 14, 2014.[199] Fyodorov explained to fans that he was not happy with the material and thus needed to delay the album's release.[200] What complicates that explanation is that he later claims to have written the album in the three weeks just prior to its release. It appears that he

Figure 22: The cover of Gorgorod (2015) depicts a version of Bruegel's 16th-century painting of the Tower of Babel.

[198] Miron Fyodorov. *Gorgorod*. November 13, 2015. Spotify.

[199] Miron Fyodorov. *Gorgorod*.

[200] Miron Fyodorov, (@oxxxymironofficial), "Oxxxymiron o Date Vyhoda Vtorovo Al'boma. 2014." [Oxxxymiron on the Date of the Release of his Second Album. 2014], August 8, 2014, 01:11. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oLUaEMv076U.

was struggling with his writing practice, which will be taken up later in this section. Regardless of his reasoning, and the fact that audiences cannot consider him a reliable narrator, the pauses become part of Oxxxymiron's persona. Fans expect long periods between albums, and Oxxxymiron does nothing to dispel this expectation. Nevertheless, Oxxxymiron produced an album that "changed the game." He writes and releases *Gorgorod* as a concept album, one in which an overarching narrative unifies the album's tracks, rather than presenting a set of standalone songs.[201] The album is quickly compared to Kendrick Lamar's 2012 *good kid, m.A.A.d. city*, perhaps the premier hip hop concept album of the early aughts. Indeed, Fyodorov himself cites it as an inspiration for the *idea* of writing a concept album.[202] This is just one example of the communication that occurs through presentational media, where rappers also constitute members of micro publics and draw their inspiration from other rappers.

Gorgorod tells the story of Mark, a writer living in a dystopian city (Gorgorod) and struggling with his literary output. It is narrated by different characters, most played by Fyodorov. The first character to appear is Mark's literary agent Kira, voiced by Oxxxymiron's real manager, Zhenya Murodshoeva. She appears in a voicemail to Mark in the introductory track "Не с начала" ("Not from the Beginning"); Kira's voice recordings to Mark serve as interludes throughout the album, connecting the different pieces of the narrative. The next featured character appears in track two "Кем ты стал" ("Who Have You Become"). He is an unnamed "повёрнутый фанат" ("crazy fan") a la Eminem's "Stan."[203] In this song, Oxxxymiron

[201] These albums are colloquially known as *concept* albums rather than *conceptual* albums.

[202] Andrei Nedashkovsky,"Porchy i Oxxxymiron: 'Bol'she, Chem Sem'ya.' Chast' 1."

[203] "Stan" is a 2000 song by Eminem about an obsessive fan whose devotion leads to violence. After the song's release, the term "stan" entered popular lingo as a term for an excessively enthusiastic or obsessive fan. A documentary about Eminem with the title "Stans" was released in August 2025.

plays the fan who angrily addresses Mark for betraying himself and his readers. “Всего Лишь Писатель” (“Just a Writer”) is the title of track 3 and it is structured as Mark’s response to his fan’s accusations.

A turning point occurs in track four when Mark lays eyes upon Алиса (Alice), whom he refers to as his “девочка пиздец” (“fucked up girl”) which is also the track’s title. Reading the song’s chorus, one understands his mental state and perception of Alice: “Каждый ёбаный день в этом зиккурате пролитых слёз/ Вавилонской башне мёртвых идей, от которых череда одних чёрных полос/ В Колизее нереализованных грёз, в клубе одиноких сердец/ Как я тебя заебался ждать и нашёл, моя девочка пиздец” (“Every fucking day in this ziggurat of shed tears, / This tower of Babel of dead ideas, from which there is only a sequence of black stripes/In the Coliseum of unrealized dreams, in the club of lonely hearts/ How I fucking managed to wait for you and find you, my fucked-up girl.”)[204] Mark alludes to feeling dejected and stifled amidst Gorgorod’s colossal and labyrinthine structures, both literal and figurative (ziggurat, tower of Babel, Coliseum). His evocation of the Tower of Babel “of dead ideas,” perverts the biblical tower’s significance, further alluding to the city’s hopelessness and failure of its oppositional forces. It is in Alice, who is portrayed as “fucked up,” that Mark finds refuge and solidarity. She is portrayed as complex, with information about her backstory primarily coming at the end of the album, such as an upbringing filled with parental pressure, comparison, and abuse.[205]

---

[204] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial). “Devochka pizdets.” [Fucked up girl], YouTube, October 31, 2019, 2:43, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-B6NDjtWlP4.

[205] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial). “Gde nas net.” [Where we aren’t], YouTube, October 31, 2019, 4:25, https://youtu.be/ByEDNOcu7bg?feature=shared.

We learn through the successive tracks that Alice introduces Mark to the politically oppositional side of Gorgorod, the esoteric ideas of which are presented through a guru character in “Переплетено” (“Intertwined,” Track 5). The basis of the guru’s philosophy is that of the city’s opposition, that everything is connected, and influence is passed between connections, undermining Gorgorod’s political powers who pretend otherwise. It is here that the Tower of Babel becomes relevant again, with the story’s original meaning being that a united and unified people were building a tower to reach the heavens. Mark becomes influenced by these ideas and acts on them in two ways: by producing two manuscripts and joining a plot against the ruling powers. Tracks seven and eleven (“Полигон,” [Shooting Range]; “Где Нас Нет,” [“Where We Are Not”]) each individually represent a manuscript, demonstrating how Mark’s writer’s block passes into writing with urgency. Mark narrates track 8 “Накануне” (“On the Eve”) which presents his thoughts the day before the plot against the city’s powers is undertaken, and track 10 “Башня из Слоновой Кости” (“Ivory Tower”), which addresses the aftermath of the failed plot and Mark’s fate.

Other than Kira’s infant son, Nick, to whom Mark sings track 6 “Колыбельная” (“Lullaby”), there is only one other character: the city’s mayor Фон Глен (Von Glen). He narrates track 9 aptly titled “Слово Мэра” (“The Mayor’s Word”). In it, he addresses a detained Mark, warning him to stay away from his daughter, Alice; their kinship is a revelation to Mark. We learn, through “Ivory Tower,” that Mark is detained and set for the gallows before the city’s mayor releases him. As the song concludes, Mark contemplates man’s choices in life but is unable to finish his thought, as he is (fatally) shot. Mark’s presumed death is never resolved.

There are other elements significant to the album, such as the mention of the fictional drug “гор” (gor). Like the album’s name, this could be derived from either the words for

mountain (гора, gora) or woe (горе, gore). Kira is the first character to mention it, warning Mark at the end of track 2 to "go easy on" the drug before attending Von Glen's reelection party.[206] It is more explicitly introduced in track 5 as the Guru raps: "Но чья наркоимперия, по-твоему, по артериям города гонит эти контейнеры с отходами/ Переработки, добытой под горою рудой, проданной за бугор/ Пока дома, в лабораториях, из её же отходов путём обработки/ Гонят в народ тот самый наркотик, что называется гор? ("But whose drug empire do you think is running through these containers of waste through the city's arteries, mined under a mountain of ore and sold abroad? While at home, in the laboratories, they push the same drug called gor to the people, made from its waste.")[207] The implication here is that the city's mayor, Von Glen, is producing this drug to control the population, something akin to the substances in Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) and George Orwell's *1984*. It is the literary, historical, and philosophical allusions in *Gorgorod*, that further connect the album, and the Oxxxymiron persona, to literature and intellectualism; an association that is made through his battle rap career as well as his ensuing industry career.

3.1.1 On the Album's Reception and Ensuing Dialogues

Gorgorod was quickly lauded upon its release by a wide range of listeners. Vladimir Zavyalov of *Afisha Daily* writes that *Gorgorod's* place on the pedestal of Russian rap is well deserved, noting that it brought the genre to places it has never been before: "на столах литературоведов, в головах у сорокалетних интеллигентов из фейсбука и в ушах студентов магистратуры гуманитарных вузов" ("on the desks of literary scholars, in the heads

[206] The final line of Кем Ты Стал (Who you Became) is: "Только полегче с гором, а то сам знаешь." or "Go easy on gor, otherwise, you know…"

[207] Переплетено, "Intertwined."

of Facebook-using 40-something members of the intelligentsia, and in the ears of graduate students of humanities universities.”)[208] The fact is that the album expanded Oxxxymiron’s reach to new micro-publics, which in turn affects the reception and conception of his persona through the online social interactions in which these publics engaged with the work and artist. The general description of Oxxxymiron and his fans are mockingly summarized by the Russian rapper Alisher “Morgenshtern” Morgenshtern when he states: “Wow какие тексты. Он поэт, wow. Умный. Круто думать. Люблю думать, слушаю Оксимирона, я умный” (“Wow, what texts. He’s a poet, wow. Smart. Thinking is cool. I love to think. I listen to Oxxxymiron. I’m smart.”) (see Fig. 23) [209][210] Indeed, *Gorgorod* spurs a public and academic discussion about rap as a literary genre, some arguing that Oxxxymiron’s work is modern poetry, and others fixating on his literary and biblical references. Writer and poet Dmitry Bykov, amongst other public comments on Oxxxymiron, published a blog post about how the *Imperivm* tour shows that poetry can and

Figure 23: A still of Morgenshtern from his vDud apperance.

[208] Vladimir Zavyalov, “Pochemu ‘Gorgorod’ Oksimirona Ostalsya v 2015 Godu.” [Why Oxxxymiron’s ‘Gorgorod’ stayed in 2015], *Afisha Daily,* November 10, 2020, https://daily.afisha.ru/music/17719-pochemu-gorgorod-oksimirona-ostalsya-v-2015-godu/

[209] Yuri Dud (@вДудь). “*MORGENSHTERN – Glavnyj Shoumen Rossii-2020 / Russian Entertainer #1*.” [*MORGENSHTERN – Main Russian Showman-2020 / Russian Entertainer #1],* November 3, 2020, 32:59-33:13, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AR6ovvs6Ihg.

[210] It is worth noting that Morgenshtern and Oxxxymiron exchanged diss tracks in 2023. Morgenshtern released “Я убил Марка (Окси дисс)” [I killed Mark (Oxxxy diss)] and Oxxxymiron replied with “THE STORY OF ALISHER (Morgenshtern RIP).”

should be performed in stadiums.[211] One situation involving a non-public individual that makes this discussion viral is the story of eleventh-grader Anastasia An who recited lines from an Oxxxymiron song ("Intertwined") for a literature assignment under the guise that they were from a poem of Osip Mandelstam's.[212] She allegedly received an A+ on the assignment.[213]

It is not just *Gorgorod,* but Oxxxymiron's oeuvre in general that lend to the literary and high culture associations with the Oxxxymiron persona. Indeed, Fyodorov's degree in Medieval literature is mentioned in profiles throughout the years. The Internet is rife with blog and vlog posts concerning Oxxxymiron and literature, including his perceived inspirations and how his work connects to Russian literary traditions. However, these literary themes are also derived in part from Fyodorov's creative decision in making *Gorgorod's* Mark a writer struggling with writer's block. One of the album's central points is that Mark struggles with writer's block until he meets Alice and is introduced to the guru's philosophy. Kira's voicemails subtly chastise Mark for not having written and serve as reminder of a deadline just weeks away. For Fyodorov, this was all too real as *Gorgorod*'s release was delayed nearly a year due to his creative struggles. When he does write the album, he does so in a hurry, claiming to have written it in just three weeks, and finalizing one song the day before a concert where he would present the album. He describes this urgency as an explicit connection between him and Mark, stating:

---

[211] Dmitry Bykov, "Nuzhno Li Poezii Vyhodit Na Stadiony, Kak Polveka Nazad?" [Should Poetry be Presented at Stadiums, like 50 Years Ago?], *BykovFM.* September 21, 2023, https://bykovfm.ru/nuzhno-li-poezii-vyhodit-na-stadiony-kak-polveka-nazad-461af2.

[212] Her recitation can be found here: youtube.com/watch?v=ClVqPtilD80&embeds_referring_euri=https%3A%2F%2Frg.ru%2F&source_ve_path=OTY3MTQ

[213] Belta, "Shkol'nyj skandal: starsheklassnitsa vydala rap za stikhi Mandel'stama i poluchila 'pyatyerku.'" [School scandal: upperclassman presents rap to the verses of Mandelstam and received an A+], *Belta,* February 4, 2016, https://belta.by/kaleidoscope/view/shkolnyj-skandal-starsheklassnitsa-vydala-rep-za-stihi-mandelshtama-i-poluchila-pjaterku-180222-2016/.

> Это место, в котором мы с героем альбома пересекаемся: я в спешке, накануне выхода альбома и питерского концерта, едва успевая записывать неожиданно полившиеся из меня строчки, писал о писателе, который в спешке пишет "Где нас нет" накануне роковых событий. Это было невероятно странное эйфорическое ощущение. Многослойное переплетение реальности и вымысла, рекурсия — называй, как хочешь.[214]
>
> This is a place where me and the album's protagonist intersect: me, in a hurry, on the eve of my album's release and the Petersburg concert, barely managing to write lines that are unexpectedly pouring out of me, writing about a writer who is writing "Where We are Not" in a hurry on the eve of fatal circumstances. It was an incredibly strange euphoric feeling. A multilayered interweaving of reality and fiction, a recursion – call it what you want.

Fyodorov's naming of the situation as a "recursion" demonstrates that Mark is both his creation, and representative of a part of him. Audiences like to believe the latter, and it is Oxxxymiron's writing of Mark that contributes to this. Other similarities include that Mark and Fyodorov are both 30 years old in 2015, and both were successful in their respective fields after releasing one work (an album, a novel) and felt paralyzed by the process of preparing to release another (a second album, a manuscript). As *The Flow* staff writes, "В фигуре Марка было сложно не увидеть самого рэпера, столкнувшегося с прессингом и испытанием вторым альбомом" ("It was not hard to see the rapper in the figure of Mark, faced with the pressure and challenge of a second album.")[215] All of these contributing factors led audiences to receive Mark as a fictionalized version of Oxxxymiron: a rapper (writer) living in Putin's Russia (Gorgorod), contemplating his political self, his growing complacency, and his creative status.

Returning to the initial point, Fyodorov claims to have written the album in three weeks but only admits this after *Gorgorod* was positively received by audiences.[216] This speaks both to

---

[214] Andrei Nedashkovsky,"Porchy i Oxxxymiron: 'Bol'she, Chem Sem'ya.' Chast' 1."

[215] The Flow.ru, "20 rep alb'omov 2010-h. Oxxxymiron 'Gorgorod'" [The 20 rap albums of the 2010s. Oxxxymiron 'Gorgorod," *The-Flow.ru,* March 6, 2017, https://the-flow.ru/top20/oxxxymiron-gorgorod.

[216] Andrei Nedashkovsky,"Porchy i Oxxxymiron: 'Bol'she, Chem Sem'ya.' Chast' 1."

the intercommunication between the fictional Mark and Oxxxymiron as discussed, but also to the Oxxxymiron persona. Fyodorov uses the audience's reactions to shape the narrative around Oxxxymiron's creative production; if *Gorgorod* was received poorly, therefore making evident that it was written quickly, Fyodorov says he would not have made this detail public. Understanding this internal process of impression management demonstrates Fyodorov's intentional construction of Oxxxymiron. When he releases "Who Killed Mark?" in 2021, Fyodorov deepens this curation by making explicit the connection between the titular Mark and the subject(s) of the new track: Miron Fyodorov and Oxxxymiron.

3.2 On "Who Killed Mark" and Deconstructing Persona

Oxxxymiron's hiatus from public life lasts a year, until КОГДА АЛЬБОМ begins to reverberate across the Internet. At this point in his career, long pauses and delayed or uncommunicated deadlines are expectations, part of his ethos as an artist and public persona. The first track that Oxxxymiron releases as part of this public relations campaign is the single titled "Who Killed Mark?" which, at the time of its debut, is his first original single to appear in two years. It is initially released in video format on YouTube and subsequently becomes available on streaming platforms. At ten-minute-and-thirty-two-seconds "Who Killed Mark?" makes an immediate impression. Not only is its length notable, but its subject matter is also unprecedented in Oxxxymiron's repertoire: it recounts a real public feud, an open secret, and their effects on both Oxxxymiron's career and Miron Fyodorov's private life. By referencing Mark, Fyodorov both connects and frees the Oxxxymiron persona from remnants of its past.

3.2.1 On Friends, Foes, and Feuds

For years, Russian hip hop fans were privy to public feuds between Oxxxymiron, his rap partner Schokk (Dmitry Hinter), and another Russian rapper, Roma Zhigan (Roman Chumakov). Though independent rappers, Oxxxymiron and Schokk were collaborators who shared a label and a rap style: Russophone rap with a German twist. The antagonism of their lyrics against other rappers comes from the German rap scene, though it was common in other parts of the world, such as U.S. hip hop where "rap beefs" were popularized. As Fyodorov tells DJ Vlad: "[…] when I first appeared I was kind of trying to position myself as the antagonist to the existing Russian rap, so you know I used to diss all the old school people."[217] This antagonism is what the Russian music journalist Nikolai Redkin refers to as "спортивная злость" (competitive animosity).[218] It is an element of battle rap that entered the mainstream, used primarily to make a name for the rappers who do the insulting; Redkin attributes this antagonism to the ethos of German hip hop at the time, though other Western rap scenes, notably, the American scene were was known for its aggression. While Oxxxymiron and Schokk both succeeded in fusing Russian language with the aggression of the German rap scene, doing so was taking a risk: they assumed their primarily Russian audience would understand and accept their style. This assumption was true, to an extent, as they individually began building a Russophone fan base. Yet, they also created enemies for whom their attacks did not land well in the Russian context.

During the late aughts, and the years that follow, Oxxxymiron and Schokk tried to make names for themselves in the Russian rap scene, a cultural scape where battle rap was not yet a popular genre understood for its purposeful, but reciprocal personal attacks. Despite dissing

---

[217] Vlad Lyubovny, Oxxxymiron on Russian Hip Hop, Battle Rap, Dizaster, Putin (Full Interview), 10:56-11:00.

[218] Nikolai Redkin, "V novom klipe Oksimiron desyat' minut chitaet o svoyem konflikte s Romoj Zhiganom." [In a new clip, Oxxxymiron reads about his feud with Roma Zhigan for ten minutes], Meduza, November 1, 2021, https://meduza.io/feature/2021/11/01/v-novom-klipe-oksimiron-desyat-minut-chitaet-o-svoem-konflikte-s-romoy-zhiganom.

others without cessation, the feud that intertwines them for years to come is not the result of a personal attack. The rapper who instigates a falling out between Schokk and Oxxxymiron, and creates a public spectacle of the two, is not one whom they personally diss. At least, that is how one version of the narrative goes.

Roman "Roma Zhigan" Chumakov is a nationalist Russian rapper from the Moscow region with a criminal past. The stage name "Zhigan" is derived from criminal slang and can be translated to mean "thief;" a nod to Chumakov's early years in the prison system. Chumakov began rapping in 2002 at the age of 18. In that same year, he was convicted of car theft and sentenced to four years in prison. He picked up rapping again upon his release but became more widely known as Roma Zhigan, after winning the competitive television show *Битва за Респект 3* (Battle for Respect 3), in 2009. Vladimir Putin, then prime minister of the Russian Federation, was present for the show's finale and congratulated Chumakov with a handshake.[219] It is this anecdote that earns Roma Zhigan the nickname "Putin's favorite rapper."

As noted, there is no personal incident, no lyric or choice of words that Schokk or Oxxxymiron use against Roma Zhigan. He is seemingly not on their radar when he takes it upon himself to be offended by their language, a point characteristic of a rapper who is openly patriotic and nationalist. In an interview with Andrei Nikitin, which broaches the topics of prison life, nationalism, and his problems with Schokk, Zhigan describes his problem with Schokk and why he decides to take physical action against him and Oxxxymiron.[220] His narrative goes as follows.

---

[219] BBC News Russian, "Reper Zhigan zaderzhan po podozreniyu v razboe." [Rapper Zhigan arrested as suspect in robbery], *BBC News Russian,* December 12, 2013, https://www.bbc.com/russian/russia/2013/12/131212_russian_rapper_arrested.

[220] Andrei Nikitin, "Zhigan: 'Davajte Zhit' Druzhno.'" [Zhigan: 'Let's Live Amicably'], *Rap. ru,* December 14, 2011, https://www.rap.ru/reading/188.

In October 2011, Oxxxymiron (Fyodorov) and Schokk (Hinter) were staying in Moscow before embarking on a tour of Russia. During their stay, they arranged to meet with an alleged concert promoter who had contacted them before their arrival in the city. The pair, along with Schokk's girlfriend at the time, were hanging out in a rented apartment, expecting to meet the promoter. They were instead surprised by Roma Zhigan (Chumakov) and a crew of unknown men. What transpires after their arrival is questioning, intimidation, forced apologies, and physical violence. At separate points both Fyodorov and Hinter are directed to kneel in front of Chumakov and apologize before they are each slapped across the face. The ordeal is recorded and bits of video, some with audio, others without, are posted as fragments on the Internet. The video of a kneeling Hinter is released shortly after the incident, making its way through the RuNet. Chumakov explains his decision to take physical action against the pair in an interview with Andrei Nikitin in December 2011. His quotes appear in several parts of the interview, and two points are combined here for clarity:

> Шок просто всем надоел, а Жига единственный, кто приехал и дал ему по голове. […] Просто надоел этот тип. В тюрьме скажи: "Я твою маму ебал" или назови пидорасом необоснованно, возьмут заточку и все. А он же кричал, что он сидел. А в новом интервью уже говорит, что не сидел и пишу заявление. Я сделал вывод, что он пиздобол. […] Пусть вспомнит, как он говорил всякую чушь про того мать, про этого мать в своих песнях. Это бумеранг — ты его запустил, он вернулся и ударил в два раза сильнее.[221]
>
> Everyone was basically tired of Schokk, and Zhiggy was the only one who showed up and gave him a blow to the head. I was basically sick of his type. Say "I fucked your mom" or baselessly call someone a faggot in prison, you'll get shanked and that's it. And here he was saying that he went to prison. Then in a new interview he says that never went to prison and he's filing charges (against me). I concluded that he's full of shit. […] Let him remember all the nonsense he said about this person's mother, and that person's mother in his songs. It's a boomerang – you threw it, and it came back to hit you twice as hard.

[221] Andrei Nikitin, "Zhigan: 'Davajte Zhit' Druzhno.'"

Chumakov refers to a singular "he," Schokk, and speaks of him as the sole antagonist. He does mention Oxxxymiron in this same interview, by acknowledging that he was in the apartment as well but does not malign or blame him the way he does Schokk. This disparate treatment has to do with how Hinter responds to the altercation: he flees Russia and publicly says that he will file charges against Chumakov. Fyodorov, on the other hand, publicly releases an explanatory video after he leaves Moscow. The video, recorded on St. Petersburg's Palace Square, describes the situation between Zhigan and Vagabund (Oxxxymiron and Schokk), and the status of Vagabund in the aftermath. Fyodorov indirectly apologizes to Chumakov, since the latter takes offense to the former's insulting words, though he makes clear that his words were never intended to be a personal attack. Yet, he adds a context that signals to the audience that he has no choice but to take these words back: "Я не считаю постыдным взять эти слова назад при явным физическим давлением" (I do not consider it shameful to take these words back under open physical intimidation.)[222].He admits that it is physical aspect of the incident that pressures him to apologize, rather than a genuine feeling of wrongdoing on his part.

What is more significant is that the video marks the end of Vagabund, with Fyodorov clarifying that it is not Chumakov who breaks up the label, but Hinter himself. He states: "Я понимаю, что у Рома Жигана сейчас есть все основания торжествовать, действительно, считая, что он развалил команду, что ему это удалось. Но по факту, к сожалению, это сделал Дима, своими непоследовательными словами и действиями" ("I understand that Roma Zhigan has every reason to celebrate, believing that he indeed succeeded in breaking up the team. But unfortunately, Dima [Schokk] is the one who did it with his inconsistent words and

[222] Stas Pro, "Oksimiron Izvinyaetsya. Roma Zhigan. Shok. (Oxxxymiron Izvinyaetsya\schokk Na Kolenyah) Original." [Oxxxymiron apologizes. Roma Zhigan. Shock. (Oxxxymiron apologizes\schokk is on his knees) Original], YouTube, August 7, 2019,1:13-1:21, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DYWCKP75Hgc.

actions.”)[223] It is Hinter’s rash decision to flee Russia after the incident with Chumakov, and announce that he would be filing charges, unbeknownst to his labelmates, that causes the rift. The swiftness of Hinter’s actions and his disregard for others involved led Fyodorov to announce the end of their relationship.

Though Oxxxymiron and Schokk stop working and seeing each other in 2011, the two artists remain tied together. What evolves between Hinter, Fyodorov, and Chumakov, profoundly affects Fyodorov’s personal and professional life as Oxxxymiron over the next ten years. It has a paradoxical effect on Fyodorov, fueling his career trajectory as it corrodes his psychological and physical health. In “Who Killed Mark?” Oxxxymiron reveals the burden these relationship have on him, opting to finally face the truth on his own terms, rather than repress it with obfuscation and silence. The track’s release marks a turn toward a new persona, one that faces challenges rather than avoids them. Thus, the conflicts between Oxxxymiron and Schokk and Zhigan, respectively, prove to be a catalyst for slow moving change from an unsure and fearful persona to a confident and transparent one.

3.2.2 On Bearing it All: Recounting the Pain of Silence

Ten years to the day of the incident, on November 1, 2021, Oxxxymiron releases “Who Killed Mark?” in video format on YouTube, with the single appearing on streaming platforms in the following days. Using the medium of video gives Fyodorov the agency to release critical footage to contextualize the song’s themes which deal with personal and professional struggles. The footage at hand lived in Russian hip hop lore for exactly ten years; it is a clip of Fyodorov the night of the altercation with Roma Zhigan. The opening shot displays the following text:

[223] Stas Pro, “Oksimiron Izvinyaetsya. Roma Zhigan. Shok. (Oxxxymiron Izvinyaetsya\schokk Na Kolenyah) Original,” 3:10-3:35.

“Следующее видео могло выйти 01.11.2011 но выходит ровно 10 лет спустя” (“The following video could have been released on November 1, 2011, but it’s being released exactly ten years later .”)[224] The referenced video clip then follows, showing Fyodorov and Hinter kneeling in front of Chumakov, flanked by a masked man and two others whose faces are out of frame. The following words are exchanged:

> Чумаков: Проси прощения.
> Фёдоров: Прошу прощения.
> Чумаков: За что?
> Фёдоров: За то, что себя вёл неподобающим образом.
> Чумаков: Иди сюда.[225]
>
> Chumakov: Ask for forgiveness.
> Fyodorov: I ask for forgiveness.
> Chumakov: For what?
> Fyodorov: For acting in an inappropriate manner.
> Chumakov: Come here.

After he delivers the final line, Chumakov slaps Fyodorov across the face (see Fig. 24).[226] After an exact decade of living in Russian hip-hop lore, the “Oxxxymiron slap video” finally materializes, and it is released of the rapper’s own accord. Unlike the snippets of the altercation that live in pockets of the Internet, or the Palace Square apology video, this one becomes public on Fyodorov’s terms. It opens the

Figure 24: Chumakov slapping Oxxxymiron. This footage was released in the "Who Killed Mark?" video.

[224] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), “Kto ubil Marka?” [Who Killed Mark?], YouTube, November 1, 2021, 0:11-0:14, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=q92DWs1MwRA

[225] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), “Kto ubil Marka?,” 0:15-0:20 seconds.

[226] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), “Kto ubil Marka?,” 0:22 seconds.

“Who Killed Mark?” video, providing an obvious subtext to a single whose subject is a pleated recounting of Fyodorov’s rise as Oxxxymiron in a nascent Russian hip hop scene, and the tribulations of fame and public attention alongside it. The clip only appears in the video; it is omitted in the audio version. It is significant, then, that the video is released first: audiences are confronted with footage that shapes the way to interpret the song’s lyrics, themes, and meaning.

The opening clip is the first signal that the single engenders revelation. The ensuing video’s format, set up in a confessional style, is the second; and Oxxxymiron’s conversational address to the audience, is the third. These elements all appear within the video’s first sixty seconds. After the altercation clip, the video transitions into a set where a black clad Oxxxymiron sits in a bare, dark space under a spotlight. The camera faces him and slowly pans in closer until it cuts to a shot in which his face fills half of the frame. His eyes look straight at the camera as he begins the first verse: “Знаешь чувство, будто забуксовал /Где-то свернул не туда и путь стал замысловат/ И ты ходишь кругами, подбирая слова/ Сознавая: всё исправить можно, лишь вернувшись назад” (“You know the feeling as if you came to a standstill/ You turned the wrong way somewhere and got mixed up/ And you’re walking in circles, fumbling words/ Realizing that you could fix everything if you could go back in time.”)[227] He begins the track with an informal question using, “знаешь” (“you know?”), a verb in the second person singular form, used to address one individual. The full question he asks is “Do you know that feeling, as if you came to a standstill? / You turned the wrong way somewhere and got mixed up / And you walk in circles, fumbling words / Realizing that you could fix everything if you could go back in time.” This verse draws individual audience members in by its intimate address and framing: Oxxxymiron speaks as if to one person and puts

[227] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), “Kto ubil Marka?” 0:42-0:52.

that person in the position of being psychologically lost. His question is rhetorical; its function is to demonstrate the headspace that he wants his audience to imagine someone being in. The verse continues: "Контрамарки — да, действительны, кинолента идёт долго/ Запаситесь терпеньем и поп-корном/ Распишитесь и получите:/Ретроспектива столь симптоматична, сколь поучительна" ("Vouchers– yeah they're real, it's a long film reel/ Stock up on patience and popcorn/ Sign up and you will receive/A retrospective that's as symptomatic as it is informative.")[228] Halfway through the verse, his language shifts to the second person plural which indicates an address to multiple individuals at once. This shift to a plural audience is aided by the filmic motif in the opening lines in which he refers to контрамарки, кинолента, and поп-корн(vouches, a film reel and popcorn), the latter also functioning as a reference to the Internet phase "get your popcorn ready" used to indicate an amusing or entertaining story. This motif suggests not only that the ensuing content will be entertaining, but it also colors the context as fictional. As if the people referenced are actors, playing characters to keep the audience entertained. In the final lines, he refers to the track as "ретроспектива столь симптоматична, сколь поучительна" ("a symptomatic and informative retrospective") nearly eleven minutes of revisiting the past, as a means of illustrating Oxxxymiron's career trajectory and Miron Fyodorov's inner struggles over the last ten years. He begins this retrospective with a personal and cultural history of Russian hip hop.

Immediately preceding the initial verse, Oxxxymiron quickens his flow and launches into his version of Russian hip hop history, beginning in "конец двухтысячных" ("the late aughts"). He refers to this period as the "ice age" of Russian hip hop, as accompanying video snippets illustrate the scene at the time: brief clips of Krip-a-Krip, Smoky Mo, and other rappers in the

[228] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?" 0:52-1:03.

early stages of their careers flash on the screen. The following verse and clips turn inward, revealing critical information to Miron Fyodorov's personal life and career trajectory, and how the former influenced the latter. In the early 2000s, at the time that the Russophone hip hop community largely interacted and created on Internet platforms like the referenced Myspace, Fyodorov had a desire to be known. This is evident when he raps that he had "яркие мечты объявить им что я есть" ("bright dreams to show them that I'm here."), but this desire was incongruent with his feelings of low self-esteem and not belonging. As he recites the following verse, the video set transitions to a chronological montage of photos and videos from Fyodorov's youth, from toddlerhood to teenagerhood: "Ведь тот, кто в детстве, как цепку и амулет/ Таскал клеймо жертвы с самооценкою на нуле/Долгих несколько лет/ После всю жизнь стоит перед выбором: сдаться, измениться внутри либо компенсировать/Я выбрал третье и стал бороться вовсю" ("'Cause he with zero self-esteem who wore the brand of the victim in childhood like a chain and charm/ Is faced with a lifelong decision after a few years: give up, change internally, or compensate./I chose the third and fought everything with a vengeance.")[229] The verse begins with the description of an anonymous person (тот), who has embodied insecurity throughout his life and must make one of three choices to deal with his lot: give up, change, or compensate. It ends, however, with a direct reference to Fyodorov as the final line reads "I chose the third [option] and fought with a vengeance."

The photo and video montage reiterate the song's function as a retrospective of Fyodorov's life and career, but it is the final line that signifies something beyond a biographical and professional history. In this case "compensation" is the process of creating a persona, a version of oneself that is not a victim of one's reality, in this case, insecurity. It is rap, more

[229] Miron Fyodorov, (@oxxxymironofficial), "Кто убил Марка?», 1:14-1:27.

specifically battle rap, that provides the antidote to Fyodorov's low self-esteem; he makes himself appear confident through building an antagonistic and aggressive rap persona:

> Против мира вдали от мест, где родные берёзки растут
> Мой максимализм: я всех этих бонз обоссу
> И баттл-рэп сходу налез, как супергеройский костюм
> В нём я умел всё, о чём не мог и мечтать
> И пришло время закрывать подростковый гештальт. Стала жизнь, как я себе тщательно рисовал. Жаль, костюм забыл научить отвечать за свои слова[230]
>
> Against the world, far from the place where the native birch trees grow
> My maximalism: I'll piss on all the top brass
> And battle rap fit like a superhero's suit
> In it I could do anything that I dreamed of
> And then came the time to close the teenage gestalt
> Life became as I carefully painted it
> It's a pity that the suit forgot to teach me to be responsible for my own words

In perhaps the most direct public self-reflection of his career, Fyodorov identifies an issue that is central to the modern world of celebrity personas: you can put on a costume to make yourself appear a certain way, but it is the one who wears the costume, not the costume itself, that suffers the consequences and faces accountability. Fyodorov positions Oxxxymiron as an aggressive and confident battle rapper who insults other rappers as part of his charade. He tries to compensate for his self-identified flaws by creating a persona that is antithetical. Yet, when others take offense to his words, Fyodorov reaps what Oxxxymiron has sown. The same Fyodorov plagued by feelings of low self-esteem and not belonging. It is this dynamic, that of the dichotomous persona-persona, that ravages Miron Fyodorov for a decade.

After this crucial admission, Fyodorov shifts topics to his creative partnership and friendship with Dmitry "Schokk" Hinter. He uses the same analytical lens to Schokk as he does to Oxxxymiron, attempting to show the audience that both personas will receive the same

[230] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?" 1:28-1:45.

treatment. Yet, his criticism of Schokk is notably sharper. Within the first few bars, Fyodorov describes Schokk as a "full-fledged psychopath" and someone with an "unsteady psyche," descriptions that contrast the victim-mentality and insecurity he uses to describe himself. Furthering the distinction between the two, he describes their dissing of other Russophone rappers. He claims that while they were both sincere in their disses, he focused on other rappers' styles and flows, while Schokk threatened them and insulted their families. In other words, Oxxxymiron stayed within the unspoken rules of the genre, but it was Schokk who went out of bounds. Hinter's behavior also personally affects Fyodorov – he describes Hinter as an antagonist and calls their friendship "toxic." While Fyodorov differentiates between himself and his persona, Oxxxymiron, he simultaneously demonstrates that Hinter and Schokk are more alike than different: both aggressive, antagonistic, and careless. In addition to giving insight into the two rappers' relationship, these details also serve another function: creating a distance between Oxxxymiron and the more egregious aspects of Vagabund's ethos. This is critical as Oxxxymiron sets up the incident with Roma Zhigan in the following verse.

As the track continues, Fyodorov claims that in mid-October 2011, he informed Schokk of his plans to leave Vagabund after the conclusion of their tour. Two weeks later they performed in Moscow and, as Oxxxymiron raps with a dramatic reference, Roma Zhigan enters the stage: "[…] но ровно тогда/ Судьбой в античной пьесе на сцену входит Рома Жиган" ("And just then, like Fate of an ancient play, Zhigan enters the stage.")[231] He likens Zhigan to fate, as it was portrayed in ancient theater: a life altering force. This dramatic trope is akin to the filmic references in his opening verse, reminding audiences that those mentioned are but actors, all with their own roles to play. He includes another filmic reference here that reinforces his life,

[231] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?" 2:25-2:28.

and the situation, as spectacle rather than reality, stating "Так с мюзикла сменился жанр кино на боевик" ("And that's how the film genre changed from musical to action movie.")[232] Though the incident with Roma Zhigan sets the tone for the entire song, Fyodorov dedicates only a few lines to the altercation, interspersing them with lessons he learned through the situation:"Но я попал под каток, враг мой – язык мой/ Так что первый урок, поскорей, парнишка, бросай/Говорить лишь издали то, что ты не повторишь в глаза/ И второй, не поддакивай косякам/Ведь когда снега настигают тебя, ты сам за себя" ("But I feel under pressure, my tongue is my enemy/ So, here's the first lesson, boy: stop saying behind one's back what you wouldn't say to his face/ And second: don't play along with mishaps/When they pelt you with snow, you must fend for yourself.")[233] Rather than blame Roma Zhigan, he reveals that the situation taught him the necessity of being accountable for one's words and being able to stand up for oneself. In calling his own language his enemy, he takes accountability for himself, but he also removes the power of the altercation from Roma Zhigan. This reinforces what Fyodorov said in his apology video a decade prior: it is not Roma Zhigan who broke up Vagabund, it was Hinter and his treatment of Fyodorov. This sense of power is complicated, however, with Oxxxymiron's retelling of the incident's aftermath. Fyodorov says that Hinter doubled down and worsened the situation by claiming that he and Fyodorov would file a police report, while he took the peaceful route and released an apology video. These actions resulted in Roma Zhigan releasing the "Schokk slap video," but not the "Oxxxymiron slap video." The public perception is that Roma Zhigan and Oxxxymiron have squashed their beef, and Schokk and Roma Zhigan have not. The reality is that Fyodorov apologized to prevent Roma Zhigan

[232] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?" 2:23-2:34.

[233] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?" 2:37-2:50.

from releasing the Oxxxymiron slap video. He is successful in this endeavor but pays for this decision in a way he was not prepared for. He explains the consequence as such: “Молчание — это клад, золото либо кляп/ Но я не подозревал, как оно изменит меня” (“Silence is a treasure, gold, or a gag/But I didn’t suspect that it would change me.”)[234] The same Fyodorov that refers to his language as his enemy reveals a more unsuspecting adversary: silence.

As he delivers this final line, Oxxxymiron, still clad in black in a bare dark room, stands from seated and with a swift motion of his right arm, transforms himself and the enveloping video set (see Figs. 25 and 26).This visual change ushers in what Fyodorov calls “новая глава” (“a new chapter”). Here he speaks of his life and career after breaking off from Vagabund and Schokk’s friendship. However, this phrase can also be used to describe the next section of his song and video, which I refer to as “Part II.” In Part II of the video, Oxxxymiron wears a shiny blue latex puffer jacket and wide black latex pants. The video set glows red with mechanical elements visible as the camera is positioned close to the floor and pans upward. Strobe lights flash from behind Oxxxymiron as he raps, and other effects appear as Part II

Figure 25: The image that ends Part I of "Who Killed Mark?"

Figure 26: The image that begins Part II of "Who Killed Mark?"

[234] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), “Kto ubil Marka?,” 3:27-3:31.

continues. The visual, performative, and textual elements work together to create a more energized and confident atmosphere as opposed to the serious and static tone of Part I.

3.2.3 On Laying it All Bare: Speaking About the Past

In Part II of "Кто Убил Марка," Oxxxymiron traverses his public and private histories in tandem. Unlike the chronology and accompanying revelations of Part I, this section successively juxtaposes Oxxxymiron's career achievements with Miron Fyodorov's private psychological struggles and their physical manifestations. These layers are disparate, with professional endeavors summarized in single words and phrases, and the deterioration of Fyodorov's mental and physical health imparted in detail. Oxxxymiron takes audiences along a suspension bridge of internalization, silence, fear, and victimhood, laying it all bare before stepping onto the steady ground of self-acceptance.

As stated in Part II's introductory lines, Oxxxymiron's "new chapter" begins with relocating to Russia where he "restarts his career from scratch" – he releases his first mixtape (miXXXtape I), begins working with beat maker and producer Dario "Porchy" Vieira, and, in 2017, becomes executive director of Booking Machine, a small, independent booking and management agency. These early events and relationships are foundational for Oxxxymiron as he assumes a prominent role in the Russian rap scene. For instance, Porchy whom he met through a mutual friend in London in 2011 and who produced some of his earliest singles and his most critically acclaimed album, *Gorgorod,* becomes a close collaborator and friend.[235] Despite his ascension in Russian rap and popular culture, Fyodorov is still preoccupied with a singular low point of then recent memory: the incident with Roma Zhigan. While Oxxxymiron releases

[235] Andrei Nedashkovsky, "Porchy i Oxxxymiron: 'Bol'she, Chem Sem'ya.' Chast' 1."

new music, expands Booking Machine's artist roster, and grows in popularity, Miron Fyodorov experiences anxiety and depression over the unreleased "Oxxxymiron slap video." In his own words, the reality of Roma Zhigan's kompromat, or compromising information, gnaws away at Fyodorov: "Тревоги и депрессии — гнёт великоват/ У Ромы Жигана на полке компромат" (Anxiety and depression are too oppressive/ Roma Zhigan has kompromat on his shelves).[236] The dichotomy of Oxxxymiron's professional flourishing and Miron Fyodorov's festering is expounded in Part II.

His fear of the kompromat being released causes Fyodorov to feel that he must "compromise" to keep it on the shelf. Though his interactions with Roma Zhigan are rare, Fyodorov takes the video's existence into his career decision making, which highlights his preoccupation with the incident. Fyodorov feels controlled by the sheer possibility of its release due to any action or inaction he takes so he begins to make compromises to prevent the video's release. The first of the compromises cited in "Who Killed Mark?" is the public apology video; the second is appearing in Roma Zhigan's 2019 Russian rap documentary, *Beef*. Unlike the apology video which is received well by fans in contrast to Schokk's continued public feud with Roma Zhigan, Oxxxymiron's appearance in *Beef*, in his own words, gives the "illusion of friendship" between he and Zhigan, which shocks his fans. Fyodorov alludes to feeling that, by agreeing to be in the documentary he cosigns with Roma Zhigan and that which he stands for. Nevertheless, he simultaneously undercuts Zhigan, rapping: "Рома — православный патриот, ладно/ Вроде как шантаж— это не слишком православно" (Roma is an Orthodox patriot, alright/ It seems like blackmail isn't very Orthodox though).[237] That is, he does not want to be

[236] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?," 3:48-3:53.

[237] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?," 3:57-3:59.

associated with nationalism, patriotism, or Orthodoxy, but he also undermines Zhigan's reputation by highlighting that his behaviors (blackmail) are not representative of his persona.

What fixates Fyodorov more is how the film, released eight years after the incident, conjures up a more pronounced personal, and a public, memory of the "open secret" of the Oxxxymiron slap video. He provides audiences with a stark visualization of his perception of the incident eight years on when he raps "Скелет в моём шкафу по новой обрастает мясом" (the skeleton in [his] closet regrows its flesh).[238] Zhigan's documentary actualizes the kompromat whose exposure Fyodorov so long lived with as hypothetical, and when faced with a real possibility of its release, Fyodorov feels powerless, rapping of the choice to appear in the documentary: "Я всё это хаваю, у меня нет выбора/ Если не хочу, чтоб мои будущие дети в школе увидали видео/ С отцом на коленях и пощёчиной/ И делаю то, что от меня хочет он" ("I eat it all up, I don't have a choice/If I don't want my future kids to see a video in school/Of their father on his knees getting slapped in the face/ I do what he [Zhigan] wants.")[239] The shift in control of the kompromat, as Oxxxymiron describes it, is a display of his victimhood, and his projection into the future of imagining his children witnessing their father in a vulnerable position emphasizes how permanently Fyodorov imagines himself a victim.

While Oxxxymiron appears to blame Zhigan for his renewed victim status, the realization that unfolds in the remaining sections of Part II of "Who Killed Mark?" is that Fyodorov compromises at his own expense; he justifies giving in to Zhigan's perceived or direct demands to protect himself from ridicule, even in the hypothetical scenario of his non-existent children watching the video. What occurs instead of self-protection is self-affliction: Fyodorov is harmed

[238] Andrei Nedashkovsky, "Porchy i Oxxxymiron: 'Bol'she, Chem Sem'ya.' Chast' 1."

[239] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?," 4:05-4:14.

by his approach to the conflict, which amounts to keeping silent and compromising. He describes the resulting consequences on his mental and physical health in detail, beginning with a demonstrative internal dialogue:

> Я сломал игру, но подсел на самоцензуру тут абсолютно во всём
> Это нельзя сказать, ведь я фан-базу оскорблю
> А это нельзя, поскольку меня сразу засмеют
> Это нельзя — моя семья читает меня часто
> А вот это точно нельзя — это небезопасно
> Психосоматика, я сдавленная пружина
> Мышечные зажимы страх, что я не мужчина
> Молчание затягивает молчащего, как трясина
> Болотка, Pussy Riot, репрессии, Украина
> Я всё игнорирую, но боль не уходит
> Я качаюсь до блевоты, курю до крови в мокроте
> Запои, наркотики, я всё убегаю
> В постели снова другая, но и это ноль помогает
> Каждый оппонент на баттле стелет про лещей мне
> Запретная тема, но секрет Полишинеля[240]
>
> I broke the game, but got hooked on self-censorship in everything
> That's forbidden to say, 'cause I might offend my fans
> And that's forbidden, 'cause they'll laugh at me right away
> That's forbidden – my family reads my stuff often
> And that's for sure forbidden, that's not safe
> Psychosomatics, I'm a compressed spring
> Muscle spasms, fear that I'm not a man
> Silence buries the silent, like quicksand
> Bolotka, Pussy Riot, repressions, Ukraine[241]
> I ignore it all, but the pain doesn't subside
> I work out 'til I puke, smoke 'til I cough up blood
> Drinks, drugs, I run away from everything
> Another girl in the sheets, but nothing helps
> Every battle opponent lays out about the slap
> A forbidden topic, but an open secret

This verse is a prime example of the step ladder approach that integrates details of Fyodorov's professional and personal lives into one fragment of text. The opening line begins with

[240] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?," 4:53-5:34.

[241] "Bolotka" is a colloquial name for Bolotnaya Ploshad' (Bolotnaya Square) but the reference here is to the Bolotnaya pro-democracy protests from 2011-2013.

Oxxxymiron's dominance of the Russian rap scene ("я сломал игру," "I broke the game") but continues with a clause about self-censorship ("подсел на самоцензуру тут абсолютно во всём"). He then verbalizes the considerations he makes before he ultimately decides to keep silent on issues that are unnamed. The ambiguity here lends to the air of fear that Fyodorov cultivates within himself – he overthinks and stifles himself to keep others (fans, audiences, his family) comfortable. These conflicting details also allow Fyodorov to get under layers of persona. He first demonstrates a factual point, that Oxxxymiron was a breakout artist in the Russian hip hop scene, but he then demystifies his stardom by admitting to self-censorship. That he, a famous *battle rapper*, known for expunging political correctness, was censoring his own speech due to an invisible pressure is reason for audiences to question the image they had of Oxxxymiron.

The fragment continues with the visceral toll that silence and censorship take on Fyodorov. Accompanied by personal tour footage, the text reveals that Fyodorov over-exercised to the point of vomiting, smoked until he coughed up blood, drank, did drugs, and turned to sexual promiscuity to evade everything that begins to bother him, from personal struggles to social issues like the Bolotnaya protests in Russia and the Maidan revolution in Ukraine. Following the incident with Roma Zhigan, Fyodorov lives in such fear and shame that his attempts at control lead to self-censorship, internalization, and avoidance. All the while, as he reminds audiences in interspliced lines, he is dominating in battle rap, appearing on the popular late-night show *Вечерний Ургант (Evening Urgant)* and making Forbes' list of wealthiest Russian artists for the first time. These career details are not intended to prove that silence and compromise accelerated Oxxxymiron's rise to fame, rather they are reminders that artists' public lives, the personas they build, can be incongruent with the lives they live. As Oxxxymiron aptly

summarizes in the middle of the given fragment, "silence drags the silent, like quicksand." In this case, while Oxxxymiron ascends in public popularity, Miron Fyodorov is immobilized and slowly sinking in the quicksand of his own creation.

In the final sections of "Part II," Oxxxymiron expounds on the destructiveness of fear and the actualizing power of confronting it. Before he arrives here, Fyodorov must face the incident and his subsequent response again. This time, he analyzes it approximately eight years later, after he attends the premiere of *Beef*. After making a *Portrait of Dorian Gray* reference, Oxxxymiron rationalizes his internalization of the incident.[242] He raps that he can relax and be calm on the surface because Roma Zhigan has not been hostile with him for years, and his fans have either forgotten about the incident or have never heard of it. These rationalizations are a means of convincing himself to let the incident go, but he cannot. He aptly summarizes the tension between his rationalization and the reality of his authentic, bodily reaction to remembering the incident once more: "Время отпустить, но ёкает грудная клетка" ("It's time to let it go, but my heart skips a beat.")[243] Eight years of silence and fear are stored within Fyodorov and his physical reaction to it is a reminder that, while it can be hidden, it cannot be rationalized away. What Fyodorov has reviewed for audiences is the mental and physical toll that the incident had taken on him over the years. To cope with the anxiety and stress, he first tried to inundate his body with distractions, and when those distractions failed, he tried to rationalize his compromises but was reminded that his body was keeping score. At that point in time, he says,"Я начинаю оступаться, я тень себя прежнего" ("I began to let myself go and was a

[242] He references the portrait itself, not the novel's title. The full line is "За меня тайно дряхлеет портрет Дориана Грея" which could be literally translated as "The portrait of Dorian Gray grows decrepit behind me." I have taken this, along with the following line that on the surface he looks fine, but within he is declining.

[243] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?" 6:10-6:12.

shadow of myself.") This demonstrates how his feelings overtake his rational thoughts and so he continues on the path of self-destruction.

One striking admission relates to how Oxxxymiron's career is affected by the incident. This is remarkable in that he has been upholding his career throughout the song, demonstrating how Oxxxymiron's popularity and responsibilities grew despite his personal circumstances. The admission moves away from cultural recognition to pierce the point of his popularity: his artistry. He raps, "Мой карьерный суицид — столько лет молчать/ Я не выпускаю шесть, не выступаю пять" ("My career suicide was being silent all these years/I haven't released (music) in six, haven't performed in five.")[244] Fyodorov realizes that what harmed his career is keeping silent about the incident to the point that it stifles his ability to write new music and perform for six and five years, respectively. He expends so much effort to keep the footage hidden than it ends up being the very force that upends his mental health and the core of his professional endeavors: making and performing music. It is this creative block that spurs the Internet refrain of "когда альбом?"

Toward the end of Part II, Fyodorov ultimately returns to himself. There is no clear turning point, no climax, no redeeming incident akin to the one that destroys him. Unlike the detailed description of the causes and effects of his deterioration, the narrative lacks mention of that which pushed him forward. At this time in his life, Fyodorov is still using distraction to avoid facing the underlying issues that plague him, but this time, the distraction is atypical. Rather than engage in the destructive habits that damaged his body, he gets involved in political actions. ""Who Killed Mark?" references specific court cases, protests, and prominent figures of the time, including the "Я буду петь свою музыку" (I will perform my music) concert

[244] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?" 6:23-6:25.

Oxxxymiron organized in support of fellow rapper, Husky. It is his involvement in political actions that leads him to the understanding that "храбрость — это постепенный процесс" ("Courage is a gradual process.")[245] This maxim is the only semblance of explanation given as to how Fyodorov finds himself in therapy while taking a hiatus from social media and public life. By taking part in, and organizing, political actions, Fyodorov becomes present and engaged, a change from the deliberately apolitical persona of his rap battles and tracks. While the change does alter Oxxxymiron's public persona, it is more pertinent to Miron Fyodorov's cognizance of his ability to face fear, regardless of if the circumstance is politically or personally repressive. Fyodorov puts it more explicitly when interviewed at a protest by a TVRain reporter on January 31, 2021, his 36th birthday, "У меня день рождения, мне исполнилось 36 лет. И я себе желаю меньше убегать от своих страхов" ("Today is my birthday, I turned 36. And I wish for myself to run away from my fears less often.")[246]

The crux of "Who Killed Mark?" is distilled in the of the penultimate verse of Part II: "Я так не хотел стоять десять секунд на коленях/что в итоге стоял на них десять лет" ("I so didn't want to be on my knees for ten seconds, that I ended up on them for ten years.")[247] Fyodorov feared ruining the reputation he had built as Oxxxymiron so much that he actively destroyed himself instead, and he admits to this self-destruction as clearly as he does to Roma Zhigan and Schokk's roles in the saga. Where in Part I he lays blame, in the final verse of Part II, Oxxxymiron doles out forgiveness, most importantly, to himself: "Но главное, что сегодня, я

---

[245] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?" 6:49-6:51.

[246] Telekanal Dozhd, "'Svobodu Politzaklyuchennym, Eto Glavnoe!' — Kak Oxxxymiron Vstrechal Svoj 36-j Den' Rozhdeniya Na Mitinge Za Svobodu Alekseya Naval'novo v 2021 Godu." ['Freedom to the Political Prisoner, that is the main thing!' — How Oxxxymiron celebrated his 36th birthday at a rally for Aleksei Navalny's release in 2021], *Telekanal Dozhd.,'* Facebook. https://www.facebook.com/reel/1178301710631032.

[247] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?," 7:49-7:54.

прощаю себя" (But most importantly, I forgive myself).[248] As he delivers this final line, the accompanying video set changes. Oxxxymiron, clad in a dark jacket and encircled by a light fixture glowing red, is shot from below (see Fig. 27). When the final word is spoken, his outfit and the set change again. Part III begins with Oxxxymiron in a white shirt with a split background: the set is dark again, but white fabric billows around and below the rapper (see Fig. 28). The camera pans from eye level, dips lower, and then shifts above, mirroring the tender movements of the billowing fabric

Figure 27: The final image of Part II of "Who Killed Mark?" (8:30).

Figure 28: The first image of Part III of "Who Killed Mark?" (8:35).

3.2.4 On Resurrection: Introducing a New Oxxxymiron

The visual changes between Parts II and III are evocative of hell and heaven, lending to the notion that Oxxxymiron has surpassed the personal difficulties described throughout the song and landed in a peaceful, or perhaps, lighter atmosphere. The intermittent background track of an ethereal feminine voice interspliced with percussion and silence underscore the performance of otherworldly calm. Like the video effects, Part III is composed of light but familiar lyrics,

[248] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Kto ubil Marka?," 8:28-8:30.

ambiguous in nature but clear in structure. This section does not include personal or psychological insights but consists solely of a series of unrelated questions (approximately 46 total).[249] These questions are drawn from literature, politics, and culture, primarily from the Russian and Soviet contexts, and the majority are asked in Russian; three are posed in English such as the mention of the viral song "Who let the dogs out?" by the Baha Men (2000). The questions are a mix of gravity and levity, with Oxxxymiron launching theoretical and cultural touchstones at his audience. He opens Part III with a line from Nikolai Gogol's *Мёртвые Души* (*Dead Souls*): "Русь, куда несёшься ты" ("Rus' where are you headed?"). It remains, along with the two succeeding questions, "Кто виноват?" ("Who is to blame?") and "Что делать?" ("What is to be done?"), a means of questioning the nation's circumstances and the uncertainty of its future.[250] Yet, these questions which have echoed throughout the Russian Empire and beyond are inexplicably found alongside questions from Soviet children's songs ("Из чего сделаны наши мальчишки?," "What are our boys made of?"), popular films of the post-Soviet period ("В чём сила, брат?," "What's power, brother?"), and telecommunications advertising commercials ("Сколько вешать в граммах?," "How much does it weigh in grams?")[251] By integrating these questions, Oxxxymiron emulates a reflective atmosphere, demonstrating to audiences that one should engage with all of life's questions, regardless of their weight; we are surrounded by them in our daily lives, and they remain unanswered. That uncertainty is what

[249] Some could be considered both single and compound questions, such as the double "Откуда? Откуда?" (Where from? Where from?); I considered each to be a single question which resulted in a higher number total.

[250] *What is to be Done?* is the title of a late 19th century novel written by Nikolai Chernyshevsky (1863), and a political pamphlet written by Vladimir Lenin (1902).

[251] The children's song was written by Yakov Khaletskii (1918-2004); the film quote is a famous line from "Брат 2" (Brother 2) [dir. Alexei Balabanov, 2000); and questions is from an ad by telecommunications company Билайн (Beeline).

Oxxxymiron shied away from, worrying what uncertainty would do to his reputation and career. It is his way of showing that he has moved past fear and silence and toward inquiry. He approaches this section as he does his rap battles; he is apt to get more abstract in his third round, moving away from a string of insults and toward a longer narrative against his opponent. In this narrative, it's as if he speaks from an afterlife or perhaps a *new* life, one in which Oxxxymiron is freed from the past and embracing an uncertain future, one question at a time.

The most important question in this song is both the first and last: "Кто убил Марка?" (Who killed Mark?) (see Figs. 29 and 30).[252] While he leads with this question by using it as the track's title, Oxxxymiron does not directly reference *Gorgorod*. Instead, like his "When's the album?" campaign, he poses the question back to his audiences; he plays with uncertainty, teasing his listeners. He spent much of the song either describing the construction and deconstruction of his persona, only to lead audiences back to *Gorgorod's* Mark. The accompanying video's otherworldly tones are reminiscent of *Gorgorod's* final track, "Где нас нет" ("Where we are not"). Sharing the content of Mark's second (to

Figure 29: Oxxxymiron posing the last question "Who killed Mark?"(9:44-9:46)

Figure 30: The video's closing shot, panning away from Oxxxymiron (9:46-9:48).

[252] The final line is "А главное: Кто убил Марка?" (Most importantly: Who killed Mark?), which better highlights its significance.

the album) manuscript, it begins with a haunting Latin intro: “Sino hora sancta morta” (In the sacred hour of death).[253] The first half of the song consists of Mark’s loved ones retelling his childhood, followed by an account of Alisa’s path through adolescence. In “Who Killed Mark?” it is Oxxxymiron who narrates his own career, and punctuates this narration with an unanswered question: who killed Mark?

Analyzing the track’s lyrics and video components leads audience to a possible answer: Oxxxymiron kills Mark and he also “kills” Oxxxymiron. He takes the public conflation of the character (Mark) and his persona (Oxxxymiron) and deflates them, indicating that the versions he was once thought to have embodied have passed on. What fans can await is a new Oxxxymiron, one who is freer, more confident, and unrestrained. One who embraces uncertainty and steps away from silence, at least until both conditions are no longer in his control.

[253] The phrase is “Время чествования священной смерти” in the Russian translation.

Chapter 4: On the Afterlife of a Public Figure

Figure 31: The cover image to Oxxxymiron's 2024 single "Мир Горит" ("The World is Burning"). It is taken from the official announcement of his designation as a "wanted" individual by the Russian Federation, following his previous designation as a foreign agent.

After he was added to a list of "undesirable artists," meant to block their mention and artistic promotion in the Russian media, Oxxxymiron released the single and accompanying video for "Ойда" (Oida, 2022).[254] The song, eventually banned in Russia, is political; in it Oxxxymiron criticizes the government and those who support the War in Ukraine. He even cheekily addresses the powers that be by adding "Передаю привет СК и прокуратуре" ("Hi to the Investigative Committee and the prosecutor's office") as he looks into the camera and waves from the streets of St. Petersburg; shocking fans that he had potentially left and returned to the country between the invasion of Ukraine and the song's release.[255][256]

This newfound voice, able to relay Oxxxymiron's beliefs in a direct manner, comes from the development of the persona subset of *public figure*. From supporting free speech, to attending

[254] RBK, "V SMI opublikovan spisok 'nezhelatel'nyh' v Rossii muzykantov." [In mass media, Russia published a list of 'undesirable' musicians], *RBK,* July 8, 2022, https://www.rbc.ru/spb_sz/08/07/2022/62c811f19a7947321a049390.

[255] СК stands for "Следственный Комитет" (Investigative Committee).

[256] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Oida," YouTube, September 16, 2022, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pYymRbfjKv8.

demonstrations in support of political prisoners, and speaking out against the War in Ukraine, Oxxxymiron begins to use his celebrity platform to share his opinions. Alongside this enhanced persona subset, he releases music that is more socially conscious and related to the zeitgeist of the time. As he builds this persona in Russia and abroad, he becomes one of the new wave of emigres making music for Russians fleeing the state. Suddenly, his reputation is challenged, and then seriously questioned when allegations of sexual assault and grooming are publicly announced in November 2021 and March 2025, respectively.

The following sections analyze Oxxxymiron's role as a public figure, from using his platform "for good" to the realization that reputation cannot be controlled by his decisions alone. This chapter will address the notions of prestige and reputation amidst the paradoxical relationship between *reality* and persona through the sub persona of the "public figure." It will begin by addressing Oxxxymiron's growing role as an activist, beginning in 2018, then move on to summarizing the political and introspective nature of three major releases, miXXXtape III: Time of Troubles, "Oida," and *Beauty and Ugliness.* The final section discusses the troubling accusations made through the *Creative Method* podcast and demonstrates what it means for persona and reputation in the era of "cancel culture" in the Russian context.

4.1 On Oxxxymiron, the Free Speech Activist

Beginning in late 2018, Oxxxymiron, who previously steered away from addressing domestic politics in his music and performances, began to publicly broach the topic. On November 22, 2018, authorities prevented the rapper Dmitry "Хаски" ("Husky") Kuznetsov from holding a concert in Krasnodar. This prohibition came after public complaints over his work in 2017 and the subsequent censorship of his video for the song "Иуда" ("Judas"), just a

week before the scheduled concert.[257] Immediately after authorities shut down his Krasnodar concert, Husky stood atop a car and began performing for the audience outside of the concert venue; he led the crowd in chanting "Я буду петь свою музыку" ("I will perform my music".)[258] The rapper was subsequently arrested on four charges, found guilty of petty hooliganism, and placed under arrest for 12 days.[259] Two days after the incident, Oxxxymiron posted a video to his X (Twitter) page, the transcript of which reads:

> Всем привет! Меня зовут Оксимирон. Я приглашаю вас на спонтанно организовано концерт солидарности, которые мы проведём в этот понедельник в Москве в Главклубе. Концерт называется простое и понятное "Я буду петь свою музыку." Это строчка рэпера Хаски, который в данный момент тот бывает 12 суток ареста в Краснодаре. В его песнях нашли пропаганду того, чего там в помине нет, заблокировали клип, сорвали от концертов, а теперь и ещё арестовали. Это беспредел если в данный момент у него нет возможности свободно самовыражаться и честно зарабатывать на хлеб, то хотя бы со вторым мы можем все ему помочь. Поэтому вся прибыль из концерта пойдёт ему. Я не друг Хаски, я не разделяю большое количество взглядов и действий. Но несмотря на это, а может быть именно поэтому, я считаю необходимым помочь ему в этой трудной ситуации. Я очень рад, что баста и Noize видят это так же и присоединились ко мне. Это не столько, не только про Хаски, сколько про всех нас и про будущее музыки в России. Приходите.[260]
>
> Hey everyone, my name is Oxxxymiron. I'm inviting you to a spontaneously organized solidarity concert, which will take place this Monday in Moscow at Glavclub. The concert is simply and understandably titled "I will perform my music." This is a line of the rapper Husky, who is currently under arrest for 12 nights in Krasnodar. They found propaganda in his music, which is not there, cut him off from holding concerts, and even arrested him. This is lawlessness if, in the given moment, he can't freely express himself or earn money, but at least we can help him. This is why the concert's profits will go

---

[257] BBC News Russian, "Khaski arestovan v Krasnodare, reperu dali 12 sutok." [Husky arrested in Krasnodar, the rapper given 12-day sentence], *BBC News Russian,* November 22, 2018, https://www.bbc.com/russian/news-46305133.

[258] SarminSKY Turbine, "Ya Budu Pet' Moyu Muzyku." [I will perform my music], YouTube., November 25, 2018, 00:31, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jccSXrOkuWs.

[259] BBC News Russian, "Khaski arestovan v Krasnodare, reperu dali 12 sutok."

[260] Miron Fyodorov (@norimyxxxo), "YA BUDU PET' SVOYU MUZYKU: Basta, Oxxxymiron, Noize MC. Contsert solidarnosti. 26 noyabrya, Glavklub, Moskva." [I WILL SING MY OWN MUSIC: Basta, Oxxxymiron, Noize MC. Concert of solidarity. November 26, Glavclub, Moscow], X, November 24, 2018, https://x.com/norimyxxxo/status/1066372820794556417.

> entirely to him. I'm not Husky's friend. I don't share the same opinions or outlooks. But nevertheless, or maybe, because of this, I think it's imperative to help him in this difficult situation. I'm really happy that Basta and Noize (MC) see things the same way and joined me. It's not so much, it's not only about Husky as it is about all of us and the future of music in Russia. Come (to the concert)!

Together with veteran rappers Vasily "Basta" Vakulenko and Ivan "Noize MC" Alekseyev, Oxxxymiron held a benefit concert in honor of Husky, with all the proceeds going to the arrested rapper. He clarifies that the concert is a means to stand up for artistic self-expression in Russia as a whole, deflecting any accusations of specific political sentiments away from the action. Over the next few years, however, his activism became more pointed when he eventually begins criticizing specific decisions and the political players who make them.

Another notable public endeavor that marries Oxxxymmiron's artistic creativity and newfound social activism is his organization of a public reading of classic texts called "Сядь за Текст" ("Get Locked up for a Text") in 2019.[261] He organized this performance in support of Russian political activists, namely then college student and amateur YouTuber, Yegor Zhukov, who posted videos in support of Russian anti-corruption and anti-establishment public figures. Zhukov was dubbed a dissident by the public and punished by the government for holding an unauthorized rally. Zhukov's sentencing for extremism elicited public support from the masses and cultural figures, Oxxxymiron included. The set for "Get Locked up for a Text" is a replica of Zhukov's room (see Figs. 32 and 33), as seen in his

Figure 32: An image of Yegor Zhukov in his bedroom (02:24).

[261261] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial),"#syadzatekst" [#getlockedupforatext], YouTube, September 19, 2019, 1:58:04, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yI_iI-0QFIE.

YouTube videos, which slowly transforms into a prison cell during the performance (see Fig. 34).[262] Throughout the performance, Oxxxymiron and several other public figures, like the rappers Basta and Levan "L'One" Gorozia, and frontman of the rock group ДДТ (DDT),Yuri Shevchuk, sat behind a table and individually read excerpts from world literature. After each reading, the delivered text was evaluated by the Russian criminal and administrative codes; each performer subsequently received punishment in line with these codes for the crime of reading texts with prohibited themes.[263] During the performance, Oxxxymiron read a famous excerpt from the early nineteenth-century comedy *Горе от Ума* (*Woe from Wit)* by Alexander Griboedov referred to as "Chatsky's monologue." [264] This monologue addresses the hypocrisy and stifling nature of conservative society, allowing Oxxxymiron to draw a parallel between the 19th-century Russian Empire and the 21st-century

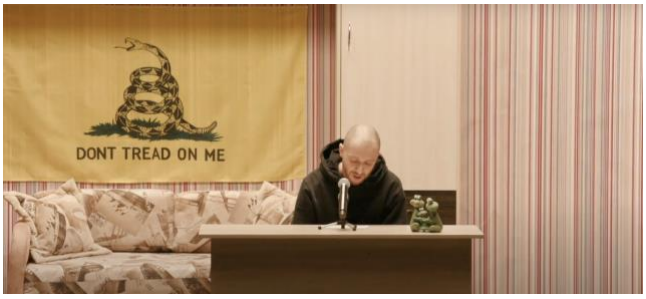


Figure 33: Fyodorov reading at the beginning of the performance in a replica of Zhukov's room.

Figure 34: Fyodorov reading at the end of the performance in front of a jail cell (1:54:00).

[262] Obozrevatel, "'Samyj ser'yeznyj batl!' Oksimiron vzbudorazhil set' rech'yu o bor'be s bespredelom v RF." ['The most serious battle!' Oxxxymiron stirred up the site with his speech on the fight with lawlessness in the Russian Federation], *Obozrevatel,* September 20, 2019, https://news.obozrevatel.com/show/people/samyij-sereznyij-batl-oksimiron-vzbudorazhil-set-rechyu-o-borbe-s-bespredelom-v-rf.htm

[263] Radio Liberty,"'Syad' za tekst': na kanale Oxxxymiron vynesli 'prigovory' klassikam literatury." ['Get locked up for a text:' Sentences are rendered for classic literature on Oxxxymiron's channel], *Radio Liberty,* September 19, 2019, https://www.svoboda.org/a/30173073.html,

[264] The monologue is included in Act II, Scene V of the play.

Russian Federation. In the performance, he is "charged" with defamation for reading the monologue and "sentenced" to 360 hours of labor.[265] This creative action contributes to the shaping of Oxxxymiron's public persona, beginning with his defense of creative speech, broadly defined and moving to direct dissidence. It is also notable in that it is another display of Oxxxymiron's literariness; an attribute well defined in his rap career.

If 2017 marks the height of Oxxxymiron's career trajectory, then 2019 is a turning point toward celebrity activism. In that year, his musical output significantly decreases – he releases just two singles and participates in the 17th Independent Battle of Hip-Hop.ru, and his social media presence shifts away from hip hop and typical meanderings to become responsive to domestic politics.[266] In Internet parlance, he begins "using his platform" to encourage others to become socially and politically engaged. Then, sometime in 2020, before the global pandemic causes billions of people around the world to double down on social connection via the Internet, Oxxxymiron puts it all on pause. By refraining from using social media, releasing new music, or performing, Oxxxymiron effectively disappears from the public eye until the release of "Who Killed Mark?" This pause is different from the one before *Gorgorod's* release as it is connected to an alleged period of personal growth and change for Oxxxymiron. What comes after this hiatus is the promotion of a new Oxxxymiron, one less fearful and freer than before. This seemingly vulnerable, politically minded, and artistically creative Oxxxymiron tests out his new persona in the realm of celebrity activism.

---

[265] Adindex, "'Syad' za tekst' Oxxxyimron provyol chtenie klassiki v podderzhku figurantov 'moskovskogo dela'" ["Get locked up for a text" Oxxxymiron led a reading of classics in support of figures from the "Moscow affairs"]," *Adindex,* September 19, 2019, https://adindex.ru/news/offtop/2019/09/19/275601.phtml.

[266] Other rappers joined the battle as well, including Noize MC, St1m, and Egor Kreed. The full participant and track list can be found on the following site: https://ib17.hip-hop.ru/#/

4.2 On Beauty, Ugliness, and the Time of Troubles: Political Themes in New Releases

In the Russian context, celebrity activism is usually related to one's acceptance of or opposition to the state. While other hip-hop artists have demonstrated political leanings through their music, such as Kasta's 2017 song "Скрепы" (Bonds),Oxxxymiron had been reticent to include overtly political material in his songs until 2021 when he releases *miXXXtape III:Time of Troubles*, *Beauty and Ugliness,* and "Oida".[267] The two albums and single are amongst other works Oxxxymiron releases between 2021-2023; this plethora of releases challenging the earlier perception of long creative process mired by silence and delay. Each of these releases is unique, one representing a collection of singles, another is his first original album since 2015, and the final is a standalone track with overtly political themes.

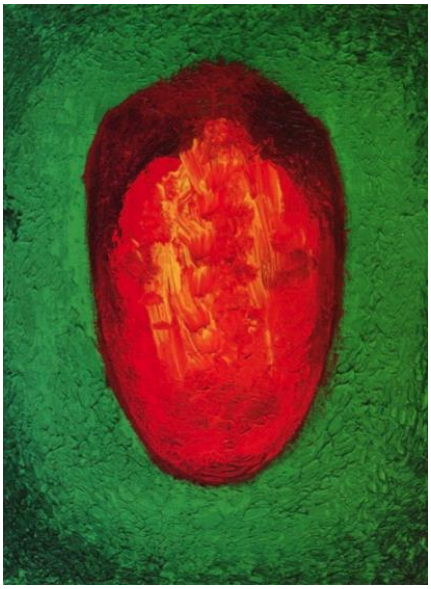


Figure 35: The cover art for "Beauty and Ugliness," painted by Boris Grebenshchikov.

Beauty and Ugliness is Oxxxymiron's first album in six years and third studio album in total. It was released on December 1, 2021, and includes twenty-two tracks total – double the number of *Gorgorod*. The album's cover art is painted by Russian rock musician and cultural icon, Boris Grebenshchikov; the title of this work is "Портрет Неизвестного И" ("Portrait of the Unknown I") (see Fig. 35).[268] The painting appears to depict a distorted portrait of an unknown figure, a powerful symbol for an album about the contradictions of beauty and ugliness, and

[267] "Bonds" is a satirical portrayal of certain Russians' love for their homeland. The song and video can be accessed here: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rVYtS_cp-yc&t=1s

[268] Boris Grebenshchikov (@Bgrebenshikov_art), "Kartina nahoditsya v chastnoj kollektsii." [The painting is in a private collection], Instagram, January 11, 2021, ://www.instagram.com/p/CJ6xVB2FB1z/?hl=en.

Oxxxymiron's paradoxical nature. Music journalist Andrei Nedashkovsky summarizes the album as such: "Весь его рэп, если коротко, про то, что уж который год Мирон под Мирона подошвой. Новый альбом про то, как он из-под неё выбирается" ("All of his rap is about how many years Miron has been under Miron's sole. The new album is about how he's getting out from under it.")[269] Referencing Oxxymiron's track "Город под подошвой" ("The City under the Sole") a 2015 song that is released in 2021 on *miXXXtape III*, Nedashkovsky cleverly describes the album's introspective nature and candid tone.

At twenty-two tracks, *Beauty and Ugliness* is the longest of Oxxxymiron's studio albums. From rapping about politics to rapping about rap, Oxxxymiron includes a myriad of references and asides that blend his thoughts on current cultural happenings alongside some braggadocio and humor. The album opens with "Хоп Механика" (Hop Mechanics) a short track that lays out several themes that are explored throughout the album: politics, censorship, repression, rap culture, and aspects of Oxxxymiron's biographical mythology (Jewishness, psychological illness). Its title is a play on the name of a musical group founded in the 1980s, "Поп-Механика" (Pop Mechanics); the allusion is that contemporary Russian rap is just a hip-hop version of this ensemble. The track opens with an intro sung by a feminine voice that references several of these themes from the get-go, adding a description of Oxxxymiron as "читающий еврей, но не Матисьяху" ("a rapping Jewish man, but not Matisyahu") alongside a theme of wandering; here Oxxxymiron reinvents the "wandering Jew" trope.[270] He again identifies himself as a distinct personality who does not fit in anywhere he goes, which is ultimately his strength.

---

[269] The-Flow.ru, "Razberaem 'Krasotu i Urodstvo' Oksimirona" [We're analyzing Oxxxymiron's "Beauty and Ugliness"], *The Flow.ru*, December 3, 2021, https://the-flow.ru/features/razbor-krasotu-urodstvo-oxxxymiron.

[270] The singer's name has not been revealed. Though many speculated that it is the voice of Elizaveta "Monetochka" Gyrdymova, this was disproven.

Moreover, he plays with the idea of the Jewish character as part of his persona, identifying as a rapper who is Jewish, but not one whose persona relies on the visible display of Jewish themes like Matthew Paul "Matisyahu" Miller, whose early hip hop and image reflected Hasidic themes. This is on par with earlier mentions of Judaism in relation to his battle rap career and overall hip hop image. Nevertheless, he expands his commentary in the first verse, rapping:

> Жив для противостояния угасанию
> Жид — не ортодоксальный, а парадоксальный
> Бартер: за лечение в Аркхеме — Пятый Картер
> Жёлтый символ на пиджаке — не эмблема Carhartt
> Тьма египетская над бездной, крещение анхом
> Батя возвращается трезвым, в руке буханка[271]
>
> I'm alive for the resistance to extinction
> Not an Orthodox Jew but a paradoxical one
> It's a barter: for treatment in Arkham, you get *The Carter V*
> The yellow symbol on my jacket isn't a Carhartt logo
> The Egyptian darkness over the abyss, baptism by the key to life
> Daddy's back sober with a loaf of bread in his hand

In just six lines of the first verse, Oxxxymiron opens his album with a pandora's box about himself, and the world. His words are layered with meaning, such as the idea that he's here to resist extinction: this could refer to him as a rapper keeping the game alive; a Jewish person resisting centuries of attempts at decimation, and his own fight for survival amidst psychological health issues. It appears that he's a paradoxical Jew because he is facing extinction against external and internal threats. Despite his mental health issues and treatment (Arkham is a fictional asylum in the Batman universe), he manages to release a new album which took 6 years to release exactly like the time between Dwayne "Lil' Wayne' Carter's albums *The Carter IV* *a*nd *The Carter V*. The final line plays with the idea of his absence in the rap world, long a

[271] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Hop-Mechanika" [Hop-Mechanics], YouTube, December 1, 2021, 0:26-0:41. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NLva43KAkic.

symbol of his persona, inverting an Internet references about fathers who abandon their families: as the reference goes, fathers who intended to abandon their families often say they are going to the store for something, but they never come back. In Oxxxymiron's case, he said he would come back with a loaf of bread, and he did. The implication here is that "he's not like the other dads." He keeps to his word. As the introductory song, "Hop Mechanics" sets the tone for the entire album, throughout which Oxxxymiron discusses the beauty and ugliness of life in its many forms, those found within us and around us, from political repression and protests to the state of contemporary Russian hip hop. Throughout the album, listeners are in for surprises, with song titles and choruses speaking to certain themes but exploring more niche contexts. For instance, the song "Агент" ("Agent)" has an overtly political title, while others, like "Мы все умрём" ("We'll all die") ponder broader themes, demonstrating his thematic range rather than putting out an album entirely dedicated to then-current political situations.

Beauty and Ugliness receives mixed reviews, with some critics praising Oxxxymiron's focus on the contentious relationship of beauty and ugliness in the contemporary world and experimental texts and sounds, and others frustrated by the album's lack of ingenuity and candor.[272] *miXXXtape III: The Time of Troubles* is similarly reviewed. The album's subtitle borrows from the historical period between the end of the sixteenth through the beginning of the seventeenth century. Yet, it can also be interpreted as a personal allusion to the period of Oxxxymiron's career discussed in "Who Killed Mark?" – when he was at the height of his success but struggling psychologically and physically. It is no surprise then that the album is predominately a collection of re-releases of older songs, including Oxxxymiron's features on

[272] The Internet hip-hop publication *The Flow* compiled an annotated list of reviews here: https://the-flow.ru/features/vse-recenzii-na-oksimirona-krasota-i-urodstvo.

collaborative tracks, such as his verse in *Konstrukt,* the track released with other members of the Booking Machine label that he headed. Included amongst these is the standout original "Организация" (Organization), a political and philosophical song that refers to the oft-used term in contemporary Russian society of the "запрещённая организация" (forbidden organization): a judicial term referring to a person or group accused of extremist or terrorist activity. The term has been widely used to repress individuals and groups that take positions oppositional to the ruling government, thus Oxxxymiron plays with the idea that thinking differently is itself an extremist activity. The song's chorus beings with: "Нас ни догнать, ни мечом обуздать нельзя/Ни одна стена нипочём, ведь мы — запрещённая организация/ Каждый из нас обречён замечать изъян мироздания и расчёсывать/ Мы — запрещённая организация" ("You can't catch us or tame us with a sword/Walls aren't a problem since we're a forbidden organization/Every one of us is bound to notice the universe's flaws and scratch them/We're a forbidden organization.")[273] The statement he makes is anyone who is capable of free thinking is dubbed as forbidden, but that nothing can stop people from thinking freely; thus, it is what is forbidden that is ironically uncontrollable.

The volume and experimental nature of these albums demonstrates a change in Oxxxymiron's creative and public personas. Beginning in 2021 he begins releasing music quickly and incorporating timely themes, such as the song "23 Февраля" ("February 23") which references the day before Russia's 2022 invasion of Ukraine. He even releases a song that, along with his public statements, gets him added to Russia's Wanted list: "Oida." It begins with a mix of audio recordings from Russian news sites discussing Oxxxymiron's status in the cultural

[273] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "My vse umryom" [We're all gonna die], YouTube, December 1, 2021, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tkqef33yRNA.

sphere after the 2022 invasion of Ukraine. In the song, he gives his take on the current social and political situation in Russia, ultimately claiming that an unnamed “we” will rebuild after the devastation at the hands of its government. The line that presumably gets him in legal trouble with the government reads “Ингрия будет свободной” (Ingria will be free). Ingria refers to a territory found in current Leningradsky Oblast (in St. Petersburg) that has been used as a symbol of separatism from the Russian state.[274] The government does not take the movement lightly and has prosecuted others under extremism laws for specific invocations of the term.[275] Oxxxymiron has already been under the government’s radar when the song is released and was thought to have left the country (something the introductory newsclips touch on). The song and accompanying video also touch on an important aspect of his personal mythology: he reveals that he covered up his signature “Imperivm” knuckle tattoos (see Figs.36 and 357. symbolizing both his rejection of a “self-made rap empire" and, in the context of the song, Russian imperialism.[276] Given the contentious context of the War in Ukraine and

Figure 36: Oxxxymiron standing on the banks of the Neva River in the "Oida" video. It is at this moment (2:07-2:08) that he addresses and gestures to the prosecutor's office.

[274] To read an in-depth history of Ingria, see: https://holod.media/2022/09/24/simanosvski-ingria/

[275] For an example, see: https://meduza.io/feature/2016/06/02/chto-takoe-ingermanlandiya-i-chego-hotyat-ee-storonniki

[276] As Reebok Classic Russia ambassador, he raps a song that is eventually added to miXXXtape III, titled “Что такое империя?” (What is an Empire?). The song and video can be watched here: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JJ72pPFrE9Y; The Flow.ru, “Foto Dnya: Oksimiron zabil tatu ‘Imperium’ na pal’tsah.” [Photo of the Day: Oxxxymiron tattoos ‘Imperium’ on his knuckles], *The Flow,* September 20, 2022, https://the-flow.ru/foto/foto-dnya-oksimiron-imperium.

Fyodorov's having been targeted by the Russian government for his speech, his surprise appearance in the video filmed in St. Petersburg bolsters his image as a public figure and celebrity oppositionist activist.

From November 2021 through approximately December 2023, Oxxxymiron's creative endeavors are more political, introspective, and defiant. This new image is also markedly pronounced in his status as a public figure. He goes far beyond the "populism" that Slava KPSS accuses him of and moves into a seemingly fearless display of his oppositional position in the realm of Russian politics. In the context of the War in Ukraine in particular, he emerges as a celebrity activist that stands out among the status quo.

Figure 37: Oxxxymiron's knuckle tattoos pictured in September 2022.

4.3 On Oxxxymiron, the Anti-War Activist

On February 24, 2022, just hours after Russian began its full-scale invasion of Ukraine, Oxxxymiron posted a video to his Instagram account (@norimyxxxo). In the video, he walks down a street in St. Petersburg with a hooded sweatshirt pulled onto his head. He looks at the camera and says:

> Всем привет из Питера! Я сегодня не ограничусь словами о том, что я за мир против войны. Потому что на словах все всегда за мир и против войны, однако это не мешает вести захватнические войны. Я хочу сказать, что я конкретно против той

> войны, которую прямо сейчас развязывает Россия против народа Украины. Я считаю, что это катастрофа и преступление.[277]
>
> Greetings from Piter! Today I won't restrain myself with words about the fact that I am for a world without war. Because everyone is always for peace and against war in words, however this does not prevent wars of conquest being waged. I want to say that I am specifically against this war, which Russia is currently unleashing against the people of Ukraine. I consider it a catastrophe and a crime.

Fyodorov's seemingly impromptu and immediate response is unprecedented when compared to his earlier hesitance to be overtly politically in his art and public interactions. His video is not staged, he is spontaneously moving and speaking, making one of the most immediate and direct statements on the invasion out of the eclectic Russian celebrity class. Throughout the lengthy video, Fyodorov gives his opinion on the wars in Afghanistan, Iraq, Vietnam, and the bombings of Belgrade. In the video Oxxxymiron also pivots into a lesson: he says that society should learn from these wars, rather than use them to justify current situations. He adds that Russia is attacking a sovereign Ukraine, not vice versa, and as such contends that a protest movement similar to the one that emerged in the United States against the Vietnam war, is needed in Russia.[278] By releasing such a direct and informative video, Oxxxymiron positions himself as a dissident, a change from his earlier hesitance to speak about political topics in clear terms. Further, his mention of protest movements is a call for collective action from likeminded Russians; it is his way of using a platform to influence public action.

---

[277] Meduza, "'Ya ne mogu razvlekat' vas, poka na Ukrainu padayut rossijskie rakety' Oksimiron otlozhil svoi pervye sol'nye kontserty za pyat' let iz-za vtorzheniya Rossii v Ukrainu. On nazval vojnu 'katastrofoj i prestupleniem.'" ['I cannot entertain you when Russian rockets fall on Ukraine,' Oxxxymiron postponed his first solo concerts in 5 years because of Russia's invasion of Ukraine. He called the war a 'catastrophe and crime'], *Meduza,*. February 24, 2022, https://meduza.io/feature/2022/02/24/ya-ne-mogu-razvlekat-vas-poka-na-ukrainu-padayut-rossiyskie-rakety.

[278] Meduza, "'Ya ne mogu razvlekat' vas, poka na Ukrainu padayut rossijskie rakety' Oksimiron otlozhil svoi pervye sol'nye kontserty za pyat' let iz-za vtorzheniya Rossii v Ukrainu. On nazval vojnu 'katastrofoj i prestupleniem.'"

Comparatively, some other rappers reacted to the war in creative ways, such as Morgenshtern who released the song and video "12" which ends with an authentic recording from his Ukrainian beatmaker's mother who was in an active war zone at the time . In the recording, she describes the destruction she saw and her experience in a bomb shelter as Morgenshtern and Palagin (the beatmaker) listen and stare into the distance. [279] Other celebrities manifest the paradoxical urge to speak up but a hesitancy to do so, some partaking in performative actions such as posting black squares on their Instagram accounts to denote their disapproval of war. Some artists include captions, such as Danila Kozlovsky's February 27 black square post which expressed dismay and disapproval through more neutral phrases like "I am against war" and "That which is occurring is a catastrophe." [280] Even the nationalist rapper, Timur "Timati" Yunusov dedicated a square of his Instagram profile to his thoughts on the "current situation," though most of his lengthy post is in support of his patriotism and love of country; his only explicit mention is the line "Теперь в отношении Украины" (Now with regard to Ukraine).[281] Both Kozlovsky and Timati's posts have been deleted, but like everything in the digital age, remain elsewhere on the web; their deletion a mark of the celebrities' self-presentation.

---

[279] Viktor Galanov, "Morgenshtern – 12 (Klip 2022) 4K+." [Morgenshtern - 12 (Clip 2022) 4K+], YouTube, Copy, March 20, 2022, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=j_QSDVqujhE, 2:43-2:57.

[280] Bulvar Gordona, "'Strashno. Bol'no. Nevynosimo grustno. I stydno. I v tom chisle za sebya.' Rossijskij akter Kozlovskij vyskazalsya o vojne RF protiv Ukrainy." ['Frightening. Hurtful. Unbearably sad. And shameful. And for ourselves.' Russian actor Koslovsky spoke out about the Russian Federation's war against Ukraine], *Bulvar Gordona,* February 27, 2022, https://gordonua.com/bulvar/news/strashno-bolno-nevynosimo-grustno-i-stydno-i-v-tom-chisle-za-sebya-rossiyskiy-akter-kozlovskiy-vyskazalsya-o-voyne-rf-protiv-ukrainy-1597449.html.

[281] Timur Yunusov (@timatiofficial), "Menya proklinayut, zhelayut smerti mne lichno, moej sem'e, rodnym i blizkim." [They curse me, wish for my death, and that of my family and loved ones], Instagram, March 4, 2022, (Post deleted but author is in possession of an original copy).

What is different about Fyodorov's response is the immediateness, coupled with a lack of creative or performative elements. Unlike Timati, he speaks clearly on the subject and does not obfuscate; unlike Morgenshtern, he does so as a public figure, rather than a rapper, making an impromptu personal statement that aligns with his values, rather than a creative one. Not only is he direct, but Fyodorov also moves away from using silence and time to cushion his response as he had done in the past. It appears that the new, political Oxxxymiron, intends to tackle life's questions as they come, as an artist *and* public figure; he has also not deleted the video from his personal platforms. This is not to suggest that Oxxxymiron is the only celebrity to make his stance known and not shy away from it. Indeed, he joins a host of oppositionist artists, some of or beyond his caliber in cultural mythology, others lesser known, who express their opinions on the War in Ukraine. Many of these artists flee Russia in the days and weeks after the war. Together they create a new wave of Russian emigres. An article published in *Москвич Маг* (Moskvich Mag, Muscovite Mag) titled "Станет ли Оксимирон новым Вертинским? Как культура делится сейчас на русскую и российскую" ("Will Oxxxymiron become the new Vertinsky? How culture is now divided into Russian and *Russian"*) is just one publication that compares the then-recent flight of the cultural class to the émigré movement that occurred between 1917 and 1922.[282][283] In it, Oxxxymiron is discussed amongst the likes of artists Boris Grebenshchikov, Zemfira, and Alla Pugacheva, directors Kirill Serebrennikov and Kantemir

[282] Moskvich Mag, "Stanet Li Oxxxymiron Novym Vertinskim? Kak Kul'tura Delitsya Sejchas Na Russkuyu I Rossijskuyu." [Will Oxxxymiron become the next Vertinsky? How culture is now dividing itself as Russian and "Russian" (as in the State)], *Moskvich Mag*, https://moskvichmag.ru/lyudi/stanet-li-oxxxymiron-novym-vertinskim-kak-kultura-delitsya-sejchas-na-russkuyu-i-rossijskuyu/.

[283] Alexander Nikolaevich Vertinsky (1889-1957) was a Russian singer and composer who left Russian in 1920 and spent most of his career entertaining Russian émigrés abroad until moving to the Soviet Union in 1943.

To clarify the translation, "Русский" (Russkii) refers to someone with Russian heritage and/or who speaks Russian; "Российский" (Rossiiskii) refers to a citizen of the Russian federation. The implication here is that those who fled Russia after the War, while no longer Russian citizens, are still representative of Russian culture abroad.

Balagov, and fellow rappers Morgenshtern and Ivan "Face" Dryomin. This new dissident milieu, amongst others, has collectively impacted domestic cultural value, and its opposition to the war has changed not only artists' reputations, but the status of culture. Thus, they contribute to the author's differentiation between Russian and "Russian" in the article's title; he suggests that Russian culture may be shaped from abroad, away from "Russian" culture produced in and by the state. As the war continues, Oxxxymiron stays true to his Instagram message and cancels his planned concerts in Russia.[284] In March, he also announces a series of benefit concerts to raise money for Ukrainian refugees called "Russians Against War" (RAW). In this announcement he demonstrates how he is using his dismay at the war to act and serves as inspiration for the millions of others who disagree with it to do the same.[285] It is in announcing this tour that Oxxxymiron connects his convictions to the masses and uses his platform to spread awareness. In this way, he elevates his public figure into the realm of influence beyond creative status and into public action.

[284] Evan Minsker, "Russian Rapper Oxxxymiron Cancels Sold Out Moscow Concerts in Protest of Ukraine Invasion," Pitchfork, February 25, 2022, https://pitchfork.com/news/russian-rapper-oxxxymiron-cancels-sold-out-moscow-concerts-in-protest-of-ukraine-invasion/.

[285] Miron Fyodorov (@oxxxymironofficial), "Oxxxymiron–RUSSIANS AGAINST WAR (ISTANBUL, TURKEY)," YouTube, March 11, 2022, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ufRsgtd2fIA

Following RAW, Oxxxymiron embarks on a 2023 world tour catering to Russophone audiences, but particularly Russians who, like him, have left the country (see Fig. 38).[286] Unlike RAW, these concerts were not organized as charity concerts, though there were some political elements to different shows. Speaking from my experience as an audience member of the October 2023 concert in Boston, Massachusetts, the atmosphere was light, and it felt like a typical concert in that the setlist was pulled from different albums and the evening was tied together with performative elements (lights, videos, etc.). Oxxxymiron even performed the banal single “1.Kla$” whose crude chorus had the crowd chanting: “Пососи мой хуй, эй/ Пососи мой хуй/Пососи мой хуй, эй/Мой красивый хуй” (Suck my dick, hey/Suck my dick/Suck my dick, hey/My beautiful dick). If there is any indication the Oxxxymiron was ready to continue his artistry and life abroad, it was this.

Figure 38: A poster advertising Oxxxymiron's 2023 world tour.

[286] Rap.ru, “OXXXY Anonsiroval Tur.” [OXXXY Announces Tour], *Rap.ru,* accessed August 25, 2023. https://www.rap.ru/news/16259.

One element provided a through-line for the concert, another way of addressing the current situation in Russia: monologues of a fictional character played by Oxxxymiron (see Fig. 39).[287] Appearing in video form before and between tracks, the character addresses the absurdity of performing for Russian audiences abroad while a real war ravishes Ukraine and transforms Russians' lives in Russia. As Mardean Isaac writes, "Through this alternative character, Miron dramatizes his own position, and that of his audience, in relation to the war. As his hybridized name attests, Miron has always thrived on embodying contradictions. This impish trickster persona exhibits Miron's awareness of the dubious morality of entertaining during war and the absurdity of performing anti-war songs to a crowd increasingly distant from the country prosecuting that war."[288] Oxxxymiron's use of a costume, including white makeup with black features and a distorted voice, creates a barrier. Where he is direct and vulnerable in his social media posts about the War in Ukraine, this character allows him to talk about the implications of war in a removed way. It is particularly the situation of Russian dissidents who are villainized by global audiences that this character speaks to, and his stark and fictional appearance is part of the performance.

Figure 39: A still image of Oxxxymiron in character, played in videos during his World Tour.

[287] Aleksandra Marciniak, personal photo, October 13, 2023.

[288] Mardean Isaac, "The Rapper and the Foreign Agent."

While Isaac discusses the overtly political messages heard during the London concert, his impression is not one of a celebrity activist, but of an individual trying to relate to the crowd. He writes, "It is as if, through his early contact with other cultures, Miron developed an ingrained sense that there are many different ways of being, and that yours — he tells his Russian audience — is just one of them." Indeed, he spent most of his career feeling like and portraying the image of a wanderer, a misfit, an oxymoron; it is in his newly evolved persona that he is able to provide comfort to himself and those in his current situation, against the war and out of the country, that their situation is nothing special in the grand scheme of the universe. Oxxxymiron demonstrates that, sometimes, it takes a fictional character to bring individuals back to the core of their current realities.

As the tour commences and time passes, he releases an experimental album (*Семейный Альбом; Family Album)* with a second cousin, under the moniker "Переучёт" (Pereuchyot, roughly "Inventory" or "Re-registration). He also posts tour vlogs capturing behind-the-scenes and from-the-stage elements of the concerts he delivers in different cities, as he did earlier during the *Imperivm* tour. During this time, he more frequently engages with the public on various platforms, including *Telegram* where he hosts a popular channel. Finally, in September 2024, he announces a new world tour titled *Dolce Vita (The Good Life)* but reschedules it just two months later announcing that the decision was made "в связи с состоянием моего здоровья" (in relation to the state of my health).[289] He has not publicly posted online since then.

Unlike other periods of silence, this one comes after years of presence and creative output. Soon, some blogs spread unsubstantiated rumors that he is dying of cancer, while others,

[289] Miron Fyodorov (@norimyxxxo), "Druz'ya! K Moemy Ogromnomy Sozhaleniyu, Tur DOLCE VITA Perenositsya Na 2026 God." [Friends! To my great disappointment, the tour DOLCE VITA has been rescheduled to 2026], Instagram, November 19, 2024, https://www.instagram.com/norimyxxxo/p/DCjgrKptXuy/.

accustomed to his retreats from the public eye, simply wait.[290] It is not until March 2025, when he is publicly accused of sexual assault and grooming by three women, that social media runs abuzz with new takes and theories on his silence. It becomes time for a reckoning on self-presentation and changing perceptions of the Oxxxymiron persona.

4.4 On "The Creative Method": The Podcast that Tackles Person and Persona

On November 2, 2021, the day after "Who Killed Mark?" was released, Miron Fyodorov's ex-girlfriend Vera Markovich posted a lengthy text on her Instagram page (@tricksterquest) expressing her frustration and disbelief at the claims of vulnerability and personal growth that Oxxxymiron makes throughout the song. When speaking with Nastya Krasilnikova, she claims that she had not spoken to Fyodorov for years and had been in therapy and receiving psychiatric treatment for depression and complex post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) to deal with their traumatic relationship. When she hears the song, however, she feels the need to react; she tells a friend about what she has written, and he encourages her to post it if it makes her feel better; she does.[291] At the time, her Instagram page was public, meaning that anyone could access it, but she claims that her post was meant for her "friends" (Instagram followers). After all, she later explains, she is not a public figure with a large following.

[290] Daria Frolova, "Pol'zovateli obsuzhdayut sluhi o zabolevanii Oksimirona*." [Users discuss rumors of Oxxxymiron's illness], *Popcake*, January 27, 2025. https://popcake.news/news/v-seti-obsuzhdayut-chto-u-repera-inoagenta-oksimirona-rak.

[291] Nastya Krasilnikova, "Tvorcheskii Metod 1: na repite" [Creative Method 1: on repeat], *Libo Libo,* podcast audio, March 3, 2025, 32:36, https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

Though she does not directly name Fyodorov in the post, it's clear to whom she's referring: the accompanying photo is of Markovich and Fyodorov, and the post's first two sentences are direct rebuttals to two "Who Killed Mark's? more prominent lines. [292] It begins:

> А у меня ушло 10 лет, чтобы наконец разозлиться и понять, что я не хочу, чтоб моя дочь в будущем жила с ощущением, что чей то безусловный талант или что-то там ещё могут оправдать почти любое к ней отношение и повесить на её плечи ответственность в чувство вины за двоих, которое потом годами может выжигать ей внутренность.
>
> Взять ответственность? Перестать быть жертвой? Серьёзно?[293]
>
> And it took me 10 years to finally get angry and understand that I don't want my daughter to live with the feeling that someone's indisputable talent or whatever else can justify any attitude toward her in the future and place the responsibility of enough blame for two on her back, which can internally eat away at her for years.
>
> Take responsibility? Stop being a victim? Are you serious?

Like a skilled battle rapper, Markovich uses a flip to respond to Oxxxymiron's track, turning his words against him and dispelling the "changed" persona he reveals in the song. As Oxxxymiron does in part III of "Who Killed Mark?" here Markovich poses a series of questions, though hers are not ambiguous in nature. Instead, they are revelatory, contextualized by details that describe their relationship, his actions against her, and her psychological state, all from her perspective. She returns to the claims made in "Who Killed Mark?" throughout as is evidenced when she asks: "1,5 года без социальных сетей и терапия? Серьёзно? Как насчёт 9 лет хронической депрессии с несколькими острыми эпизодами, 7 лет терапии и сжирающего все чувства

[292] The lines are "Я так не хотел стоять десять секунд на коленях/что в итоге стоял на них десять лет" (I so didn't want to be on my knees for ten seconds, that I ended up on them for ten years) and "Я всё это хаваю, у меня нет выбора/ Если не хочу, чтоб мои будущие дети в школе увидали видео/ С отцом на коленях и пощёчиной" (I'm fed up but I have no choice if I don't want my future kids to see a video in school of their father on his knees getting slapped in the face)

[293]The original post was deleted by Instagram, but a copy is accessible on the "Tvorcheskii Metod" site, along with other visuals and evidence. Non-Objective," Sedmoy sezon podkasta 'doch razboinika' Tvorecheskii metod" [The seventh season of the "Bandit's Daughter" podcast "The Creative Method"]. 2025. https://method.libolibo.me/.

вины от того, что она тебя, гения, разрушила…" ("1.5 years without social media and in therapy? Seriously? What about 9 years of chronic depression with several acute episodes, 7 years of therapy and all the feelings of guilt devouring her because she destroyed you, a genius…").[294] She makes clear the connection between her psychological state throughout the years, and their past relationship. As she centers her experience in this post in contrast to Oxxxymiron's self-presentation in "Who Killed Mark?" Markovich both undermines his persona and demonstrates the influence it had over her: much of her pain related to his status as a creative "genius."

These revelations attract wide attention, but not just for their deeply personal and accusatory nature. Perhaps the most important point Markovich makes is that she and Fyodorov met when she was 15 years old and he was 23 years old and married.[295] The two met when she was studying abroad in England; he was assigned as her "опекун" ("guardian") through a private agency. They dated while she worked as his manager for four years, around the time she turned 19 and both were living in Russia. Shortly after posting on Instagram, Markovich receives a notification that the platform has deleted her post due to "stalking or harassment." While not having worked with Oxxxymiron for years, Vera Markovich was still considered part of his web so his fans and other onlookers were attuned to her page and engaged with the post immediately. The Internet proves again that even what is deleted is never gone and its reception cannot be controlled.

---

[294] Non-Objective, " Sedmoy sezon podkasta 'doch razboinika' Tvorecheskii metod" [The seventh season of the "Bandit's Daughter" podcast "The Creative Method"].

[295] Non-Objective, " Sedmoy sezon podkasta 'doch razboinika' Tvorecheskii metod" [The seventh season of the "Bandit's Daughter" podcast "The Creative Method"].

It comes as a surprise then, when in the following days, Markovich posts an addendum, informing followers and lurkers alike that she and Fyodorov did not have sexual relations until she was sixteen years old, highlighting that this is the age of consent (in Russia).[296] Uncharacteristically, Fyodorov also posts about the situation directly, albeit in a different format. He writes in part: "У нас была сложная и травматичная для обоих история отношений, которую мы вчера наконец-то смогли проговорить. Мне жаль, что я причинил ей столько боли и беру ответственность за свои поступки" ("We had a difficult and traumatic relationship history for both of us, which we finally were able to discuss yesterday. It's a pity that I caused her so much pain and I take responsibility for my action.")[297] [298] His response is direct, seemingly sincere, and vulnerable, acknowledging the difficulty of their relationship and extending a protective tone to Markovich at the post's conclusion. The media buzz is short lived and Oxxxymiron continues his career by releasing a myriad of creative projects. The topic is not publicly broached again until March 2025, when Markovich restates her claims alongside other women who accuse Fyodorov of grooming and sexual assault.

In March 2025, in the midst of his monthslong hiatus from public life, after the cancellation of *Dolce Vita,* three women (Vera Markovich, Vika Kuchak, and Vika Mikhailova) accuse Fyodorov of sexual assault and grooming. Their stories are revealed on the new season of "Дочь Разбойника" ("Bandit's Daughter"), a podcast dedicated to women's rights; the season is titled "Творческий Метод" ("The Creative Method") and hosted by investigative journalist and

[296] The Flow.ru,"Oksimiron otreagiroval na post svoej byvshej devushki." [Oxxxymiron reacts to his ex-girlfriend's post], *The-Flow.ru,* November 5, 2021, https://the-flow.ru/news/oksimiron-post-o-byvshey.

[297] The Flow.ru,"Oksimiron otreagiroval na post svoej byvshej devushki."

[298] Instagram stories are features of one's page that are made to disappear. Posters are able to save their stories if they wish, but without action, they disappear after 24 hours.

self-proclaimed Oxxxymiron fan, Nastya Krasilnikova. Alongside shepherding the women through telling their stories, Krasilnikova interjects her changing perceptions about Oxxxymiron and the aftermath of her personal fandom considering the women's revelations. The podcast exposes that when personal accusations are levied against public figures, it is as if the veil has been lifted, exposing the paradox of a person who was always visible but simultaneously imperceivable and inaccessible.

In the first episode of "The Creative Method," Markovich tells Nastya Krasilnikova about her relationship with Fyodorov, from when he served as her guardian through their eventual break up as both manager and artist, and girlfriend and boyfriend. She also discusses the decisions to make the Instagram post and its aftermath. After her post was published on Instagram, Fyodorov reaches out to Markovich and asks to speak so they can resolve the situation. In her retelling of this conversation, Markovich describes how she regressed back into the fifteen-year-old version of herself, agreeing with Fyodorov who repeatedly reminded her that they didn't engage in any sexual activities until she was 16.[299] He decides, she says, that they need to make public statements because he is afraid he will be "cancelled." Moreover, he tells her that she should post her statement to her Instagram page while he will post a *story*, a function of the platform that is designed to disappear after 24 hours. His claim is that he needs to maintain a "conceptual Instagram page" having deleted all of his posts. [300] That he chooses the impermanence of "stories" to make his announcement so as not to disrupt the conceptual nature of his Instagram page is a clear sign of concern for his public image. Oxxxymiron's statement is

[299] Nastya Krasilnikova, "Tvorcheskii Metod 1: na repite" [Creative Method 1: on repeat], *Libo Libo,* podcast audio, March 3, 202, 32:36, https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

[300] Nastya Krasilnikova, "Tvorcheskii Metod 1: na repite" [Creative Method 1: on repeat], *Libo Libo,* podcast audio, March 3, 202, 32:36, https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

explanatory, apologetic, and almost protective of Markovich; he asks fans not to interact with her online out of spite. After years of avoiding public statements and commentary, particularly on his personal life, Fyodorov addresses Markovich's claims swiftly and directly, demonstrating to fans that he is indeed the changed man introduced in "Who Killed Mark?" It is this uncharacteristic decision that allows Fyodorov to maintain his public reputation. By defying expectations and speaking out about the allegations, he closes the issue and recreates the spectacle for his audience, briefly allowing himself to appear as a person with a life history before escaping back into his public persona.

The public's general reaction to Markovich's post is relayed to listeners through Nastya Krasilnikov's contemplation of her own fandom and its reckoning in the aftermath of the original and subsequent claims against Miron Fyodorov. When she reads Markovich's original post in 2021, Krasilnikova states that she chooses to perceive it as "историю неудачных отношении между двумя молодыми людьми" (a story of unsuccessful relations between two young people).[301] This response, and Krasilnikova's contemplation of fandom, are directly tied to persona. Not only does she discuss her interest in Oxxxymiron as a personality (личность), but she grapples with her relationship to his music in light of her investigative work. This reckoning is tied to the concept of prestige (Marshall, Moore, Barbour), wherein Oxxxymiron's online persona generates respect and admiration. For Krasilnikova, the true reckoning begins when she receives a message from Vika Kuchak who tells her that she and at least six others were sexually involved with Fyodorov as young teens; Kuchak was just thirteen when they began

[301] Non-Objective, " Sedmoy sezon podkasta 'doch razboinika' Tvorecheskii metod" [The seventh season of the "Bandit's Daughter" podcast "The Creative Method"].

corresponding. Krasilnikova interviews some of these women and releases their stories in March 2025 on a *The Creative Method* podcast.

4.4.1 On Personal and Impersonal Relationships with Miron Fyodorov a.k.a. Oxxxymiron

Beginning with its title, the podcast speaks to persona and artistry: The Creative Method. It infers that the information in each episode will illuminate some part of a creative process, in this case, how the women viewed their relationships and treatment with Fyodorov as being connected to his artistry. The podcast's cover art depicts a strong and fierce feminine figure attempting to burst out of a faceless, dark head meant to be Oxxxymiron's signature look of a shaved head (see Fig. 40).[302] Together, the title and cover art symbolize a rupture, a break in a creative process that they have somehow become a part of and now break free from.

Figure 40: The cover art for *The Creative Method* season on the *Bandit's Daughter* podcast.

Amidst the women telling their stories, and sharing personal evidence on the podcast's official site, Krasilnikova builds a narrative about the Oxxxymiron persona that relates to the notions of prestige and reputation as expressed by Marshall, Moore, and Barbour. Indeed, the episodes' titles all relate to both the women's and Krasilnikova's relationship with Fyodorov and his creative persona: "На репите" ("On repeat"), "'Мы спасаем гения'" ("We're saving a genius"), "Море" ("The Sea"), and "Формирование личности" ("The forming of a

[302] Ruslana Mirzaalieva, Oblozhka "Tvorcheskij Metod." Digital Image. "Sed'moj sezon podkasta 'doch' razbojnika' Tvorcheshkij Metod." [Cover art for "Creative Method." Seventh season of the podcast 'Daughter of the Bandit' Creative Method], 2025, https://method.libolibo.me/.

personality.”) These elements frame the podcast and contrast the severity of the women’s accusations with the creative livelihood of an artist, each living in a contentious time of cancel culture.

The title of the first episode “On Repeat” refers to Krasilnikova’s repeated listening to “Who Killed Mark?” after its release, a direct nod to the podcast’s secondary narrative about persona and fandom. Nevertheless, the episode is largely dedicated to Vera Markovich’s early history with Fyodorov, while he was serving as her guardian, and through certain points in their later, consensual relationship. She reveals intimate details about the grooming and sexual assault she experienced, alleging that he raped her at a house party after she turned 16. Years later, serving as his manager, she describes having access to his social media accounts and seeing evidence of his explicit conversations with other women. She tells Krasilnikova that she put her feelings aside and did not confront him because his career was more important at the time, stating: “Мои обиды второстепенны, мы спасаем гения” (My grievances are secondary, we’re saving a genius).[303] This podcast’s second episode is named after this soundbite (We’re saving a genius). Throughout the episode, she grapples with similar feelings related to both his artistry and the person she knew as an individual. For instance, she reveals that she was the inspiration for Oxxxymiron’s original version of “Fucked Up Girl” (2012) as well as an included reference in “Песенка Гремлина” (2013) (Gremlin’s Song), both of which left her distraught. Yet, she explains trying to reconcile the man who groomed her, assaulted her, and used her with the man who supported her through some of the most difficult times of her then young life. The episode is bookended with Krasilnikova’s explanation of when she became an Oxxxymiron fan to her

[303] Nastya Krasilnikova, “Tvorcheskii Metod 1: na repite” [Creative Method 1: on repeat], *Libo Libo,* podcast audio, March 3, 202, 32:36, https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

contemplation of his persona as she and her collaborator prepare to reach out to him for an interview for the podcast (he reads the message but never responds). These details set the tone for the remaining three episodes which delve deeper into Markovich's story alongside the experiences of Kuchak and Mikhailova, and back to Krasilnikova's reckoning with his persona. In turn, the podcast also adopts a stepladder approach similar to the one found in "Who Killed Mark?," weaving between the women's personal experience with Miron Fyodorov, their interest in his music and witness to his persona, and Krasilnikova's overarching contemplation of a fan's relationship with an artist.

Episode two "We're saving a genius" further recounts Markovich's story and forefronts Vika Kuchak's experience with Fyodorov. Kuchak alleges that she began corresponding with Fyodorov when she was 13, after he commented on one of her social media photos. Like Markovich, she claims that they corresponded for years as he groomed her, writing messages and calling one another on social media sites. When she turned 16, she attended her first Oxxxymiron concert and the two met face-to-face for the first time that night. She recalls imagining the situation beforehand as a cheerful first meeting of two Internet friends and says she felt excited at finally being able to meet the most important adult of her then young life.[304] Having described himself as a teacher figure and mentor, often writing to Kuchak about his existential and philosophical takes on life, it is this persona that she expects to meet. Instead of the friendly and supportive person with whom she corresponded overs the years, Kuchak is met with a cold and off-putting Fyodorov, who pressures her into having sex. In her recollection, as he was

[304] Nastya Krasilnikova, "Tvorcheskii metod 2: 'My spasaem genia'" [The Creative Method 2" We're saving a genius], *Libo Libo*, podcast audio, March 3, 2025, 49:25, https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

undressing her, he confirms her age by asking, "You're 16 right?"[305] This detail indicates his awareness of his grooming, something that adult Vika Kuchak accuses him of, alongside rape; both concepts that were unfamiliar to her at the age of 16.[306]

Episode three "The Sea" begins with Krasilnikova discussing her Oxxxymiron fandom. She describes how at the end of her final episode of the first season of "The Bandit's Daughter," also on the topic of violence against women, she thanks Oxxxymiron for making music that gives her strength. A commenter writes in to criticize her for thanking someone who groomed and raped a girl under his care in a podcast about sexual violence against women.[307]

Krasilnikova then continues a discussion with her collaborator from episode one; it's 2024 and they stand at the edge of the sea on a trip to Italy, waves crashing as they speak. She reflects on how she felt when she read the comment, saying that she was frustrated that everyone expects her to be perfect: "Но, окей, да я неидеальна, да я предпочла закрыть глаза но то что можно было закрывать глаза, потому что мне в тот момент было гораздо важнее зацепится за то что давало мне хоть какую-то силу" (Well okay I'm not perfect, yes I preferred to close my eyes to something that I could close my eyes to, because at that time it was more important to hold onto something that gave me strength).[308] Krasilnikova's admission that she would rather maintain the status quo of her life is similar to Markovich's avoidance of her own feelings in favor of helping Oxxxymiron with his career. The acute difference is that Markovich has an

---

[305] Nastya Krasilnikova, "Tvorcheskii metod 2: 'My spasaem genia'" [The Creative Method 2" We're saving a genius], *Libo Libo*, podcast audio, March 3, 2025, 49:25, https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

[306] Vika Kuchak goes on to file an official complaint against Miron Fyodorov in Russia' Следственный Комитет" (Investigative Committee) shortly after the podcast is released.

[307] Nastya Krasilnikova, "Tvorcheskii metod 3: More" [The Creative Method 3: The Sea], *Libo Libo*, podcast audio, March 3, 2025, 49:25, https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

[308] Nastya Krasilnikova, "Tvorcheskii metod 3: More" [The Creative Method 3: The Sea], *Libo Libo*, podcast audio, March 3, 2025, 49:25, https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

intimate relationship with Fyodorov, whereas Krasilnikova is simply a fan of his music, two markedly different experiences converging through the revelation of private information.

P. David Marhsall addresses the intimacy of celebrity in the digital age, alongside its power in his book *Celebrity and Power: Fame in Contemporary Culture.* In it, he centers his idea of the "new public intimacy" or the celebrity's role in contemporary society in shaping our concepts of public, private, and intimate, through an over exposure of information that is readily accessible on different platforms.[309] This intimacy lends to an affective power, one in which the celebrity persona is able to influence the public's thoughts, feelings, and emotions on a topic. In Krasilnikova's case, Fyodorov uses his affective power to quell the feelings that his fans may have had in reaction to Markovich's post. Since she has already developed an intimate relationship with his music, citing it as her strength and support in difficult times, Krasilnikova, an investigator on violence against woman, is overtaken by affective power and ignores the original accusations. This research aligns with Henry Jenkins' contention that fans are active, rather than passive participants of culture.[310] That is, fans' engagement with celebrities through new media allows them to contribute to cultural discourses. In this case, it is Oxxxymiron's affective power that shapes the narrative around his reputation and his fans' participation, through their overwhelming silence, that solidifies it.

As episode three continues, Krasilnikova discusses her resistance to making the Oxxxymiron allegations the topic of the podcast; she says that at the time (four months before the podcast premiers) she still has resistance that is difficult to overcome. She believes this

---

[309] P. David Marshall, *Celebrity and Power: Fame in Contemporary Culture*, University of Minnesota Press, 2014, 283.

[310] Henry Jenkins, *Convergence Culture: Where Old and New Media Collide*, New York: New York University Press, 2006.

resistance stems from the release of information, stating "как только мы сделаем эту информацию публичной…она станет реальнее, ещё больше чем она реальна сейчас для нас"("As soon as we make this information public…it will become more real, even more real that it is right now for us.")[311] Her personal trepidation is tied to her own affective power in swaying the public's opinion of Oxxxymiron and changing how his image is perceived. It is through the collective and mediatized nature of contemporary persona that Krasilnikova's project, about three women's experiences with Miron Fyodorov can shape and affect his reputation in the public sphere.

Episode three also introduces listeners to Vika Mikhailova, who began corresponding with Fyodorov on social media when she was 15 years old. She became familiar with his music through the forum HipHop.ru. After following Fyodorov on the Russian social media site ВКонтакте (VKontakte*)*, he commented on one of her photos in an explicit way and then sent her a pornographic video. As their correspondence continued, he invited her to his 2009 concert in Kyiv, asking her if she's ever had sex in a dressing room.[312] These messages scared Mikhailova who did not attend the concert or accept Fyodorov' future concert invitations. Like Markovich and Kuchak, Mikhailova describes not only the explicit nature of his messages, but the complimentary language he used in grooming her, highlighting her intelligence, as well as her looks. Mikhailova and Kuchak met on a fan forum, and it is through their relationship that his pattern of grooming and sexual assault was identified. According to Krasilnikova, she

[311] Nastya Krasilnikova, "Tvorcheskii metod 3: More" [The Creative Method 3: The Sea], *Libo Libo*, podcast audio, March 3, 2025, 49:25, https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

[312] Nastya Krasilnikova, "Tvorcheskii metod 3: More" [The Creative Method 3: The Sea], *Libo Libo*, podcast audio, March 3, 2025, 49:25, https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

reached out to other victims who refused to talk to her. The episode ends with a discussion of the complexity of trauma and its influence on decision making and the concept of revictimization.

The final episode of "The Creative Method," titled "Personality Formation" is a discussion about Oxxxymiron's popularity, beginning with Krasilnikova talking with music journalist Vladimir Zavyalov. Zavyalov describes hip hop as an aggressive genre and calls it "музыка мужского ресентимента" ("music of masculine resentment"); in the Russian context of an ultra-patriarchal society, he argues, this ethos is more pronounced than in other cultures.[313] When asked about Markovich's original Instagram post and why it did not cause a public reckoning, Zavyalov brings up an illuminating point: most of his fans are not self-reflexive people, they just listen to his music.[314] This argument moves away from a consideration of Oxxxymiron as a celebrity and focuses solely on his artistry. Krasilnikova, however, also reflects on her relationship with Oxxxymiron as a *public figure*: she values his public opposition to the status quo as well as the War in Ukraine. Their conversation lends to the notion of diverse micro publics, engendered through new media platforms. As Marshall, Moore, and Barbour explain, users are able to approach and cultivate audiences through different forums and platforms, resulting in divergent micro publics. For some fans, Markovich's post drove them away from engaging with Oxxxymiron, but for many others, it had no effect on their relationship as listeners. Ultimately, Krasilnikova has no answer about how the Oxxxymiron persona will function after the podcast's release. All she can do, she concludes, is do her job as a journalist: give a voice to those who need one.

---

[313] Nastya Krasilnikova, "Tvorcheskii metod 4: 'Formirovanie Lichnosti" [The Creative Method 4: Personality Formation], *Libo Libo,* podcast audio, March 3, 2025, 36:15, https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

[314] Nastya Krasilnikova, "Tvorcheskii metod 4: 'Formirovanie Lichnosti" [The Creative Method 4: Personality Formation], *Libo Libo,* podcast audio, March 3, 2025, 36:15, https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

Critical to Markovich, Kuchak, Mikhailova, and Krasilnikova's revelations is the role of silence. It is in the profound act of breaking silence that they individually and collectively discredit and challenge the Oxxxymiron persona. As much as celebrities try to curate their images, their success relies on the silence or silencing of others. Yan Fyodorov's admission of his son's intentionality around what information about him is publicly available supports this claim, as do the methods of silence and avoidance Fyodorov employed throughout his career. It is through silence, in its eclectic manifestations throughout his career, that Oxxxymiron has attempted to control his public narrative. Yet, as Krasilnikova declares at the end of the podcast, no one can control how information will impact others; she cannot control how the public perceives Oxxxymiron after the podcast is released, nor can he. It is in this way that Oxxxymiron's yet unbroken silence on the matter becomes not a sign of control, but one of loss.

Silence and speaking occupy significant roles in Oxxxymiron's self-presentation. As a battle rapper, industry rapper, and public figure, his entire relationship with the public is based on words. He has captivated audiences with his lyrical abilities and built a rapport as a successful, intellectual rapper. It is in his silence, however, and rejection social interaction with the public, that have sustained his career. Now, as he continues another period of retreat amidst serious personal allegations, it remains to be seen how this silence will affect public perception. In the era of Web 3.0, marked by the rise of personalized technological functions, both the silence and the noise are captured, proliferated, analyzed, and pondered. Even silence cannot escape the Internet, and whether he speaks about the allegations or not, neither can Oxxxymiron.

Conclusion: On Man's Digital Permanence

Мне бы
памятник при жизни
полагается по
чину.
Заложил бы
динамиту
ну-ка,

дрызнь!
–Владимир Маяковский,
"Юбилейное" (1924)

By rank
I'm due a monument
in my lifetime

I would plant it
with dynamite
come on now,

blow!
–Vladimir Mayakovsky,
"Jubilee" (1924)

Derived from the lexicon of antiquity, persona is the manifestation of the way we wish to be perceived; it is the social mask(s) we wear. In the twenty-first century, persona is foremostly mediatized, shaped by the changing landscape of technology and the world wide web. The Internet has engendered a context in which our digital actions, from the social media sites we join to the images we post and then delete, have become ceaseless points of analysis for our constructed personas. For the celebrity class, Webs 2.0 and 3.0 offer access to different micro-publics, allowing them to curate messages, images, and other posts based on a given platform and audience. And when a change is deemed necessary, a persona can be reworked with a few clicks of the mouse; social media pages cleared, Wikipedia pages amended, narratives changed.

The paradoxical relationship between the disappearance or removal of content has a unique role in Oxxxymiron's self-presentation; they are related to his use of silence and

throughout the process of self-presentation. From obfuscating when faced with taunts about Roma Zhigan, taking long breaks between albums, refusing interviews, wiping his Instagram page, cancelling a tour, and not responding to Nastya Krasilnikova's request for comment on her grooming and sexual assault investigation, his career is marked by silence in its divergent forms. Moreover, it is a seeming inaction, which can be interpreted as avoidance or deliberate non-response, that is a defining feature of the Oxxxymiron persona.

As "The Creative Method" demonstrates, everything built for a mediatized society, personas included, is bound to be confronted by the very media that allowed it to be. Celebrities have more agency than ordinary individuals in using silence and silencing to control their images, but that control does not extend to others' lived experience. In addition to the collective aspect of persona (Marshall, Moore, and Barbour) and its negotiation through digital social interaction, there are additional circumstances that can be consequential. Such is the case with the videos of now-defunct battle rap league Versus. In December 2023, after having hosted their videos on YouTube since 2013, the league's organizers abruptly hid all its videos from public view. The decision was made after the detention of seventeen-year-old rapper Islam "Recivid" Zakirov.[315] The Kyrgyz rapper was charged and later convicted of inciting ethnic hatred after making a comment in a rap battle about beating a pregnant Russian woman. Shortly after his charges were announced, several battle leagues, including Versus, hid their publicly available content on YouTube. Fear of legal repercussions overtakes the battle rap tenet of free speech (in its already modified form in the Russian sphere). In the context of persona, it is a reminder that self-presentation, whether of an individual or an entity, is strongly tied to our existence in the digital sphere.

[315] He goes by "Рецивид" in Russian, which can translate to "recidivist" or "relapsed person."

Versus' deletion from the Internet demonstrates the loss of a primary source of Oxxxymiron's persona: his battle performances, their accompanying comment sections, and their official view counts. Now, his viral videos, encapsulated on fan and media pages and the hard drive of at least one American doctoral student, are no longer tied to the ticker of an official @VersusBattleRu YouTube view counter. Their affiliation outside of Versus changes their prestige but paradoxically lends to it a mythic quality. Whereas Oxxxymiron's public identity was once tied to the millions of view counts that a rap battle generated, it is now tied to the notion that *there once was a view count.* It is this paradox, the teetering of online content and its lack, that defines persona in the age of digital permanence.

In the Russian context, celebrities face other challenges to self-presentation vis-à-vis Internet platforms. The continuing War in Ukraine has caused threats of blocking social media sites like Instagram, making users, celebrities and micro-publics alike reconsider or change both the manner and forum for self-presentation.[316] Though access to banned sites can still be possible with technological support, the precarity of online forums is ever present. Thus, threats alone can signify the devastating possibility of inaccessibility, altering one's relation to forces of self-presentation and social interaction in the digital age. This experience is complex both for the Russians who remain in Russia and navigate the changing digital landscape, and for those outside of it, whose connections to culture and collective are primarily through digital means.

As I consider the complexity of mediatization in the age of burgeoning artificial intelligence and a "customizable" Internet, I think about how we refer to media sites and similar spaces of digital social interaction not as dramaturgical stages, but *platforms*, foundations on

[316] BBC News, "War in Ukraine: Instagram Banned in Russia over "Calls to Violence," *BBC News,* March 11, 2022, https://www.bbc.com/news/technology-60709208.

which to build. It is these foundations that are constantly changing and being engineered to curate our online experiences as a result of our mouse clicks and the sites which our keyboards take us to. I am unsure what to make of Boym's contention about the realization of roles through individual performance in the theater-less platform-focused digital age except that we do far more mediatizing than *realizing* in the contemporary world. That is, we spend time self-presenting mediatized versions of our individual personas, rather than realizing specific roles in a cultural context. Perhaps the crux of our cultural mythology is the very notion that nothing can be realized in a hyper-individualized, mediatized context; we simply keep changing alongside the platforms on which we build.

Afterword: On the Researcher's Intention

Years ago, I attended a lunch with professors in my department and a visiting scholar when we got on the topic of researching living subjects. The visiting scholar, who met several of her subjects, argued that meeting and talking with them is a necessary practice for developing research; a professor in our department disagreed, suggesting that a meeting would set the researcher up for disappointment. His contention was that the subject will either attempt to disprove your research or betray the version you have created of them. At this point in my fledgling career as a graduate student, I agreed with the visiting scholar; now I agree with the departmental professor. After years of dissertation work, I am no longer convinced that an interview with Miron Fyodorov would have benefited this work in any way. His persona is not his own curation, but a phenomenon that is negotiated through digital means and social interaction. What question can he answer or talking point can he make that changes this fact?

When it was released, I listened to "The Creative Method" on walks throughout my neighborhood; my movement a manifestation of my uneasiness in engaging with such sensitive

material about the person whose artistry and persona I had spent years researching. The allegations made me feel conflicted about my role and responsibility as a researcher. Unlike Krasilnikova, I was not grappling with my fandom. On the contrary, I questioned how I could continue to listen to his music for the purpose of writing this dissertation. One of my first digital instincts is to block, delete, forget. What I had to come to terms with is a point antithetical to the one that Krasilnikova makes at the end of her podcast. Where she considered how someone from whose work she derived strength could display a pattern of harming girls and young women, I thought about my discomfort in choosing to spotlight the Oxxxymiron persona in my writing. My attempt, in this dissertation, is to lead readers through the complexity of this thought in introducing different iterations of the Oxxxymiron persona until they are confronted with the sexual assault and grooming allegations themselves. It is my belief that persona is meant to be experienced and negotiated. And when, like a monument, it is blown to bits, we must reconcile our own positions among the pieces.

Bibliography

Adindex. "'Syad' za tekst' Oxxxyimron provyol chtenie klassiki v podderzhku figurantov 'moskovskogo dela'" ["Get locked up for a text" Oxxxymiron led a reading of classics in support of figures from the "Moscow affairs"] " *Adindex.* September 19, 2019. https://adindex.ru/news/offtop/2019/09/19/275601.phtml

Alim, H. Samy, Jooyoung Lee, and Lauren Mason Carris. "'Short Fried-Rice-Eating Chinese MCs' and 'Good-Hair-Havin Uncle Tom Niggas': Performing Race and Ethnicity in Freestyle Rap Battles." *Journal of Linguistic Anthropology*, vol. 20, no. 1 (2010): 116–33. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1548-1395.2010.01052.x.

Aniskiewicz, Alena. "Cultural Remix: Polish Hip-Hop and the Sampling of Heritage." Thesis, 2019. http://deepblue.lib.umich.edu/handle/2027.42/151384.

Avilova, Elena Ravilevna. "Arhetip geroya v russkoy rok poezii" [The archetype of the hero in Russian rock poetry]. *Russian rock poetry: text and context.* No. 16 (2016). https://cyberleninka.ru/article/n/arhetip-geroya-v-russkoy-rok-poezii.

Balin, Denis. "Battl-Rep Umer i Vot Pochemu: 5 Faktov o Smerti Zhanra." [Battle-Rap Died and This is Why: 5 Facts about the Death of the Genre]. *5 T.,* August 7, 2021. https://www.5-tv.ru/tabloid/286452/battl-rep-umer-ivot-pocemu-5-faktov-osmerti-zanra-21-1/.

Barthes, Roland. *Mythologies*. Translated by Annette Lavers. Hill and Wang, 1972.

Belta. "Shkol'nyj skandal: starsheklassnitsa vydala rap za stikhi Mandel'stama i poluchila 'pyatyerku.'" [School scandal: upperclassman presents rap to the verses of Mandelstam and received an A+]. *Belta.* February 4, 2016. https://belta.by/kaleidoscope/view/shkolnyj-skandal-starsheklassnitsa-vydala-rep-za-stihi-mandelshtama-i-poluchila-pjaterku-180222-2016/.

BBC News. "War in Ukraine: Instagram Banned in Russia over "Calls to Violence." *BBC News.* March 11, 2022. https://www.bbc.com/news/technology-60709208.

BBC News Russian. "Khaski arestovan v Krasnodare, reperu dali 12 sutok." [Husky arrested in Krasnodar, the rapper given 12 day sentence]. *BBC News Russian.* November 22, 2018, https://www.bbc.com/russian/news-46305133.

BBC News Russian. "Reper Zhigan zaderzhan po podozreniyu v razboe." [Rapper Zhigan arrested as suspect in robbery]. *BBC News Russian.* December 12, 2013. https://www.bbc.com/russian/russia/2013/12/131212_russian_rapper_arrested.

Bliznets, Masha. “Oxxxymiron stal litsom Reebok Classic (vnezapno).” [Oxxxymiron became the face of Reebok Classic (unexpectedly)]. *GQ.* June 28, 2016. https://www.gq.ru/style/oxxxymiron-stal-licom-reebok-classic-vnezapno.

Boym, Svetlana. *Death in Quotation Marks: Cultural Myths of the Modern Poet*. Harvard University Press, 1991.

Britenkov, Andrei. “Oksford nichevo ne dal, krome neskol’kikh depressivnykh let: Oksimiron ot Peterburga do Britanii i obratno.” [Oxford didn’t give anything, other than several depressive years: Oxxxymiron from St. Petersburg to Britain and back]. *Saint-Petersburg.ru.* July 1, 2019. https://saint-petersburg.ru/m/culture/britenkov/371760/.

Bulvar Gordona. “‘Strashno. Bol’no. Nevynosimo grustno. I stydno. I v tom chisle za sebya.’ Rossijskij akter Kozlovskij vyskazalsya o vojne RF protiv Ukrainy.” [‘Frightening. Hurtful. Unbearably sad. And shameful. And for ourselves.’ Russian actor Koslovsky spoke out about the Russian Federation’s war against Ukraine]. *Bulvar Gordona.* February 27, 2022. https://gordonua.com/bulvar/news/strashno-bolno-nevynosimo-grustno-i-stydno-i-v-tom-chisle-za-sebya-rossiyskiy-akter-kozlovskiy-vyskazalsya-o-voyne-rf-protiv-ukrainy-1597449.html.

Bykov, Dmitry. “Nuzhno Li Poezii Vyhodit Na Stadiony, Kak Polveka Nazad?” [Should Poetry be Presented at Stadiums, like 50 Years Ago?]. *BykovFM.* September 21, 2023. https://bykovfm.ru/nuzhno-li-poezii-vyhodit-na-stadiony-kak-polveka-nazad-461af2.

Cinnsealach, Somhairle. “Russian Rap Battle Racks up 15M Views in 3 Days.” *Hip Hop DX.* August 16, 2017. https://hiphopdx.com/news/id.44401/title.russian-rap-battle-racks-up-15m-views-in-3-days#.

Davydova, Yana. “The Russian Rapper from the UK Suburbs Who Studied at Oxford.” *Dazed*, September 6, 2016. https://www.dazeddigital.com/music/article/32690/1/oxxxymiron-russian-rap-interview.

Derzhavin, Gavrila, “Bog” [God]. *Kultura.rf.* 1784. https://www.culture.ru/poems/23840/bog.

Dimitriadis, *Greg. Performing Identity/Performing Culture: Hip Hop as Text, Pedagogy, and Lived Practice.* Rev. Ed. Lang Publishing House, 2001.

Diveeva, Alina Albertovna. “Kontseptsy ‘Chelovek.’ ‘Vremya,’ I ‘Zhizn’ i Sposoby ih representatsii v russkoyazychnych rep tekstah.” [The concepts of ‘Persona,’ ‘Time,’ and ‘Life’ and Methods of their representation in Russsophone rap texts]. *Litera.* No. 5 (2021). https://cyberleninka.ru/article/n/kontsepty-chelovek-vremya-zhizn-i-sposoby-ih-reprezentatsii-v-russkoyazychnyh-rep-tekstah.

Dollard, John. “The Dozens: Dialect of Insult” *American Imago.* Vol. 1, no. 1 (1939): 3–25. JSTOR.

Dud, Yuri (@вДудь). "*MORGENSHTERN – Glavnyj Shoumen Rossii-2020 / Russian Entertainer #1.*" [*MORGENSHTERN – Main Russian Showman-2020 / Russian Entertainer #1].* November 3, 2020. 32:59-33:13. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AR6ovvs6Ihg.

Dud, Yuri (@вДудь). *"Restorator – Ob Oksimirone, Tsenzure I Bable." [Restaurateur – About Oxxxymiron, Censorship, and Money].* YouTube. March 7, 2017. 48:08.. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=baLHI-u8h5g.

Fiske, John. *Understanding Popular Culture*. Second edition. Routledge: 2010. 232. https://doi-org.proxy.lib.umich.edu/10.4324/9780203837177.

Freidin, Gregory. *A Coat of Many Colors: Osip Mandelstam and his Mythologies of Self Presentation. University of California Press, 1987.*

Frith, Simon. *Performing Rites: On the Value of Popular Music*. New York: 1998. 360.

Frolova, Daria. "Pol'zovateli obsuzhdayut sluhi o zabolevanii Oksimirona*." [Users discuss rumors of Oxxxymiron's illness]. *Popcake*. January 27, 2025. https://popcake.news/news/v-seti-obsuzhdayut-chto-u-repera-inoagenta-oksimirona-rak.

Fyodorov, Miron. *Gorgorod.* November 13, 2015. Spotify.

Fyodorov, Miron. *Krasota i Urodstvo [Beauty and Ugliness].* December 1, 2021. Spotify.

Fyodorov, Miron. *miXXXtape III: Smutnoe Vremya [miXXXtape III: The Time of Troubles].* November 12. 2021. Spotify.

Fyodorov, Miron. "Ya Znayu, Shto Ty Delal Proshlym Letom." [I Know What You Did Last Summer]. August 25, 2023. Spotify.

Fyodorov, Miron (@oxxxymironofficial)."Devochka pizdets." [Fucked up girl]. YouTube. October 31, 2019. 2:43. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-B6NDjtWlP4.

Fyodorov, Miron (@oxxxymironofficial). "Hop-Mechanika" [Hop-Mechanics]. YouTube. December 1, 2021. 0:26-0:41. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NLva43KAkic.

Fyodorov, Miron (@oxxxymironofficial). "Kto ubil Marka?" [Who killed Mark?]. YouTube. November 1, 2021. 10:31. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=q92DWs1MwRA.

Fyodorov, Miron. (@oxxxymironofficial). "Gde nas net." [Where we aren't]. YouTube. October 31, 2019. 4:25. https://youtu.be/ByEDNOcu7bg?feature=shared.

Fyodorov, Miron. (@oxxxymironofficial). "My vse umryom" [We're all gonna die]. YouTube. December 1, 2021. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tkqef33yRNA.

Fyodorov, Miron (@oxxxymironofficial). “Oida” YouTube. September 16, 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pYymRbfjKv8.

Fyodorov, Miron (@oxxxymironofficial). “Oxxxymiron o Date Vyhoda Vtorovo Al’boma. 2014.” [Oxxxymiron on the Date of the Release of his Second Album. 2014]. August 8, 2014. 01:11. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oLUaEMv076U.

Fyodorov, Miron (@oxxxymironofficial). "Oxxxymiron–RUSSIANS AGAINST WAR (ISTANBUL, TURKEY).” YouTube, March 11, 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ufRsgtd2fIA.

Fyodorov, Miron (oxxxymironofficial). *P.S.*. YouTube. August 25, 2019. 3:22-3:35, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1FYOURWJxyE.

Fyodorov, Miron (@oxxxymironofficial). “Vechnyj Zhid.” [The Wandering Jew]. YouTube. October 31, 2019. 2:33. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MiSfRHhWxKU.

Fyodorov, Miron (@oxxxymironofficial). “#syadzatekst” [#getlockedupforatext]. YouTube. September 19, 2019. 1:58:04. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yI_iI-0QFIE.

Fyodorov, Miron (@norimyxxxo)."Coping with extreme mood swings on a daily basis since ’04. Two decades in the shut up your inner demons business. A brand you can trust. Me.” Twitter. January 1, 2016, 9:09 AM. https://x.com/norimyxxxo/status/684738671631822848.

Fyodorov, Miron (@norimyxxxo). “Druz’ya! K Moemy Ogromnomy Sozhaleniyu, Tur DOLCE VITA Perenositsya Na 2026 God.” [Friends! To my great disappointment, the tour DOLCE VITA has been rescheduled to 2026]. Instagram. November 19, 2024. https://www.instagram.com/norimyxxxo/p/DCjgrKptXuy/.

Fyodorov, Miron (@norimyxxxo). “Mezh tem tur prodolzhaetsya. Bilety: http://oxxxytour.com.” [Meanwhile the tour continues. Tickets: http://oxxxytour.com]. X. November 17, 2017. https://x.com/norimyxxxo/status/931517294911639553.

Fyodorov, Miron (@norimyxxxo). “YA BUDU PET’ SVOYU MUZYKU: Basta, Oxxxymiron, Noize MC. Contsert solidarnosti. 26 noyabrya, Glavklub, Moskva.” [I WILL SING MY OWN MUSIC: Basta, Oxxxymiron, Noize MC. Concert of solidarity. November 26, Glavclub, Moscow]. X. November 24, 2018. https://x.com/norimyxxxo/status/1066372820794556417.

Fyodorov, Yan. Email message to the author. October 26, 2022.

Galanov, Viktor. “Morgenshtern – 12 (Klip 2022) 4K+.” [Morgenshtern - 12 (Clip 2022) 4K+]. YouTube. Copy. March 20, 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=j_QSDVqujhE, 2:43-2:57.

Genius. “Restorator.” https://genius.com/artists/Restorator.

Goffman, Erving. *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*. Doubleday, 1959.

Gorbachev, Alexander. "Oksimiron ob Oksforde, trave, ideologii, i problemah russkovo repa." [Oxxxymiron on Oxford, weed, ideology, and problems with Russian rap]. *Afisha Daily*. https://daily.afisha.ru/archive/volna/archive/rusrap_oxxxymiron/.

Grebenshchikov, Boris (@Bgrebenshikov_art). "Kartina nahoditsya v chastnoj kollektsii." [The painting is in a private collection]. Instagram. January 11, 2021. ://www.instagram.com/p/CJ6xVB2FB1z/?hl=en.

Harris, Travis. "Can It Be Bigger Than Hip Hop?: From Global Hip Hop Studies to Hip Hop." *Journal of Hip Hop Studies.* Vol. 6, Issue 2 (2019). https://doi.org/10.34718/27NK-BX98.

HashTrust Technologies Pvt. Ltd. "The Ultimate Comparison between Web 1.0, 2.0, and 3.0 , An In-Depth Analysis ." *Medium*, October 14, 2022. https://medium.com/@Hashtrust_Technologies/the-ultimate-comparison-between-web-1-0-2-0-and-3-0-an-in-depth-analysis-2c7c3f4885e8.

Hickey-Moody, Anna. "Eminem's Lyrical Personae: The Everyman, the Needy Man, the Hegemon." *Culture, Society and Masculinities.* Vol. 1, no. 2 (2009): 213–23. https://doi.org/10.3149/csm.0102.213.

Idov, Mikhail. "Otkrytie goda Oxxxymiron: 'Ya ne erudite, ya standartnyj intelligentishka." [Discovery of the year Oxxxymiron: 'I am not an erudite, but a standard intellectual]. GQ. October 11, 2012. https://www.gq.ru/heroes/otkrytie-goda-oxxxymiron-ya-ne-erudit-ya-standartnyj-intelligentishk.

I Ian . "1703, Bar, Pub, Saint Petersburg, Ligovskiy Avenue, 50П." *Yandex Maps.* Accessed August 6, 2025. https://yandex.com/maps/org/1703/1853235568/.

Isaac, Mardean. "The Rapper and the Foreign Agent." *News Line Magazine.* September 4, 2023. https://newlinesmag.com/review/the-rapper-and-the-foreign-agent/.

Jenkins, Henry. *Convergence Culture: Where Old and New Media Collide*. New York: New York University Press, 2006.

King Of The Dot Entertainment. "#WDVILA Official Flyer." Facebook. September 28, 2017. https://www.facebook.com/KOTDTV/posts/wdviila-official-flyerkotd-world-domination-7oxxxymiron-vs-dizasterday-1-will-be/10154896013616551/.

King of the Dot Entertainment. "*KOTD - #WDVIILA - Oxxxymiron vs Dizaster (Trailer) | #WDVII.*" YouTube. September 14, 2017. 01:40, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NxsU-JL-G9U.

King Of The Dot Entertainment."*Oxxxymiron (RU) vs Dizaster (USA) | #WDVII*." YouTube. October 17, 2017. 51:20. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ldK9qvRBkMI.

Kings College London "Professor Yan Fyodorov." King's People. https://www.kcl.ac.uk/people/yan-fyodorov.

Krasilnikova, Nastya. "Tvorcheskij Metod 1: na repite" [Creative Method 1: On Repeat]. *Libo Libo,* podcast audio, March 3, 2025. 32:36. https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

Krasilnikova, Nastya. "Tvorcheskij Metod 2: 'My spasaem geniya.'" [Creative Method 2: 'We're saving a genius']. *Libo Libo,* podcast audio, March 3, 2025. 49:25. https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

Krasilnikova, Nastya. "Tvorcheskij Metod 3: More." [Creative Method 3: The Sea]. *Libo Libo,* podcast audio, March 3, 2025. 29:31. https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

Krasilnikova, Nastya. "Tvorcheskij Metod 4: Formirovanie lichnosti." [Creative Method 4: The Formation of Personality]. *Libo Libo,* podcast audio, March 3, 2025. 36:15. https://pc.st/1540573120/e/.

Kukulin, Ilya. "Playing the Revolt: The Cultural Valorization of Russian rap and Covert Change in Russian Society of the 2010." *Russian Literature*. Vol. 118 (2020).79-105. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ruslit.2020.11.004.

Kusenko, S.G. "Funktsii rifmy v stikhe Mayakovskogo" *[The function of rhyme in the poetry of Mayakovsky]. Intellectual Potential of the 21st century: Stages of Knowledge.* Vol. 8 (2011). 44-47. https://cyberleninka.ru/article/n/funktsii-rifmy-v-stihe-mayakovskogo/viewer.

Lassan, Eleonora. "Rep-battly kak kulturny I lingvokylturny fenomen" *[Rap battles as a cultural and lingo-cultural phenomenon]. Communications Research*. No. 3 (2018). 129-141. https://cyberleninka.ru/article/n/rep-battly-kak-kulturnyy-i-lingvokulturnyy-fenomen.

Lassan, Eleonora. "Rep-battly kak spetsificheskiy zhanr sovremmenoy kultury" [Rap battles as a specific genre of contemporary culture]. *Speech Genres.* No. 4 (2018): 313-320. https://cyberleninka.ru/article/n/rep-battly-kak-spetsificheskiy-zhanr-sovremennoy-kultury.

Lee, Jooyoung. *Blowin' up: Rap Dreams in South Central*. The University of Chicago Press, 2016.

Lefever, Harry G. "'Playing the Dozens': A Mechanism for Social Control." *Phylon.* Vol. 42, no. 1 (1981): 73–85. https://doi.org/10.2307/274886.

Lenta.ru. "Kolichestvo Prosmotrov Battla Oksimirona I Gnojnovo Perevalilo Za 10 Millionov." [The Battle between Oxxxymiron and Gnojny has surpassed 10 million views]. *Lenta.ru.* accessed August 15. 2017. https://lenta.ru/news/2017/08/15/ten_million/.

Lyubovny, Vlad (@DJVlad). *Oxxxymiron on Russian Hip Hop, Battle Rap, Dizaster, Putin (Full Interview*). February 21, 2018. 55:43. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=HLx2boiXAY.

Madden, Sidney. "New Drake Lawsuit Claims His Label Pushed 'Not Like Us' Diss to Defame Him." *NPR*. January 15, 2025. https://www.npr.org/2025/01/15/g-s1-42924/drake-umg-defamation-lawsuit-not-like-us.

Marciniak, Aleksandra. Personal photo. October 13, 2023.

Marciniak, Aleksandra. Personal photo. August 13, 2025.

Markovich, Vera (@tricksterquest). https://the-flow.ru/news/oksimiron-post-o-byvshey (post deleted, author in possession of original copy).

Marshall, P. David. "Monitoring Persona: Mediatized Identity and the Edited Public Self." *Frame: Journal of Literary Studies*, 28 (2015): 115-133, https://www.frameliteraryjournal.com/wp-content/uploads/2015/10/Frame-28_1-Monitoring-Persona.pdf.

Marshall, P. David. "Persona Studies: Mapping the Proliferation of the Public Self." *Journalism* 15, no. 2 (2014): 153–70. https://doi.org/10.1177/1464884913488720.

Marshall, P. David, Christopher Moore, and Kim Barbour. *Persona Studies: An Introduction.* John Wiley & Sons, 2019.

MasterClass. "Grime Music Guide: Understanding British Grime Music - 2025." June 21, 2021. https://www.masterclass.com/articles/grime-music-guide.

Mayakovsky, Vladimir. "Yubileynoye" [Jubilee]. *IBiblioteka.ru. 1924,* https://ilibrary.ru/text/4571/p.1/index.html.

Meduza. "Sochuvstuyu vsem kto ne ponimaet pochemy eto nasilie" ["I feel sorry for those who don't understand why this is considered rape"]. *Meduza*, March 7, 2025. https://meduza.io/feature/2025/03/07/sochuvstvuyu-vsem-kto-ne-ponimaet-pochemu-eto-nasilie.

Meduza. "'Ya ne mogu razvlekat' vas, poka na Ukrainu padayut rossijskie rakety' Oksimiron otlozhil svoi pervye sol'nye kontserty za pyat' let iz-za vtorzheniya Rossii v Ukrainu. On nazval vojnu 'katastrofoj i prestupleniem.'" ['I cannot entertain you when Russian rockets fall on Ukraine,' Oxxxymiron postponed his first solo concerts in 5 years because of Russia's invasion of Ukraine. He called the war a 'catastrophe and crime']. *Meduza.* February 24, 2022. https://meduza.io/feature/2022/02/24/ya-ne-mogu-razvlekat-vas-poka-na-ukrainu-padayut-rossiyskie-rakety.

Minsker, Evan. "Russian Rapper Oxxxymiron Cancels Sold Out Moscow Concerts in Protest of Ukraine Invasion." *Pitchfork.* February 25, 2022. https://pitchfork.com/news/russian-rapper-oxxxymiron-cancels-sold-out-moscow-concerts-in-protest-of-ukraine-invasion/.

Mirzaalieva, Ruslana. Oblozhka "Tvorcheskij Metod." Digital Image. "Sed'moj sezon podkasta 'doch' razbojnika' Tvorcheshkij Metod." [Cover art for "Creative Method." Seventh

season of the podcast 'Daughter of the Bandit' Creative Method]. 2025. https://method.libolibo.me/.

Mondry, Henrietta. *Exemplary bodies: Constructing the Jew in Russian Culture, since the 1880s.* Academic Studies Press, 2010. https://doi-org.proxy.lib.umich.edu/10.2307/j.ctt21h4wgs.

Moskvich Mag. "Stanet Li Oxxxymiron Novym Vertinskim? Kak Kul'tura Delitsya Sejchas Na Russkuyu I Rossijskuyu." [Will Oxxxymiron become the next Vertinsky? How culture is now dividing itself as Russian and "Russian" (as in the State)]. *Moskvich Mag*. https://moskvichmag.ru/lyudi/stanet-li-oxxxymiron-novym-vertinskim-kak-kultura-delitsya-sejchas-na-russkuyu-i-rossijskuyu/.

Murodshoeva, Zhenya (@zhenyam_). "Noch' s Hellouina na Den' Vseh Svyatyh traditsionno shitaetsya edinstvennym dnyem v godu, kogda duhi umershih mogut vernutsya na zemlyu." [The night from Halloween to All Saints' Day is traditionally recognized as the only day of the year when souls of those who have passed can return to Earth]. X. November 1, 2021. 2:24 AM. https://mobile.twitter.com/ZMurodshoeva/status/1455058084360073216?cxt=HHwWgMC93crns7EoAAAA, (link no longer accessible, original copy in author's possession).

Navalny, Alexey. "Pro battl Oksimirona i Gnojnovo." [About the battle between Oxxxymiron and Gnojny]. Navalny Blog. August 14, 2017. https://navalny.com/p/5496/.

Nedashkovsky, Andrei. "Porchy i Oxxxymiron: 'Bol'she, Chem Sem'ya.' Chast' 1." [Porchy and Oxxxymiron: 'More than Family.' Part 1]. *TheFlow.ru.* April 1, 2016. https://the-flow.ru/features/porchy-oxxymiron-2016-part-1.

Newsru. "Battl reperov Oxxxymiron i Gnojnovo stal nastoyashim sobytiem ne tol'ko dlya sotssetej, no i dlya traditsionnyh SMI." [The battle between rappers Oxxxymiron and Gnojny became a real event not only on social media, but also in traditional mass media]. *NEWSru.com*. August 15, 2017. https://www.newsru.com/russia/15aug2017/recordbattle.html.

Nikitin, Andrei. "Zhigan: 'Davajte Zhit' Druzhno.'" [Zhigan: 'Let's Live Amicably']. *Rap. ru.* December 14, 2011. https://www.rap.ru/reading/188.

Nikitina, Olga. "Dominanty obraza rok geroya v russkoy rok kulture" [Predominant depictions of the rock star in Russian rock culture]. *Russian rock poetry: text and context.* No 8 (2005). https://cyberleninka.ru/article/n/dominanty-obraza-rok-geroya-v-russkoy-rok-kulture.

Non-Objective. "Sed'moj sezon podkasta 'doch' razbojnika' Tvorcheshkij Metod." [Seventh season of the podcast 'Daughter of the Bandit' Creative Method]. 2025. https://method.libolibo.me/.

Obozrevatel. "'Samyj ser'yeznyj batl!' Oksimiron vzbudorazhil set' rech'yu o bor'be s bespredelom v RF." ['The most serious battle!' Oxxxymiron stirred up the site with his

speech on the fight with lawlessness in the Russian Federation]. *Obozrevatel.* September 20, 2019. https://news.obozrevatel.com/show/people/samyij-sereznyij-batl-oksimiron-vzbudorazhil-set-rechyu-o-borbe-s-bespredelom-v-rf.htm.

Oxford. "History." https://www.ox.ac.uk/about/organisation/history.

Pushkin, Alexander."Ya pamiatnik vozdvig sebye ne rukotvornyi" [I erected a monument to myself not built by hand]. 1836. https://www.culture.ru/poems/5577/ya-pamyatnik-sebe-vozdvig-nerukotvornyi.

Rusrapuk. "Oxxxymiron – Ya Hejter." [Oxxxymiron – I'm a Hater]. YouTube. August 22, 2008. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=t5x3Ke21hUA.

Radio Liberty. "'Syad' za tekst': na kanale Oxxxymiron vynesli 'prigovory' klassikam literatury." ['Get locked up for a text:' Sentences are rendered for classic literature on Oxxxymiron's channel]. *Radio Liberty.* September 19, 2019. https://www.svoboda.org/a/30173073.html.

Rap.ru. "'Apgrejd Budet, Narniya Poka Podozhyet:' Oxxxymiron Prokommentiroval Battl s Gnojnym." ['An upgrade is coming, meanwhile Narnia is waiting:' Oxxxymiron commented on the battle with Gnojny]. *Rap.ru*. August 14, 2017. https://www.rap.ru/news/9111.

Rap.ru. "OXXXY Anonsiroval Tur." [OXXXY Announces Tour]. *Rap.ru.* accessed August 25, 2023. https://www.rap.ru/news/16259.

RBK. "V SMI opublikovan spisok 'nezhelatel'nyh' v Rossii muzykantov." [In mass media, Russia published a list of 'undesirable' musicians]. *RBK.* July 8, 2022. https://www.rbc.ru/spb_sz/08/07/2022/62c811f19a7947321a049390.

Redkin, Nikolai. "V novom klipe Oksimiron desyat' minut chitaet o svoyem konflikte s Romoj Zhiganom." [In a new clip, Oxxxymiron reads about his feud with Roma Zhigan for ten minutes]. *Meduza*. November 1, 2021. https://meduza.io/feature/2021/11/01/v-novom-klipe-oksimiron-desyat-minut-chitaet-o-svoem-konflikte-s-romoy-zhiganom.

Sandalov, Felix. "Oksimiron beseduet s samim soboj v proshlom." [Oxxxymiron talks to himself about his past]. *Afisha Daily*. December 23, 2015. https://daily.afisha.ru/music/13-bez-prava-na-zabvenie/.

Sandler, Stephanie. *Commemorating Pushkin: Russia's Myth of a National Poet.* Stanford University Press, 2004.

SarminSKY Turbine. "Ya Budu Pet' Moyu Muzyku." [I will perform my music]. YouTube. November 25, 2018. 00:31. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jccSXrOkuWs.

Shumway, David R. et al., *Rock Star: The Making of Musical Icons from Elvis to Springsteen*. Johns Hopkins University Press, 2014.

Stas Pro, dir. "Oksimiron Izvinyaetsya. Roma Zhigan. Shok. (Oxxxymiron Izvinyaetsya\schokk Na Kolenyah) Original." [Oxxxymiron apologizes. Roma Zhigan. Shock. (Oxxxymiron apologizes\schokk is on his knees) Original]. YouTube. August 7, 2019. 04:21. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DYWCKP75Hgc.

Stites, Richard. *Russian Popular Culture: Entertainment and Society Since 1900*. Georgetown University Press: 1992.

Strukov, Vlad. "The (im)personal Connection." In *Digital Russia: The Language, Culture and Politics of New Media Communication*, edited by Michael S. Gorham, Ingunn Lunde, and Martin Paulsen. Routledge, 2014. 11-33.

Taylor, Charles. "Modern Social Imaginaries." Public Culture 14, no. 1 (2002): 91–124. https://doi.org/10.1215/08992363-14-1-91.

Taylor, Jim. "Oksimiron: 'Molodyh vse slozhnee zastavlyat' nenavidet.'" [Oxxxymiron: 'It's becoming harder to get the youth to hate']. *BBC News Russian.* February 12, 2018. https://www.bbc.com/russian/features-43023140.

Telekanal Dozhd. "'Svobodu Politzaklyuchennym, Eto Glavnoe!' — Kak Oxxxymiron Vstrechal Svoj 36-j Den' Rozhdeniya Na Mitinge Za Svobodu Alekseya Naval'novo v 2021 Godu." ['Freedom to the Political Prisoner, that is the main thing!' — How Oxxxymiron celebrated his 36th birthday at a rally for Aleksei Navalny's release in 2021]. *Telekanal Dozhd.,'* Facebook. https://www.facebook.com/reel/1178301710631032.

The Flow.ru. "20 rep alb'omov 2010-h. Oxxxymiron 'Gorgorod'" [The 20 rap albums of the 2010s. Oxxxymiron 'Gorgorod." *The-Flow.ru.* March 6, 2017. https://the-flow.ru/top20/oxxxymiron-gorgorod.

The Flow.ru. "Bannery Oksimirona 'Kogda Al'bom razmestil SberZvuk " [SberZvuk posted Oxxxymiron's 'When's the album?' banners]. November 1, 2021. https://the-flow.ru/news/oksimiron-sberzvuk.

The Flow.ru. "Battl Oxxxymiron i Johnyboy Za Sutki Nabral Million Prosmotrov / Novosti." [Battle between Oxxxymiron and Johnyboy gets over one million views in 24 hours / news]. *The Flow.ru*. April 14, 2015. https://the-flow.ru/news/versus-battle-oxxxymiron-johnyboy-nifiga-sebe.

The Flow.ru. "Foto Dnya: Oksimiron zabil tatu 'Imperium' na pal'tsah." [Photo of the Day: Oxxxymiron tattoos 'Imperium' on his knuckles]. *The Flow.* September 20, 2022. https://the-flow.ru/foto/foto-dnya-oksimiron-imperium.

The Flow.ru. “Oksimiron otreagiroval na post svoej byvshej devushki.” [Oxxxymiron reacts to his ex-girlfriend’s post]. *The-Flow.ru.* November 5, 2021. https://the-flow.ru/news/oksimiron-post-o-byvshey.

The-Flow.ru. “Razberaem ‘Krasotu i Urodstvo’ Oksimirona” [We’re analyzing Oxxxymiron’s “Beauty and Ugliness”]. *The Flow.ru*. December 3, 2021. https://the-flow.ru/features/razbor-krasotu-urodstvo-oxxxymiron.

The Flow.ru. “V Moskve na Novom Arbate poyavilsya ‘Kogda al’bom?’” [A banner for ‘When is the Album?’ appeared on New Arbat Street in Moscow]. *The Flow.ru.* October 29, 2021. https://the-flow.ru/news/kogda-albom-banner.

Toyoda, Sonoko." Persona." International Association of Analytical Psychology. https://iaap.org/jung-analytical-psychology/short-articles-on-analytical-psychology/persona-2/.

Tsyptsyna, Iana. “More than punch lines and rhymes: Dizaster v Oxxxymiron.” *The Oxford Student*. November 11, 2017. https://www.oxfordstudent.com/2017/11/11/punch-lines-rhymes-dizaster-v-oxxxymiron/.

TheWriterSam. “Is the World’s Biggest Battle Rapper Now Oxxxymiron of Russia? *The Source.* February 11, 2018. https://thesource.com/2018/02/11/is-the-worlds-biggest-battle-rapper-now-oxxxymiron-of-russia/.

VerseTracker. “Dizaster | Battle Rapper Profile.” Accessed August 1, 2025. https://versetracker.com/rapper/dizaster.

VersusBattleRu. “Versus #1 (sezon III): Oxxxymiron VS Johnyboy.” [Versus #1 (season III): Oxxxymiron VS Johnyboy]. YouTube. April 12, 2015. 00:11-00:17. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MVouMFKmaeI, (page no longer available; copy of original in author's possession).

VersusBattleRu. “Versus #3 (sezon I): Oxxxymiron VS Krip-a-Krip.” [Versus #3 (season I): Oxxxymiron VS Krip-a-Krip]. YouTube. September 14, 2013. 00:07-00:09. (page no longer available; copy of original in author's possession).

VersusBattleRu. “Versus #5 (sezon III): Oxxxymiron VS ST.” [Versus #5 (season III): Oxxxymiron VS ST]. YouTube. June 19, 2016,. 01:17-01:29. (page no longer available; copy of original in author's possession).

VersusBattleRu. “Versus Main Event #1 (sezon 2): Oxxxymiron VS Dunya.” [Versus Main Event #1 (season 2): Oxxxymiron VS Dunya]. YouTube. April 15, 2014. 40:06. (page no longer available; copy of original in author's possession).

VersusBattleRu. “Versus X #SlovoSPB: Oxxxymiron VS Slava KPSS (Gnojny).” YouTube. August 13, 2017. 1:04:16. https://www.YouTube.com/watch?v=v4rvTMBCJD0. (page no longer available; copy of original in author's possession).

Wald, Elijah. *The Dozens: A History of Rap's Mama*. Oxford University Press, 2012.

Walker, Shaun. "The man who was raised in Slough and raps in Russian." *The Independent.* November 17, 2012. https://www.independent.co.uk/news/world/europe/the-man-who-was-raised-in-slough-and-raps-in-russia-8324127.html.

Williams, Matt. "Meet the Man Behind Drake's Favorite Battle Rap League, King of the Dot." Accessed August 1, 2025. https://www.vice.com/en/article/king-of-the-dot-organik-interview-kotd-ovo/.

Yunusov, Timur (@timatiofficial). "Menya proklinayut, zhelayut smerti mne lichno, moej sem'e, rodnym i blizkim." [They curse me, wish for my death, and that of my family and loved ones]. Instagram. March 4, 2022. (Post deleted but author is in possession of an original copy).

Zabalyev, Yaroslav. "'Kak Mayakovskij:' Oskimiron spel pered revolyutsiej." ['Like Mayakovsky:' Oxxxymiron performed before a revolution]. *Gazeta.ru*. November 7, 2017. https://www.gazeta.ru/culture/2017/11/06/a_10973264.shtml.

Zaitsev, Vladislav Alexeivich. "Motiv 'pamiatnika' v russkoi poezii ot Lomonosova i Pushkina do Brodskogo" [The Monument Motif in Russian Poetry from Lomonosov and Pushkin to Brodsky]. Vestnik Moskovskogo Universiteta. Filologia. Seria 9, 1(1998). 7-22.

Zavyalov, Vladimir. "Pochemu 'Gorgorod' Oksimirona Ostalsya v 2015 Godu." [Why Oxxxymiron's 'Gorgorod' stayed in 2015]. *Afisha Daily.* November 10, 2020. https://daily.afisha.ru/music/17719-pochemu-gorgorod-oksimirona-ostalsya-v-2015-godu/.